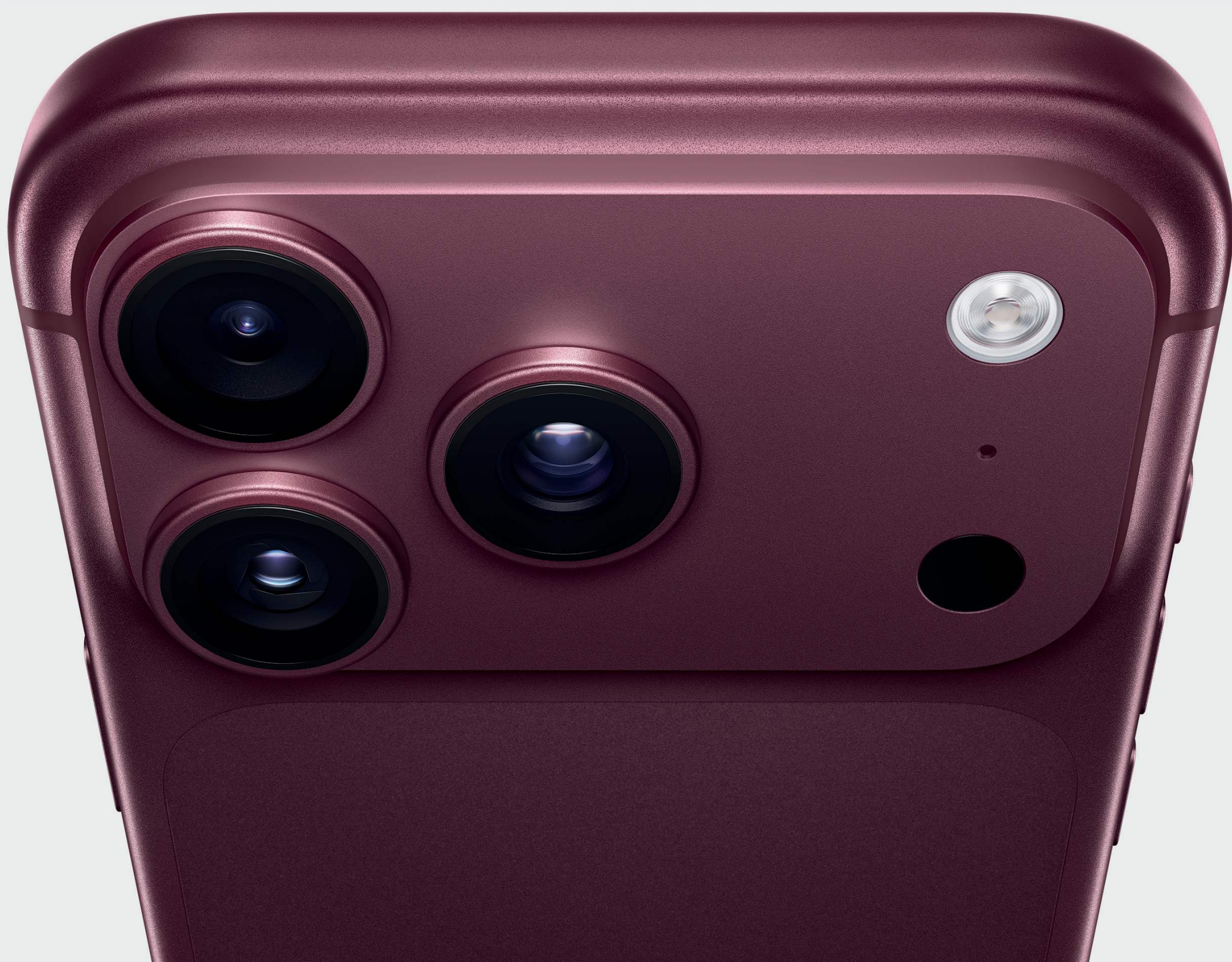




► India Faces Challenge in Replacing Russian Oil as US House Passes Tariff Bill ► Tata Sons Board Clears Chandra's Reappointment; Noel Calls It Illegal: P 1

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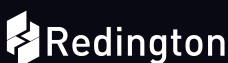
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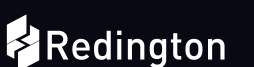
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India's Chip Gains Strengthen Global Supply Chains: PM

India's success in a critical sector such as semiconductors strengthens the entire world's supply chain, said PM Narendra Modi, who turned 76 on Thursday. India is taking every step to become a preferred manufacturing destination for the chip industry, he said at the inauguration of 5th Semicon India summit. ►► 16

PUREPOLITICS

SC Seeks Report on Unnatural Deaths at Manipur Relief Camps

The Supreme Court on Thursday directed the chief secretary of Manipur to file a detailed affidavit on deaths, particularly unnatural ones, reported among internally displaced people staying in relief camps in the violence-hit state. It questioned the steps taken by state authorities to investigate such cases. Raghav Ohri reports. ►► 3

■ EC Bars TMC Factions From Using Party Name, Symbol ►► 3

Retailers Urge Finmin to Scrap Proposed MDR

Retailers across the country are mounting a strong push-back against the MDR on UPI transactions above ₹2,000, with industry bodies petitioning the finance ministry to scrap the fee, saying it will erode their net margins. Writankar Mukherjee reports. ►► 4

MORE REPORTS ►► 4, 8, 13, 16

Advent to Buy 25% in Yatharth for ₹3,150 cr

BRANDS: CREATING DESIRE ►► 4

JSW ONE PLANS TO SOON FILE PAPERS FOR ₹3KCR IPO

►► PAGE 15

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MARKETS: BEATING VOLATILITY ►► 13

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ALL EYES ON AGM AFTER A STORMY BOARD MEET

ALL-OUT WAR AT TATA

Majority shareholder Tata Trusts terms Tata Sons chairman Chandrasekaran's reappointment illegal; Noel moots structural alternatives to keep holdco private



Kala Vijayraghavan & Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: A pitched battle for control broke out between the holding company of India's largest business conglomerate and the chairman of its majority shareholder following a stormy board meeting on Thursday, with the latter publicly terming key majority decisions taken by the former's board "illegal."

The public battle broke out after the board of Tata Sons, the holdco of the \$125-billion salt-to-semiconductors business group, reappointed by a majority, 4-1 decision, incumbent executive chairman N Chandrasekaran for a five-year term.

The decision was opposed by Noel Tata, chairman of Tata Trusts, the umbrella organisation of a clutch of charitable trusts that own the majority of shares in Tata Sons. He cast the sole vote opposing the resolution.

The meeting took place in the backdrop of a decision over the weekend by RBI, which rejected Tata Sons' request to stay private and unlisted and clarified its norms for shadow banks of a certain size, which are required to be publicly held, would be applicable to it. Shortly after the meeting, Tata Sons said in a statement that its board had resolved by a majority decision to reappoint Chandra as executive chairman for five years at the end of his current term.

Question of Veto Power ►► 3



Illustration: ZAHID

Plot Thickens

AUG 12, 2026 Chandra says he won't seek reappointment after his term as Tata Sons chairman ends

AUG 13 Tata Trusts accepts his decision; succession process kicks off

SEPT 3 NRC asks veteran leader to stay; recommends his reappointment

BY DEC 31 Chandra to face AGM test, needs shareholder nod to remain director

SEPT 17 Tata Sons board clears Chandra's reappointment for five years

Noel Tata votes against decision; Trusts contests move

Trust Deficit: A Divided (Bombay) House

Contrasting votes by Noel, Srinivasan show all trustees not on same page on Tata Sons listing, Chandra's extension

Kala Vijayraghavan & Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: A sharp divide between the two Tata Trusts nominees on the Tata Sons board has emerged over the holding company's most consequential decisions on Thursday — its listing and the continuation of N Chandrasekaran as chairman.

Noel Tata and fellow Tata Trusts nominee Venu Srinivasan took opposing positions on both issues, forcing

the board to rely on casting votes to resolve them, people familiar with the proceedings said. On the listing proposal, Noel Tata voted against proceeding while Srinivasan backed it. With

the two votes cancelling each other out, Chandrasekaran, as chairman of Tata Sons, exercised his casting vote, clearing the proposal.

The same split surfaced over Chandrasekaran's reappointment for another five years. Noel voted against him staying on, while Srinivasan backed it. The matter again went to a casting vote, with director Harish Manwani voting in favour of Chandrasekaran's reappointment, the people said.

The divisions are notable because the Tata Trusts collectively own about 66% of Tata Sons and their nominees represent the majority shareholder on the board.

No Collective View ►► 3

AFTER TATA SONS BOARD DECISION

Tata, SP Group Stocks Zoom

Shares of Tata Group companies rose on Thursday after Tata Sons board approved another 5-year term for N Chandrasekaran as executive chairman. Shares of SP Group firms also gained. ►► 13

INDUSTRY WEIGHS TARIFF THREAT

Tough to Replace Russian Oil Amid Supply Crunch

US bill clears way for up to 100% levy on India, China & other buyers

Sanjeev Choudhary

New Delhi: Replacing Russian crude, which has accounted for 47% of India's imports since the Iran war began, will be difficult for local refiners in the current market, with many key suppliers already cut off, industry executives said in the light of recent legislation passed by the US Congress. The legislation empowers President Donald Trump to impose tariffs of up to 100% on India, China and other buyers of Russian oil.

This doesn't necessarily mean Trump will immediately impose the penalties. US ambassador to India Sergio Gor had said on August 22 at The Economic Times World Leaders Forum that the legislation wasn't being pushed by Trump.

"The bill is being pushed by the Congress in a very bipartisan way. This is not something that you have seen the White House advocate for," Gor said. "And, I think, that's important to understand as people here say, you know, President Trump is pushing this. You won't find a clip of (him) pushing it."

Stark Choice ►► 3

Slippery Slope

Prices will soar if India, others scramble for alternatives; Brent currently around \$105/bbl

Russia, Saudi & UAE met 2/3rd of India's crude needs in March-Aug

India stuck to Moscow purchase after the US levied 25% tariff last year

Russian oil imports rose to 1.8 mb/d in Nov, fell to 1 mb/d by Feb on lifting of duty

NEW DELHI REACTS

'Impact on US Ties Likely'

India has indicated that a Trump nod to 'Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act' is likely to affect bilateral ties. Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury reports. ►► 2



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MILITARY CONTRACTS ANNOUNCED AFTER COMPANY REPRESENTATIVES' MEETING WITH PAKISTANI ARMY CHIEF GEN ASIM MUNIR AT RAWALPINDI

New Drone Co, With Trump Family Links, Gets Pak Order

Same company has bagged contract to protect West Asia oil infra hit by Iran war

Manu Pubby

New Delhi: A newly minted US drone company, with close links to the sons of President Donald Trump, has announced contracts with the Pakistani military after its representatives met Pakistani Army Chief Gen Asim Munir at Rawalpindi on Wednesday. Last month, the same company announced a \$22.3 million deal with an undisclosed customer in West Asia for equipment to protect oil and gas infrastructure from drone attacks. Several companies in West Asia have suffe-

red significant damage to their facilities after Trump's war on Iran. While the details of the deal have not been announced, a memorandum of agreement has been signed between Delaware manufacturer Powerus and the Pakistani Army, which includes sale of unmanned systems and potentially joint manufacturing in Pakistan as well, news agency Reuters has reported. Trump has publicly expressed his fondness for Munir and his family-backed companies are already working with the Pakistani government on crypto currency. This January, the Pakistani government had signed a deal with SC Financial Technologies, an affiliate of Trump family-backed World Liberty Financial, to use crypto for cross-border payments. The high-profile deal too was signed in the presence of Munir. The drone deal with Powerus does not specify the technologies likely

Knowing Powerus Corporation

Was incorporated in Delaware in October 2025, nine months into Trump's second presidency

Showed no revenue and a net loss of \$0.7 m as of December 31, 2025

American Ventures, an investment vehicle in which Donald Trump Junior and Eric Trump have stakes, set to hold a 9.9% share in Powerus Corporation

2026: POWERUS' DEALS

- MARCH** Company announces a merger agreement with Aureus Greenway, which owns two golf courses in Florida
- Raises over **\$9 m** through a group of investors, including Unusual Machines, which counts Trump Junior as a shareholder
- AUGUST 3** Powerus subsidiary, Tandem Defense, announces contract with US Air Force for aerial denial drones, with total financial ceiling of **\$90 m**

AUGUST 12 Announces **\$2.5 m** first personal view drone purchase for a US Department of War programme

AUGUST 20 Declares **\$22.3 m** contract in West Asia for protection of oil and gas infra

Will supply anti-drone systems to undisclosed customer

SEPTEMBER 16 Signs MoU with Pak Army that includes an initial order for drones

Value, details not disclosed



to be shared or the exact equipment sold, but the US company specialises in manufacturing heavy lift unmanned aerial systems. Such drones can be used for a variety of missions, from logistics support for troops to a lethal weapons payload. Pakistan has in recent years heavily leaned on China and Turkey for its armed forces requirements. For drones, in particular, Turkey has been a major contributor and several unmanned systems supplied were used by Pakistan against India last year during Operation Sindoor. Pakistan also uses armed drones from Turkey and China. Powerus is a relatively unknown drone company that is trying to ride on the new tech wave and made its entry with small contracts with the US Air Force and Department of Defence in the last few months. The company is currently being merged with an entity that opera-

CRYPTO CURRENCY DEAL



Trump has publicly expressed his fondness for Munir, and his family-backed cos are working with Pak govt on crypto currency

tes two golf courses in Florida. Company records show that Donald Trump Junior and Eric Trump are 'notable investors' in the company through their American Venture Partners vehicle. In a statement to Reuters, the company's representatives claimed that the Trump family has no operational control or involvement.

'IF WHITE HOUSE GIVES GREEN SIGNAL'

Ties may be Impacted: India to US on 'Sanctioning Russia & Iran Act'

Govt to work closely with Indian trade and industry bodies to deal with implications: MEA

Dipanjn Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: The Indian government on Thursday stated that it had discussed with the USA the potential implications of the 'Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act' on bilateral ties and on international energy markets, indicating that bilateral relations may be adversely impacted if the Act is given a green signal by the White House.

"This issue has been discussed at high levels in recent months with various US interlocutors. Its potential implications for not just the bilateral relationship but also the international energy market have been very clearly articulated by the Indian side," the Ministry of External Affairs informed through a statement hours after the passage of the Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act in the US Congress.

The Indian government has noted the passage of the Act in the US Congress, according to the MEA statement. "We are monitoring further developments on this matter. As stated on several earlier occasions, India remains firmly committed to ensuring energy security for its 1.4 billion people. It will continue to do so through diversified sourcing and on the basis of evolving market dynamics." The statement noted that the government will not compromise on energy security.

The Indian government has also made clear its determination to take all necessary measures to protect its trade and economic interests and the government will work closely with Indian trade and industry bodies to deal with the implications of these developments, the statement said amid threat of tariffs and in the backdrop of the trade pact that is being negotiated with the USA.

The Lindsay O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026, passed by the US Senate last month, was approved by the House in a 262-159 vote on Wednesday.

The Act authorises President Donald Trump to impose stiff tariffs of up to 100% on countries, including India and China, to reduce their dependence on Russian oil and gas, and extend sanctions on Iran.

The Act has been sent to Trump to sign into law.

In a rather arrogant statement, US Senator Richard Blumenthal on Wednesday told India to "clean up your act" after Congress passed the Act. "To China and India: You better clean up your act. Buy your oil and gas somewhere else. Appeasement is not a strategy," said Blumenthal. Sources told ET that any absence of Russia from the international oil market at a time when Iran is absent from the market and sourcing from West Asia is a challenge that will play havoc with global oil prices.

Last year, Trump imposed 25% tariffs on India for purchasing Russian oil, but later withdrew it as trade deal negotiations with India progressed.

US DOUBLE STANDARDS UNDER TRUMP ADMINISTRATION



US continues to import uranium, fertilisers and other products from Russia. In 2025, the goods trade between the US and Russia was around \$4.6 billion



A worker at a polling booth ahead of parliamentary elections in Podolsk, located in Russia's Moscow region, on Thursday - REUTERS

OPPN PARTY TAKES A SWIPE AT MODI GOVT

Appeasement has Never Paid, Will Never Pay: Cong

Party maintains MDR on UPI transactions has been introduced under US pressure to benefit card cos

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Congress on Thursday took a swipe at the Modi government, saying "appeasement has never paid and will never pay" after the US House of Representatives passed a bill that would authorise President Donald Trump to impose steep tariffs on Russia's trading partners in oil and gas.

The Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026, passed by the US Senate last month, was approved by the House of Representatives in a 262-159 vote on Wednesday and will now go to Trump to be signed into law.

Reacting to the passage, Congress general secretary in charge of communications, Jai Ram Ramesh, stated on X, "Appeasement has never paid and will never pay."

Congress had attacked the Centre on Tuesday for introducing the merchant discount rate (MDR) on UPI transactions and said this had been done under US pressure to benefit card companies.

The bill seeks to impose sanctions not only on Russia's leadership and energy sector, but also on the "shadow fleet" of vessels that enable Moscow to evade sanctions on oil deliveries. It also seeks to authorise Trump to impose stiff tariffs on China, India and other countries to reduce their dependence on Russian oil and gas, as well as additional sanctions on Iran.



Besides 203 Republicans, 58 Democrats and an Independent voted in favour of the legislation

Besides 203 Republicans, 58 Democrats and an Independent voted in favour of the legislation. Seven Republicans and 152 Democrats opposed it. Democratic opposition largely centred around the tariff authorities provided to Trump. The bill is named after Senator Lindsey Graham, the South Carolina Republican who died in July after spending more than a year building support for it.

India: Won't Compromise on Energy Security

This issue has been discussed at high levels in recent months with various US interlocutors. Its potential implications for not just the bilateral relationship but also the international energy market have been very clearly articulated by the Indian side



India remains firmly committed to ensuring energy security for its 1.4 billion people. It will continue to do so through diversified sourcing and on the basis of evolving market dynamics: MEA

To China and India: You better clean up your act. Buy your oil and gas somewhere else. Appeasement is not a strategy

RICHARD BLUMENTHAL US Senator



HITTING OUT China Rejects 'US Long-Arm Jurisdiction'

BEIJING: China on Thursday rejected the US "long-arm jurisdiction" to impose tariffs on purchases of Russian oil and gas, saying its normal trade and economic cooperation with other countries should not be subject to interference or coercion by third parties.

Chinese foreign ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun told a media briefing here that China opposes any action that lacks UN Security Council authorisation. - PTI

SUPREME COURT TO TAMIL NADU GOVERNMENT

'Reconsider Opposition to Navodaya Vidyalayas'

Bench gives state three months to identify land for residential schools funded by central govt

Raghav Ohri

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Thursday urged the Tamil Nadu government to reconsider its opposition to establishing Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalayas in the state, saying Chennai and New Delhi should not "alienate" each other over differences on language and education policy.

A bench of justices BV Nagarathna and Augustine George Masih asked Tamil Nadu to reconsider its approach to the three-language policy followed by Navodaya Vidyalayas and directed it to identify suitable land in every district for setting up the centrally funded residential schools. The court gave the state three months to identify suitable land and clarified that the direction didn't amount to an immediate order to acquire land.

During the hearing, the bench stressed the importance of cooperation between the Centre and the state on education. Justice Nagarathna observed that the state could not maintain a position that Hindi should not be taught in Tamil Nadu and remarked that "Chennai should not alienate Delhi and vice versa".

Tamil Nadu has traditionally followed a two-language policy centred on Tamil and English and opposed the Centre's three-language formula. Its opposition to

Navodaya schools has largely stemmed from the language policy governing these institutions.

Counsel for the Tamil Nadu government clarified that the state was not opposed to teaching Hindi as such, but had reservations about the three-language framework associated with the proposed schools.

The state also raised concerns about the financial implications of providing land and other resources for schools, particularly amid pending issues related to central funding for education schemes.

The Centre maintained that the state's principal responsibility under the Navodaya scheme was to make suitable land available while the Union government would bear the major expenditure associated with constructing and operating the institutions.

The bench also encouraged the Centre and Tamil Nadu to continue discussions to find a mutually acceptable solution to the language-related differences. It indicated that Tamil could potentially be accommodated within the language framework of the proposed schools.

The dispute stems from proceedings concerning the establishment of Navodaya Vidyalayas in every district of Tamil Nadu. The Supreme Court had earlier directed the state to identify suitable land for the schools, following which Tamil Nadu sought reconsideration of the direction. The bench on Thursday declined to recall its earlier order and gave the state additional time to comply with the direction to identify land.



GRAHAM STAINES MURDER CASE

Rejected Convict Dara Singh's Remission Plea, Odisha tells SC

Press Trust Of India

New Delhi: The Odisha government on Thursday told the Supreme Court that it has rejected the remission plea of Ravindra Pal, alias Dara Singh, who is serving a life sentence for the murder of Australian missionary Graham Stuart Staines and his two minor sons in 1999.

"You take whatever grounds you want to take to challenge it. Amend your petition and then argue," a bench of justices Manoj Misra and Vijay Bhishnoi told the counsel appearing for Singh. The bench noted that a copy of the August 31 order rejecting the remission plea has been supplied to Singh's counsel.

VAN DYKE CASE

Delhi Court Issues Notice to NIA on US Citizen's Bail Plea

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court on Thursday sought a response from the National Investigation Agency on a bail plea moved by US national Matthew Aaron Van Dyke arrested in a terror conspiracy case for alleged links to ethnic armed groups in India, sources said. According to court sources, special judge Prashant Sharma issued a notice to NIA on Van Dyke's bail plea. They said that the agency has to file its reply by September 18. Earlier this month, NIA had filed a chargesheet against Van Dyke and six Ukrainian citizens. - PTI

Apex Court to Take up Plea Challenging SIR in Delhi

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Supreme Court is set to take up a plea challenging the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Delhi, with petitioners questioning, among other aspects, the use of 'logical discrepancies' as a ground for issuing notices to voters. The petitioners have contended that 'logical discrepancies' have not been clearly defined, leaving elec-



'Authorities have arbitrary powers to flag voters over undefined logical discrepancies'

the precise grounds for such action.

NEIGHBOURHOOD IN FOCUS Nepal FM Wagle in New Delhi to Discuss Post-Disaster Reconstruction

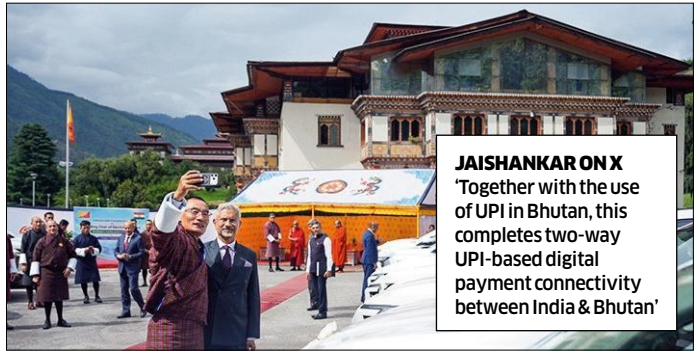
India Committed to Bhutan's Growth: EAM

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: External affairs minister S Jaishankar on Thursday reaffirmed India's commitment to Bhutan's development and progress by launching a slew of projects during his two-day visit to the Himalayan country.

Jaishankar held discussions with Bhutanese foreign minister Lyonpo DN Dhungyel and finance minister Lyonpo Lekey Dorji. During his visit, Jaishankar and Dhungyel jointly participated in several development initiatives. Jaishankar also handed over 43 pure line Jersey cows from India for Bhutan's dairy cattle breeding programme.

Following EAM's meeting with Dorji, phase-II of international UPI @UPI NPCI for Bhutanese citizens visiting India was launched. Meanwhile, Nepal's finance mini-



Jaishankar with Bhutan PM Dashi Tshering Tobgay in Thimphu on Thursday

ster Swarnim Wagle held a meeting with finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman in New Delhi on Thursday. They discussed Nepal's post-flood reconstruction, trade and investment, cooperation in the energy sector and improving connecti-

ty between the two countries. The visit comes as Nepal evaluates the destruction from the catastrophic flash floods and initiates rebuilding efforts. Wagle is on a three-day trip to New Delhi at the invitation of the Indian government.

OVER 6,100 MISSING Nepal Floods Death Toll Surges to 1,410

KATHMANDU: The death toll from the devastating flash floods in Nepal surged to 1,410, with over 6,100 people still missing, as per disaster management authorities. Flash floods, triggered by an ice-rock avalanche near the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26, devastated towns and villages in northern and central Nepal. - PTI

EC Bars TMC Factions From Using Party Name, Symbol



FILE PHOTO

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Election Commission on Thursday decided to freeze the symbol of the Trinamool Congress, in effect, on Thursday last day for nomination filing for two bypolls in West Bengal- stating clearly that none of the two factions shall be permitted to use the symbol “Flowers & Grass” for now. Both factions are to submit their choice of party name and ‘free symbol’ by September 18, 11 am for upcoming bypoll purposes, as per EC’s directions.

“On due consideration of the totality of information available on record... the commission is of the opinion that there are two rival groups in the All India Trinamool Congress, one led by Ms. Mamata Banerjee and the other led by Shri Arup Roy,” the EC interim order said.

“Each group is now claiming to be the party, and therefore the matter requires a substantive determination by the Commission under Para 15 of the Election Symbols (Reservation & Allotment) Order 1968,” it added. The EC Decision is in keeping with part trends and positions taken on symbol disputes- particularly when faced with bypolls.

The poll panel has largely chosen to freeze the disputed party symbol and grant temporary free symbols in case of bypolls.

Accordingly, in a late evening order, the EC said that both the Ritabrata and Mamata Banerjee factions may

choose other party/ factions, names from three ‘free’ symbols for the purpose of the upcoming bye elections.

September 16 was the last day for filing nominations for fraught the October 6 bypolls in West Bengal in Nandigram and Rejinagar.

Both the Ritabrata and Mamata Banerjee factions-locked in a battle for the twin-flower symbol- ‘Jora GhashPhool’-are contesting the bypoll which is also the first electoral test for both after the party split following the assembly elections that ousted TMC from power after 15 years.

The two seats were vacated by incumbent Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari and Humayun Kabir respectively as they retained Bhabanipur and Nowda seats which they won concurrently.

The bypoll necessitated is now set to turn into a five cornered fight with the two TMC factions, BJP Congress and the CPI-M—all fielding candidates.

The EC has been faced with similar issues on symbol disputes ahead of bypolls in the past but has usually passed interim orders several days ahead of nomination filing deadlines- in effect freezing the disputed symbol and allotting temporary ‘free’ symbols for bypoll purposes.

For instance, in 2022, the poll panel passed an interim order freezing the Shiv Sena symbol of ‘bow and arrow’ amid a dispute between two factions but it did so by October 8- well before the final date of nomination of October 14.

SC QUESTIONS ₹20,000 COMPENSATION FOR CAMP DEATHS

SC Examines Unnatural Deaths in Manipur Camps

Raghav Ohri

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Thursday directed the Manipur Chief Secretary to file a detailed affidavit on deaths, particularly unnatural deaths, reported among internally displaced persons staying at the relief camps in the violence-hit state.

A three-member bench, comprising Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justices Joyymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, expressed serious concern over the information placed before it regarding deaths in the camps and questioned the steps taken by the state authorities to investigate such cases.

The court directed the chief secretary to provide details of 25 unnatural deaths reported from relief camps, including post-mortem reports identifying the causes of death and in-



SEXUAL ASSAULT TOO

Court records show over 30 camp deaths including one preceded by alleged sexual assault

formation on preventive measures taken to avoid such incidents in the camps.

The bench questioned the state

government over the conduct of post-mortems as it was reportedly conducted in only 20 of 34 death cases as reflected in the material placed before the court.

CJI Kant questioned the Manipur government on why the information concerning the deaths had not resulted in significant action. During the hearing, the bench cautioned the state administration and said, “tell your chief secretary not to invite orders. Tell us what measures you have taken.”

The bench also questioned the compensation provided to internally displaced persons who died unnatural deaths while staying at the relief camps. The bench sought an explanation from the state as to why compensation of only ₹20,000 to ₹30,000 had been paid in such cases, particularly when substantially higher compensation had been contemplated in other cases arising from the violence.

AFTER HIS NAME CROPS UP IN SALIAN CASE

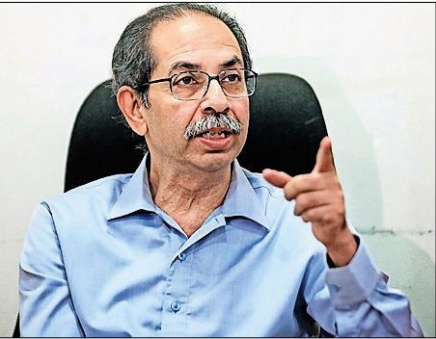
Uddhav Thackeray Raises Questions Over Gopinath Munde, Ajit Pawar Deaths

Krishna Kumar

Mumbai: The political warfare in Maharashtra has taken a darker turn as a bitter dispute over the “suspicious” high-profile death of Disha Salian has escalated into a macabre situation with questions being raised on the deaths of other political leaders too. Days after Uddhav Thackeray and his son Aaditya’s name figured in the FIR related to the death of former celebrity manager Disha Salian, Uddhav Thackeray has counter attacked by raising doubts over the suspicious deaths of BJP leader Gopinath Munde and NCP leader and former Deputy Chief Minister Ajit Pawar.

Uddhav Thackeray, who is touring Maharashtra, on Thursday raked up the death of Gopinath Munde who died in a car accident in 2014. “Gopinath ji’s death is still a mystery. I feel quite bad that the man who helped the BJP gain ground in the state could not enjoy power,” Uddhav Thackeray said. He was referring to Gopinath Munde who was widely tipped to become the chief minister after the BJP won the Maharashtra Lok Sabha polls and was expected to sweep the ensuing Maharashtra assembly polls too.

Uddhav also brought up Ajit Pawar’s death in a plane crash early this year. “I am not making any allegations on anyone or raising suspicions. There are suspicions on Ajit (Pawar) Dada’s death too. These suspicions are



not being raised by me, but his family members. There are no answers to that also. These are all suspicions and there should be an inquiry,” Thackeray said.

Thackeray said they had no connection with Salian’s death but their names were being sullied. “We are not connected to the case even remotely. Yet, they (Disha Salian’s family) have named me, my son. The incident that happened was extremely painful (of Disha allegedly falling to her death). But we have no role in it. Tomorrow, anyone’s name can be included like this,” Uddhav said.

He called the case ‘politically motivated’ and said the agencies probing the case can keep investigating but his family would initiate legal steps to prevent their names from being dragged into the case.

GIVES 90 DAYS FOR QUOTA

Jarange Ends 20-day Fast After Govt Assurances

Krishna Kumar

Mumbai: Maharashtra leader Manoj Jarange Patil ended his 20-day fast after receiving assurances from the government that his demands would be met in 90 days. A government delegation met him on Thursday at Patoda in Beed and requested him to call off his fast and assured him that the government would speedily issue kumbi caste certificates to eligible Marathas after legal clearances.

Ministers Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil, Dada Bhuse, accompanied by BJP MLC Prasad Lad and BJP MLA Suresh Dhas, met Patil and asked him to call off his fast.

Jarange said the government had assured him that in three months the state would give ‘official recognition’ of the historical administrative records like the Hyderabad Gazette, Satara Gazette and the Aundh Gazette that had, at different times, recognised Marathas in Marathwada as Kumbhis, making them eligible to get quota under OBC category.



name is deleted, he would not tolerate it and resume his stir. “The government should give in writing that not a single Kunbi record is ignored,” he said.

“If the government goes back on its assurances and if we are betrayed by them in these three months, then all the Marathas would go to Mumbai. There will be children and women this time,” Jarange Patil warned.

The Maharashtra government has heaved a sigh of relief as Jarange coming to Mumbai along with thousands of his followers could have caused traffic and law and order issues, especially during the Ganesh festive season.

UNDERGROUND CABLING PLANNED

Amaravati Plans Fully Privatised Power Grid

Nidhi Sharma

New Delhi: Amaravati, Andhra Pradesh’s under construction capital, is poised to become the second greenfield city in India, after Greater Noida, to completely privatize power distribution.

Andhra Pradesh government has called for expression of interest (EOI) from private power companies for “establishment and operation of electrical distribution network with distribution and retail supply of electricity in Amaravati Capital City”. According to sources, a team of Calcutta Electric Supply Corporation (CESC) has already conducted a field visit and shown interest in establishing and distributing power in the new capital city of Andhra Pradesh. Incidentally, CESC powers Greater Noida through its subsidiary company Noida Power Company Limited (NPCL). In 1993, Uttar Pradesh government privatised power distribution in Greater Noida, which became the first greenfield city in the true sense where power was privatised. Power privatisation of state-owned entities was

initiated much later in 1999. Delhi, for instance, privatised power in 2002 and unbundled Delhi Vidut Board.

Amaravati power distribution network will have another unique feature—entirety will have underground cable network. Mumbai is the only other city which has a fully underground transmission network. Other states like Gujarat, Karnataka and Delhi

have specific municipalities or neighbourhoods which have underground cabling but not entire cities. Amaravati, which has been termed by chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu as “People’s Capital”, comprises of 27 villages. Under the land pooling scheme, farmers of all 27 villages gave their land to build the capital.

They have been allotted their share of residential and commercial plots. These have been included in the planned city and the population is expected to grow to 3.55 million by 2050. According to official sources, at present there are seven substations with overhead transmission lines that are feeding Amaravati.



Stark Choice

►► From Page 1

Indian refiners have been seeking barrels from far and wide. But the bulk of their imports over the past six months has still come from the world’s large producers. Russia, Saudi Arabia and the UAE accounted for two-thirds of India’s crude imports during March-August.

Saudi supplies, which made up about 9% of India’s imports, were disrupted by drone attacks on a crucial pipeline last week.

If India and other buyers were to scramble for replacement barrels at the same time, oil prices could rise sharply, executives said. Brent futures are currently around \$105 a barrel. Finding vessels could also be a major challenge amid record-high tanker freight rates, they said.

India faced a similar choice when the US imposed a 25% tariff on Russian oil purchases in August 2025. But the choice is starker now: Gulf supplies, which were normal then, have been disrupted since the West Asia conflict began at the end of February. India chose to bear the cost of the tariff rather than cut Russian imports. Imports rose for three months after the duty

was imposed, peaking at 1.8 million barrels a day in November 2025. They began falling in December as US-India discussions on removing the tariff took shape, reaching 1 million barrels a day by February, when it was finally lifted.

The US said India had agreed to halt Russian crude purchases as the reason for lifting the tariff. India, however, never publicly accepted that it had made such a commitment.

Some industry executives are of the view that Trump may not rush to impose the new tariff. Further disruption to the oil market could push up fuel prices ahead of the US midterm elections and add to inflationary pressures. Diesel prices are already at a record high and the Federal Reserve raised interest rates Wednesday to tame inflation.

The global crude market has become more fragile in recent days with Saudi supplies grinding to a halt and the US blockade of Iranian exports having further slashed available barrels. Any further curtailment of Russian supplies, especially when global inventories are already depleted, could put significant upward pressure on oil prices.



PHOTOS: AGENCIES

RAM IDOL, GOND PAINTING, SPORTS COLLECTIBLES ON OFFER

PM’s 1,500 Gifts Up for Sale

Rakesh Mohan Chaturvedi

New Delhi: A silver idol of Lord Ram from Karnataka with the base price of ₹13.5 lakh, a silver replica of Kakatiya Kala Thoranam or Warangal Gate with base price of ₹9 lakh and a framed Tree of Life Gond painting priced at ₹7.5 lakh top the list of items put up for sale at the eighth edition of e-auction of mementos received by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Proceeds of the e-auc-

FOR NAMAMI GANGE

The proceeds of 8th e-auction of PM’s mementos will go to Namami Gange

tion, which was opened on Modi’s 76th birthday on Thursday and will end on Gandhi Jayanti, will go to the Namami Gange project.

Over 1,500 items are up for e-

auction with items ranging from vibrant artworks to sports collectibles, exquisite sculptures and traditional handicrafts. One can participate in the e-auction by visiting the site mnmementos.gov.in or view them in person at the National Gallery of Modern Art in the national capital.

GM Siddeshwara, a former Lok Sabha MP from Devangere in Karnataka, had presented the silver Ram idol to the prime minister which is the highest priced item up for e-auction.

Question of Veto Power

►► From Page 1

Tata Sons had also resolved to “initiate steps to comply with the applicable RBI (Reserve Bank of India) guidelines and will seek guidance from RBI, Tata Trusts and other stakeholders...”

Shortly afterwards, Tata Trusts publicly said it considered the board decision to reappoint Chandra for five years as illegal.

“The Trusts’ position remains unchanged, as a considered judgement of a majority shareholder. This position was reiterated in today’s board meeting by the chairman, Tata Trusts. The resolution seeking to reappoint N Chandrasekaran in the board meeting today, with four directors voting in favour, and Noel Tata against, was a legal nullity in view of the provisions of the Articles of Association of Tata Sons,” it said in a statement.

The public opposition by the trust makes the deferred and overdue Annual General Meeting of Tata Sons critical. To serve as chairman, Chandra needs to be reappointed as a director at the AGM, where majority owner Tata Trusts holds the cards. One of the two trusts that hold a majority of the shares—Sir Ratan Tata Trust—is currently barred by the Maharashtra charity commissioner from making decisions and therefore cannot participate in the AGM, which has consequentially had to be deferred due to a lack of quorum. The meeting has also called into ques-

tion the mechanism through which Tata Trusts exercises control over Tata Sons—a provision known as assenting vote available to the directors nominated by the trusts. All important decisions on the Tata Sons board need the assenting vote of a majority of trust nominees, according to the company’s Articles of Association. In the event of a tie, the chairman of the board can cast a casting vote.

With only two trust nominees—Noel Tata and Venu Srinivasan—currently serving on Tata Sons board, and both voting in opposing directions on the two resolutions discussed on Thursday, the question of the tie breaker has come into focus. Tata Sons board, backed by legal opinion, has taken the view that the casting vote by the chairman of the session, counts to settle the tie. Since Chandra could not vote on the matter of his reappointment, a casting vote was made by Harish Manwani, who was called to chair the session, multiple people familiar with the developments said.

Tata Trusts has taken the view that the negative vote by Noel Tata, a trust nominee, counts as a veto against the majority decision, rendering the decision invalid. It says Tata presented a legal opinion by former Supreme Court chief justice DY Chandrachud, which the board did not take on record.

The Tata Trusts said Chandrasekaran’s August 12 decision to

not offer himself up for reappointment was freely made, publicly communicated and accepted by the Trusts.

The legal issue is not settled. “The Act does not, by itself, prescribe that a particular shareholder nominee must vote in favour of the appointment of a chairman. Therefore, the contention that the resolution is a ‘legal nullity’ cannot be derived from the Companies Act alone,” said Ruchi Khatlawala, a corporate lawyer.

RESOLUTION OPEN TO CHALLENGE

The key question, she said, is whether Tata Sons’ Articles impose an additional mandatory voting requirement for chairman appointments. If so, failure to meet it could leave the resolution open to challenge despite the majority vote.

“In my view, therefore, the expression ‘illegal’ requires some caution at this stage. The more precise legal formulation would be that the resolution is open to challenge if the special voting mechanism under the Articles was mandatory and was not followed,” Khatlawala said.

On the listing issue, Noel’s position has been that Tata Sons can comply with the Reserve Bank of India’s requirements without explicitly committing to a public listing. He suggested that structural alternatives could be examined to meet the regulator’s



requirements while allowing Tata Sons to remain privately held. Noel also proposed setting up a committee or team comprising representatives of Tata Trusts and Tata Sons to jointly examine the way forward and work out how the company could comply with the RBI directive.

The board, however, is proceeding on a different interpretation of the RBI directive. Officials said that with Tata Sons continuing as an NBFC in the upper layer, the company has to comply with the regulator’s requirements and prepare for a listing. The board is therefore not considering structural alternatives as a substitute for meeting the listing requirement, they said.

The AGM, originally scheduled for August 18, was adjourned after the Sir Ratan Tata Trust and Sir Dorabji Tata Trust could not jointly nominate a representative. It must be held by December 31.

DIFFERENT INTERPRETATION

Noel’s statement also challenges the assumption that the Reserve Bank of India’s September 11 decision necessarily means Tata Sons must list. He said RBI had declined the company’s application to surrender its certificate of registration and directed it to comply with the Upper Layer NBFC framework, but the communication did not mention listing, prescribe a particular step or say Tata Sons was in breach.

Noel also pointed to the March 2024 board decision to remain unlisted, saying it had never been formally rescinded or reconsidered. Tata Sons had subsequently repaid borrowings and prematu-

rely redeemed preference shares worth about ₹20,000 crore, funded through internal resources and monetisation of group holdings, as part of that strategy.

The Trusts had separately reaffirmed its position in unanimous resolutions in May and July 2025, asking Tata Sons to explore alternatives and engage with RBI. Those resolutions, Noel said, remain unamended and have not been revisited by the trustees.

Noel has proposed a detailed representation to RBI, a hearing with the regulator and exploration of alternatives including restructuring. He has also sought legal advice on possible remedies and the complete RBI file and notings to understand the basis of the decision.

Even if listing ultimately proves unavoidable, Noel has asked RBI for at least three years—from September 11, 2026 to September 2029—to comply.

Noel also tabled a proposal from the Shapoorji Pallonji Group to sell part of its Tata Sons stake held by Sterling Investments Corporation and Cyrus Investments for gross proceeds of at least ₹25,000 crore. The proposal envisages the buyout in two tranches over 18 months and a selective capital reduction by Tata Sons through the NCLT. He proposed funding the buyout through internal cash flows, sale of listed shares, bringing investors into newer businesses and possible offer-for-sale listings of some businesses. He asked the Tata Sons board to initiate the NCLT process and allow the company and Tata Trusts to continue discussions with the SP Group and bankers.

New Vulnerable Areas, Deployment Talked at Manipur Security Review Meet

GUWAHATI With the increasing violence in Manipur, Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh held a security review meeting on Thursday during which new vulnerable areas

were identified and steps to deploy security personnel in those areas were discussed at length. The Security Coordination Meeting held at the Cabinet Hall of the CM’s secretariat in Imphal, and chaired by Singh, reviewed the law and order situation. With the working season approaching, authorities of the National Highways and Infrastructure Development Corporation (NHIDCL) and contractors are gearing up to intensify their work in the next six months.—**OPB**



SUITS & SAYINGS

ET's roundup of the wackiest whippers in corporate corridors

Bad Heir Day

Barely has the dust settled on a family feud, fresh trouble appears to be brewing for a corporate scion, this time over some upcoming real estate projects. Word is that construction at certain properties may have strayed beyond approved plans, catching the regulator's eye and raising the prospect of stop-work action. The scion is now said to be shuttling between lawyers and senior regulatory officials in search of a solution. Some plans, it seems, are best executed without straying too far from the original cut.

Flight Risk

Overseas travel has become a rather elaborate affair for a top executive at a major Chinese smartphone company facing allegations of financial fraud. His latest proposed stop is Bangkok, where the company is hosting a business meet in October ahead of the festive season. But after the ED didn't respond to his request for permission to travel, the executive had to turn to the court, which eventually cleared the trip. This comes after months of legal legwork: since March, he had repeatedly approached the court seeking to have the lookout order against him quashed. He finally got his way, but apparently that hasn't made foreign travel quite permission-free yet.

Privy to the whippers in power corridors or juicy tips on India Inc? Do share with us at etsuits.sayings@timesofindia.com

Tata Motors Set to Increase Vehicle Prices by up to 1%

MUMBAI: Tata Motors on Thursday said it will increase vehicle prices by up to 1% from October 1. This is being done to offset the rise in commodity and other input costs, it said. -PTI

Cos hike rates by up to 35% as they expect surge in orders till Diwali, say executives

QComm Platforms Step Up Ad Rates This Festive Season

Ratna Bhushan & Pranav Mukul

New Delhi: Quick delivery platforms have hiked festive season advertising rates by 30-35% from last year for brand placements on banners, carousels, mastheads and interactive widgets even as they expect almost 100% year-on-year surge in orders from now to Diwali, executives said. The increase comes at a time when advertisers increasingly use quick-commerce platforms to reach consumers closer to the point of purchase, particularly during periods of heightened shopping activity they noted.

"While the platforms have been hiking fees for the past two-three years, this year the increase is particularly higher, as a lot of premium and newer categories have been added to the mix," said the chief of a gourmet confectionery maker who requested not to be identified. Brands are willing to pay the premium despite steep hike in rates, particularly those seeking traction in tier-2 and 3 markets.

"We are willing to spend what Blinkit and Zepto are charging for the October-December quarter, since traditional retail will not give us the same reach," said the founder of a mid-sized cosmetics firm who requested not to be identified.

Ravi Saxena, CEO of premium appliances maker Wonderchef, said advertising is becoming a key revenue stream for quick-commerce platforms as they compete with e-commerce and traditional retail. "Our growth on QComm platforms is almost twice that of e-commerce this year," he said.

E-commerce platforms in India generate an estimated ₹20,000-₹25,000 crore in advertising revenue annually, with a significant portion coming during periods such as festive sales, Indian Premier League and other major shopping events, industry executives said. The share of quick commerce in this advertising pie is growing each year, they added.

"During festive-season events in the second half of the year, demand for both endemic and non-endemic advertising rises on quick-commerce platforms," one of the executives said. "Specific occasions such as Ganesh Chaturthi, Dussehra, Dhanteras and Diwali see ad inventory on these platforms getting sold out. These campaigns are typically finali-



sed a few months in advance." Endemic advertising refers to campaigns of brands selling on platform while non-endemic campaigns are those by firms that don't sell their products or services on the platform, such as an insurance company or an automobile maker.

India is heading into its strongest online festive season in five years, Redseer Strategy Consultants said. During the season, quick commerce is projected to grow 110-120%

year-on-year, compared with 16-18% for the rest of e-commerce, the report said. Mobiles and electronics could comprise 14-15% of quick-commerce sales during the period, nearly twice their usual share, it added.

"QComm could account for nearly one-fifth of festive online retail this year, after 3 successive years of near-doubling in H1 market size," said Kushal Bhatnagar, partner at Redseer. Queries sent to Blinkit, Instamart, Zepto, Flipkart Minutes, Amazon Now and BigBasket did not elicit a response until press time on Thursday.

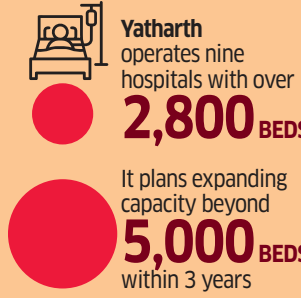
Promoter Tyagi family to remain single-largest shareholder of the speciality hospital chain

Our Bureau

Mumbai: US private equity firm Advent International has inked a definitive pact with Yatharth Hospital and Trauma Care Services to invest ₹3,150 crore for a 24.9% stake in the listed speciality hospital chain. Following the primary capital infusion, promoter Tyagi family will remain Yatharth's single-largest shareholder and continue to guide the company's long-term vision, alongside a leadership team of healthcare and business professionals, according to a company statement.

ET was the first to report August 28 that Advent and Blackstone-

Health Check



backed Aster DM Quality Care were competing for a stake in Yatharth. Promoters Ajay Kumar Tyagi and family and Kapil Kumar currently hold 55.8% stake in Yatharth; public shareholders own the remainder.

"Advent's investment marks a pivotal milestone in our journey and helps validate the strength of our platform and long-term vision,"



ET first reported on the development in its edition dated August 28, 2026

said Yatharth Tyagi, whole-time director at Yatharth Hospitals. "Beyond capital, Advent brings deep healthcare expertise, global insights, and a strong value-creation mindset that will...help accelerate our next phase of growth. Together, we aim to expand our reach, strengthen our capabilities, and build one of India's leading healthcare networks."

HEALTHCARE SECTOR RESPONDS TO MAHA FDA REVIEW REPORT ON PRICING GAP

Medical Tech Needs Separate Review: Hospitals

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The healthcare industry has called for an evidence-based and differentiated framework for reviewing medical device and consumable pricing, saying procurement costs cannot automatically be equated with the cost of delivering technology safely to patients.

Responding to the Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration's pricing review report, industry body Nathealth said hospitals incur costs related to clinical evaluation, emergency inventory, sterile-chain integrity, traceability, trained teams, specialised infrastructure and expiry risks.

While excessive margins on routine consumables merit scrutiny, sophisticated medical technologies require a separate assessment, industry executives said.

"Patient safety, clinical outcomes and transparency must remain at the centre of healthcare delivery,"



said Nathealth secretary general Siddhartha Bhattacharya. "At the same time, it is important to distinguish between a simple commodity consumable and a complex medical technology that has to be made safely and reliably available at the point of care," he noted.

ET reported on Wednesday that the Centre has sought a report from the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) after the Maharashtra FDA commissioner, Tukaram Mundhe, flagged gaps between the trade procurement prices and printed MRPs of hospital consumables such as syringes,

COST CHART

Nathealth said hospitals incur costs related to clinical evaluation, emergency inventory, among others

Earlier in a post on X, Mundhe, who has been in the news for strictly enforcing food-safety measures in the state, cited a survey of hospital consumables in Maharashtra that found an intravenous infusion set with a trade price of ₹11.05 carrying a printed MRP of ₹325, a markup of 2,841%. A syringe procured at ₹6.75 carried an MRP of ₹57.20, while a catheter procured at ₹29.41 had an MRP of ₹310.

Mundhe recommended a review of the survey findings and clear guidelines on the permissible gap between trade procurement prices

Founded in 2008, Yatharth operates nine multi-speciality hospitals with more than 2,800 beds. The company is targeting a total capacity of more than 5,000 beds in the next three years by opening new centres and expanding existing hospitals. Apart from Noida and Greater Noida, its footprint covers Jhansi-Orchha in Madhya Pradesh and Faridabad in Haryana.

Yatharth has expanded its presence through a mix of organic and inorganic growth.

"This investment underscores Advent's deep and long-standing commitment to India's healthcare sector, which we believe is entering a decade of structural growth as access expands, quality improves, and consolidation advances," said Pankaj Patwari, managing director at Advent.

For the first quarter ended June, Yatharth reported a 51% year-on-year rise in consolidated revenue at ₹392.7 crore. Average revenue per occupied bed (ARPOB) increased 7% to ₹34,758.

and declared MRPs.

Bhattacharya said that for sophisticated medical devices and consumables, the hospital is not merely a reseller. According to him, before a technology reaches the patient, the hospital may undertake clinical evaluation and selection, maintain multiple configurations and emergency inventory, ensure sterile-chain integrity and traceability, provide trained clinical and biomedical teams, manage expiry and obsolescence risks, maintain specialised infrastructure, safe disposal and assume responsibility for quality, safety and outcomes while ensuring compliance to all safety regulations. "Procurement price of a device cannot automatically be equated with its true cost of delivery to the patient," he said.

However, he added that extraordinarily high margins on routine, commoditised consumables deserve scrutiny and should not be justified by costs associated with sophisticated technologies.

Issues advisory permitting such treatment only as standard care for approved conditions

Health Min Moves to Regulate Use of Stem Cell Therapy

Teena Thacker

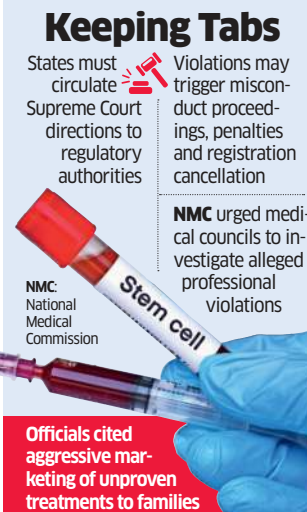
New Delhi: The Union health ministry issued an advisory against unregulated use of stem cell therapies, making clear that such treatment can be offered as standard care only for conditions specifically approved by the ministry. For autism spectrum disorder, a lifelong neurodevelopmental condition, the ministry said therapeutic use of any type of stem cells was restricted to approved clinical trials conducted in accordance with the National Guidelines for Stem Cell Research, 2017, issued jointly by the Indian Council of Medical Research and the department of biotechnology.

"The advisory reiterates the existing framework governing stem cell research and therapy" and seeks to ensure that the therapy is permitted as standard care only for disease conditions/indications included on the list approved by the ministry, the advisory stated. The advisory is in line with a Supreme Court ruling in January restricting the use of unproven stem cell therapy.

The ministry asked all states and union territories to widely disseminate the Supreme Court's directions to state and district regulatory authorities, as well as all government and private clinical establishments involved in stem cell research, treatment, promotion or administration. The advisory also drew attention to the consequences of non-compliance.

The Supreme Court held that violations could attract consequences including for professional misconduct under Regulation 7.22 of the Indian Medical Council Regulations dealing with ethical considerations in clinical trials, as well as cancellation of registration and financial penalties under Sections 32 and 40 of the Clinical Establishments Act.

"The ministry has accordingly



requested the concerned state and district regulatory authorities and clinical establishments to ensure strict compliance with the applicable framework governing stem cell research and therapy," it said.

"Stem cell therapy has been one of the most aggressively marketed unproven treatments in India over the past decade, particularly for conditions like autism, cerebral palsy and spinal cord injuries, where families desperate for solutions have often paid significant sums for treatment," said an official.

The National Medical Commission has separately reinforced the position. In an advisory issued on September 5, the commission also said stem cell therapy might be offered as standard clinical care only for approved indications and advised state medical councils to examine alleged violations and take appropriate disciplinary action if misconduct was established.

AS CENTRE MOVES TO INTRODUCE 0.4% MDR ON UPI DEALS ABOVE ₹2,000

With Margins at Risk, Retailers Push for Scrapping Proposed MDR Levy

BREATHING ROOM



Writankar Mukherjee

Kolkata: Retailers across the country are mounting a strong pushback against the proposed merchant discount rate (MDR) on unified payments interface (UPI) transactions above ₹2,000, with industry associations representing consumer electronics, mobile phones and FMCG retailers petitioning the finance ministry to scrap the charge, saying it will erode their already thin net margins.

In a letter to the finance ministry Wednesday, the All India Mobile Retailers Association (AIMRA), representing 150,000 neighbourhood stores, highlighted that the sector is facing a severe crisis, with a nearly 40% year-on-year drop in business

volumes as companies raised handset prices to offset higher memory chip costs.

"Mainline mobile retailers operate on extremely thin net margins (often between 0.75% and 1.5%)," AIMRA said in the letter. "If an MDR charge of 0.40% is imposed on UPI transactions—which account for a significant portion of digital payments—it will directly erode their survival margins."

The resistance follows the Centre's decision to introduce a 0.4% MDR on person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI transactions above ₹2,000, capped at ₹300 for payments of ₹75,000 and above, from October 15. Merchants will bear the charge, while zero MDR will continue for transactions up to ₹2,000—which account for more than 95% of P2M volume

s—and for small merchants earning up to ₹1 lakh a month through UPI QR codes directly into their bank accounts. Those crossing the ₹1 lakh threshold will pay the MDR.

While the Centre stressed that the 0.4% MDR is significantly lower than the standard MDR on debit and credit cards, industry bodies said the charge would disproportionately hurt higher-value offline retailers, which operate with high overheads and low margins.

The South Indian Organised Retailers Association (ORA), which represents over 5,500 large electronics and mobile phone retail stores under chains such as Poorvika, Sangeetha and Big C, estimates that 20% of its annual sales revenues of ₹26,400 crore, or about ₹5,280 crore, comes through UPI.

In a letter to the finance ministry on Thursday, ORA said the low net margins and high overheads of physical retailers mean "absorbing additional transaction charges severely impacts the viability of physical retail stores."

The All India Consumer Products Distributors Federation, the FMCG general trade industry body, plans to write to the government on Friday, while the Retailers Association of India is consulting the government and is also expected to make a representation. Dhairyashil H Patil, president of the FMCG trade body, said FMCG retailers typically operate with gross margins of 8-12%, leaving kiranas with net margins of only 1.5-2% due to high operational cost and other expenses like stock expiry.

Price Hike Not on Menu for Now, Say Eateries

Anumeha Chaturvedi & Anoushka Sawhney

New Delhi: Cafes, restaurants, pubs and bars are unlikely to raise menu prices further in the October-December quarter, the busiest season for the hospitality industry, after the Centre said UPI-driven transactions above ₹2,000 would attract a 0.4% merchant discount rate (MDR) levy from next month.

"There are supply chain challenges, but consumption has never been so high, and people are going out so much," said Burma Burma co-founder Chirag Chhajer. "These are exciting times, and we are foreseeing the best ever October-December quarter in terms of revenues for the chain and we won't be hiking our prices due to the MDR levy," Roshan Banan, MD of Sagar Ratna Restaurants, said the chain has raised prices by 5% after two years due to higher input costs and won't look at more hikes.

Food and beverage services recorded inflation of 8.4% year-on-year in August, compared with 7.8% in July and 2.9% in January, reflecting the impact of the West Asia crisis on commercial liquefi-

ed petroleum gas. Spending at restaurants has increased, reflected in a 22.2% rise in UPI transactions, which reached 21.8 billion in the first eight months of the year, up from 17.8 billion in the same period last year.

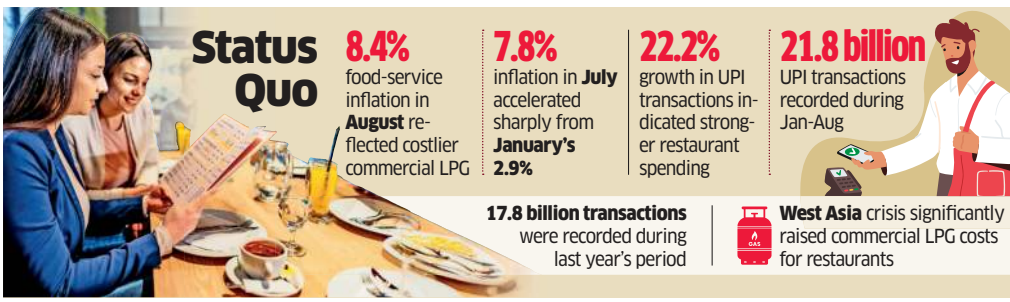
Rahul Singh, founder of The Beer Café, said he expects the October-December quarter to be 'really healthy' for eating out. "Inflation will make consumers more discerning, but I don't see it taking them away from going and eating out. They may spend more carefully, but the social and experiential nature of eating out remains strong," he said. "On UPI MDR, restaurants are already operating with wafer-thin margins. You can't keep passing every cost increase to

the consumer as at some point, the consumer pushes back. Some of that pressure will inevitably have to be absorbed by the industry."

Saurabh Khanijo, managing director of the Klyn chain of restaurants, also ruled out price hikes in the upcoming quarter despite shrinking margins, as that could dent demand. "The 8.4% inflation in food and beverage services is certainly significant, and the industry continues to face pressure across ingredients, manpower and rentals," said Zorawar Kalra, managing director of Massive Restaurants, which operates restaurant brands such as Farzi Cafe and Sly Granny. "But eating out in India has increasingly become an

experience-led discretionary spend, and we continue to see resilience, particularly in the organised and premium segments." Rising food prices have been adding to the pressure the industry faces. Food inflation rose to 6% year-on-year in August compared with 5.5% in July, while overall retail inflation rose to 4.8% from 4.5%. Sakshi Gupta, principal economist at HDFC Bank said F&B services is one of the categories where consumers saw the first increase at the retail level in terms of a pass-through.

"With a combination of input cost pass-throughs and climbing seasonal demand, it is anticipated that this particular category continues to be elevated," she said.



Former KKR CEO Sanjay Nayar Buys ₹90-cr Apartment in South Mumbai

Kailash Babar

Mumbai: Sanjay Nayar, the former chief executive officer of KKR India and founder of Sorin Investment Fund, has purchased a luxury apartment in south Mumbai's plush Carmichael Road for ₹90 crore, making it one of the country's most expensive residential property transactions on a per sq ft basis.

The transaction involves a 4,537.29 sq ft apartment on the first floor of a property on ML Dahanukar Marg, also known as Carmichael Road. The deal works out to around ₹1.98 lakh per sq ft based on the carpet area.

The transaction, registered on Tuesday, includes an open garage measuring 225.89 sq ft. The total registered area of the property, including the garage, is 5,448.9 sq ft, showed registration documents accessed through Zapkeo.com.

The purchase adds to a series of high-value residential transactions in Mumbai's premium neighbourhoods, where limited inventory, large-format apartments and strong demand for trophy residences have continued to support elevated property values.

The apartment complex, Kamal Mahal, was developed over seven decades ago and was among the first buildings to come up on Carmichael Road. The seven-storey Kamal Mahal and the adjacent Anand building are spread over a two-acre plot with a landscaped garden.

Malabar Hill, along with nearby areas such as Cumballa Hill and Altamount Road, has remained among Mumbai's most sought-after residential locations, with transactions for large apartments often commanding substantial ticket sizes and setting new benchmarks.

In December 2022, Nayar founded Sorin Investment Fund, an investment platform focused on growth and private equity investments. He previously served as CEO of KKR India and is also a board member of FSNE-Commerce Ventures, the parent company of Nykaa.

ET's email query to Nayar remained unanswered until the publication of this report.

The latest transaction comes amid continued activity in Mumbai's luxury residential market, particularly for large apartments in established south and central Mumbai neighbourhoods.



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Annual General Meeting

Hotel Pride Plaza, Aerocity, New Delhi
18th September 2026 (Friday) 5:00 to 7:00 PM

PLENARY SESSION

The Invisible Revolution: How Innovation is Feeding India

SPEAKER PANEL



Dr. Vishal Choudhary
Scientist 'F'
Nodal Officer for Science & Technology (S&T) Clusters
Principal Scientific Adviser (PSA)
to the Government of India



Dr. Sweetie Behera
Director
Food Safety and Standards
Authority of India (FSSAI)



Dr. Kavya Dashora
Professor
Indian Institute of Technology
Delhi



Dr. Rajvir Singh Rath
Director Agricultural
Affairs & Policy;
Lead Traits Licensing Business
Bayer CropScience Ltd.



Dr. Pushplata Singh
Director and Senior Fellow
Sustainable Agriculture
Division, The Energy and
Resources Institute



Mr. Prabhudutta Mishra
Deputy Editor
Hindu Businessline



Mr. Srinivasa Karavadi
Founder & CEO
Kshetragna Farm
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Mr. Gopinath Koneti
Senior Advisor and Lead
Food and Agriculture
KPMG in India



Mr. Rahul Dhanuka
(Chairman, ACFI)
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Warsh-led Fed Starts US War on Inflation

India will feel drag of higher global interest rates

US Fed chair Kevin Warsh led a unanimous 12-0 vote to raise interest rate to 3.75-4%, defying Donald Trump's calls for lower borrowing costs. This is the Fed's first interest rate hike in 3 yrs, as central bankers across the world get their act together over controlling inflation. The dollar is nestled higher, equities are shuffling after a dip, and short-term bond yields have jumped on expectation of another rate hike this year. A hawkish Fed could be spoilsport for the AI party, as investors take stock of rich valuation. Inflation expectations are up across the board as energy prices and bond yields stay high. G7 central banks will take their cue from the Fed. This will be a second round of concerted interest rate hikes since the Ukraine conflict as stagflation rears its head. Most emerging economies will have to follow into an interest rate upcycle.

India will feel the drag of higher global interest rates combined with trade friction and disrupted energy supplies. Effects on Indian equities could be mixed if AI valuations moderate, while its vulnerability to the US war on Iran remains elevated. The rupee will remain under pressure from a strengthening dollar. Global capital seeking safe harbour in US treasuries will affect India's equity and commodity markets. There is some cushion in domestic consumption. But that comes at the cost of fiscal slippage and RBI's tolerance for inflation resurging soon after a painful spike.

RBI has consistently opted for a low growth sacrifice while chasing inflation targets. The economy has shown remarkable resilience during the West Asia crisis. But persistent energy disruption will chip away at the momentum. Separately, food inflation is on an episodic climb, with second-order effects of energy inflation yet to work their way through the system. Timelines for interest rate changes may have to be foreshortened. This could throttle credit-led consumption and a revival of private investment. But, as the Fed has shown, it's better to strike first in the battle against inflation.

We Cannot Normalise 'Orwellian Dystopia'

Last week, Allahabad High Court came down heavily on the UP government over alleged misuse of Uttar Pradesh Control of Goondas Act 1970. Cases before it, it noted, suggested the state was using the law as a tool of harassment, adding that such misuse will invite punitive damages. The court made its statement while quashing an order by the Gonda DM declaring a person a 'goonda' and externing him for 6 mths. It reminded the executive that a solitary case does not make a habitual offender, and an acquittal can't become a tool of surveillance and instrument of harassment.

Appetite for such procedural shortcuts is becoming worryingly systemic. Only weeks earlier, the high court had called Deoria police officials a 'bunch of liars' after they claimed station CCTV cameras were non-functional during alleged illegal detention of four individuals. Its split verdict on 'bulldozer justice' also exposed the constitutional tension around executive overreach. Nowhere was this more glaring than in the case of Aakriti Chaudhary. The 24-year-old DU student activist was slapped with NSA for advocating for low-wage workers protesting in Noida. Her preventive detention paperwork was found to be generated after she had been taken into custody, a move the court termed a 'sham'. Finding no evidence of incitement, it quashed her detention.

Governments have the duty to preserve law and order. But law enforcement without constitutional fidelity is coercion. Maintaining public order doesn't give the executive a blank cheque to forgo fundamental rights without proof, evidence and due process. When preventive laws are weaponised to quiet dissent, or paperwork is forged to justify illegal custody, we risk sliding into, as the court said, 'Orwellian dystopia'.



JUST IN JEST

Industrial policy is fine, but India needs to give the divine maker his due

Time to Bump Up Vishwakarma

India has tried production-linked incentives, industrial corridors, startup missions, semiconductor missions.... But one element of industrial policy remains scandalously underutilised: Vishwakarma. 'V-man', whose puja was observed yesterday, is traditionally the divine architect and craftsman, honoured by engineers, mechanics, artisans and factory workers. Machines and tools are duly venerated on his day in his honour. Yet, India continues to treat him like an ITI graduate when he's clearly more than qualified to be Union minister of manufacturing, heavy industry, MSMEs, semiconductors and AI.

Policy is all very well. But what rational economic framework neglects the literal divine maker? Economists obsess over capital formation, productivity and supply chains. Vishwakarma offers all three, without demanding retro taxation. If anyone understands tech transfer, here's the guy. Vishwakarma needs bigger pujas, better branding and his own manufacturing PLI: puja-linked incentive. Before the next semiconductor fab is inaugurated, forget ribbon-cutting. Bring flowers, incense and a lathe. The Greeks provide a warning. They had Hephaestus, god of smiths, metalworking and craftsmen. They allowed him to slip down the cultural rankings. Result? Sovereign-debt crisis, and a Mediterranean economy that not even Chris Nolan will make a movie on.

Tokenisation can transform India's bond market, but the bigger test is whether it broadens access

TOKEN, NOW STIR

Oh, Let's Look Beyond AAA



Dinesh Patwari

Launch of Sebi-RBI's Demat 2.0 pilot for tokenised corporate bonds on Sept 10 marked a significant evolution in the architecture of India's financial markets. The initiative uses distributed ledger technology, digital securities and central bank digital currency (CBDC) to bring securities and settlement legs of a transaction closer together.

The pilot has seen three issuances, raising around ₹1,025 cr, signalling that tokenisation is moving from an idea into a practical market experiment. But there's one question that needs to be answered alongside tokenisation: can we make bonds liquid after they have been issued?

Consider the dilemma faced by an investor looking at an AA, A+, or A-rated bond. The bond may offer higher yield than a comparable AAA instrument. The investor may be comfortable with the additional risk. But then there's the key question: if I need money before maturity, who will buy my bond? That uncertainty means investors demand an additional premium, or avoid the security. Low liquidity leads to fewer investors, higher liquidity premium and higher borrowing costs, further shrinking investor base. The answer is not to tell investors to take more risks, but to make the market more liquid.

Equity markets facilitate continuous buying and selling. Why should the corporate bond market be different? A new generation of professional corporate-bond market makers could provide investors with something missing in many lower-rated bonds: a credible 2-way market. This is where a targeted regulatory intervention can make a difference.

Every new listed corporate bond issue of ₹200 cr or more, rated AA and below, should have a professional market-making arrangement. A Sebi-registered merchant banker could be designated as the market maker for 3 yrs, or until maturity if the bond matures earlier. The market maker would provide 2-way quotes within a prescribed spread. The proposed maximum spread could range from about 75 bps for AA bonds to 150 bps for lower-rated bonds, reflecting greater risk and lower liquidity of the securities.

The market maker would be compensated for providing this service through a transparent fee paid by the issuer. This is not a guarantee against losses or of the issuer's credit quality, but a commitment to provide a functioning secondary market.

There's a major advantage in starting with new issues. Cost of market-making can be built into the economics of the bond at the time it's issued. The investor knows before subscribing that there's a designated professional market maker. The issuer knows the cost. The merchant banker knows the obligation. The regulator can monitor compliance. And the market gradually builds a stock of more liquid bonds. This is preferable to imposing retrospective obligations on thousands of existing securities.

A framework could have 5 pillars:

- **₹200 cr threshold** Smaller issues may not have enough depth to justify the mechanism initially.
- **AA and below** This is precisely where additional liquidity can make the greatest difference.

● **3-yr obligation** The objective is to establish secondary-market liquidity without imposing an indefinite balance-sheet commitment on the market maker.

● **Rating-linked spreads** A higher-risk bond should command a wider market-making spread. The proposed range could be 75-150 bps.

● **Limit on number of mandates** A merchant banker should not be permitted to undertake unlimited market-making obligations. A ceiling of 10 bonds at a time would help ensure that market making is genuine rather than merely contractual.

Investors price liquidity risk alongside credit risk, so better liquidity can reduce the premium embedded in yields.

The benefit can flow back to issuers. A company with a good credit profile but a lower rating shouldn't have to pay an excessive premium merely because investors fear that the bond will be difficult to sell. A deeper sec-



Raise a glass to ₹1,025 cr

ondary market can, therefore, reduce the cost of capital while simultaneously improving investor choice.

This is important for India's next phase of growth. Its infrastructure, manufacturing, logistics, RE, real estate and financial-services sectors will require enormous amounts of long-term capital. Banks can't—and shouldn't—be expected to finance everything. A deeper corporate bond market is essential. But a bond market dominated by AAA and quasi-sovereign issuers cannot fully meet financing requirements of a rapidly expanding economy. India needs a broad credit spectrum.

The market should be able to finance strong companies rated AA, A, or BBB, not merely those fortunate enough to carry an AAA rating. That requires investors to have confidence not only in an issuer's creditworthiness but also in liquidity of the security.

The regulatory objective should, therefore, be to make AA, A, and other appropriately rated corporate bonds more investible, not by reducing credit standards but by improving market infrastructure. A transparent, regulated market-making framework for new issues above ₹200 cr could be an important step.

If successful, it could gradually change investor behaviour: The result would not be an abandonment of AAA bonds but something better: a shift from rating-driven investing to risk-adjusted investing.

The writer is former chairman, Metropolitan Stock Exchange of India (MSEI)



Sri Misra

Credit Where Credit's Due

Singapore: On Sept 7, REC raised ₹500 cr through India's first pilot issue of tokenised corporate bonds under Sebi's regulatory sandbox. Ownership sat on a permissioned distributed ledger; settlement was in wholesale CBDC, and pay-in, allotment and listing finished the same day.

The book drew ₹796 cr against a ₹100 cr base issue, with ₹500 cr accepted. Two days later, L&T raised ₹500 cr for 3 yrs, becoming the first private issuer to follow, while IIFL Finance raised ₹25 cr at 9.1%, the first non-PSU.

₹1,025 cr in a week, against a corporate bond market of roughly ₹59 lakh cr that privately placed ₹2.65 lakh cr across 603 issues between April and July. As a share of the market, it may be nothing, but as an engineering result, it's not nothing.

Atomic settlement, where security and money change hands in one

stand at roughly \$16 bn, inside a non-stablecoin tokenised asset market in the mid-\$30 bn range. That growth is not a fashion. The buyer was capital already living onchain, holding dollars that earned nothing, while someone else kept the bill yield. It could have wired out and bought bills, but only by leaving the rail its business runs on. Tokenisation removed that choice, and the money arrived.

Tokenised credit is now roughly \$8 bn, but it too is concentrated in US dollar assets. Emerging-market corporate credit onchain remains a rounding error.

So, concentration is not really about asset class but about economy. Whether the label says 'treasury' or 'credit', the cash flow is mostly dollar-denominated, and US, exposed to one currency, one central bank and one credit cycle. Ten such instruments are not a portfolio.

India is where the gap is clearest. Foreign capital does reach Indian credit. EY recorded \$3.5 bn of private credit investment in H1 2026, with global funds at 26% of deal value, down from 68% a year earlier. But locked at the channel carrying it. A global fund stands up an offshore vehicle, takes a registration, appoints a custodian and a designated bank, and writes large tickets. Each step costs roughly the same.

The real minimum is not the instrument's face value but the operating stack around it, which prices out everyone below institutional scale. Family offices, smaller institutions, wealth platforms and onchain treasuries may want the exposure; the access cost keeps them out.

The swing is the evidence. A channel carrying 68% of a market one year, and 26% the next, isn't a market so much as a small number of large decisions. Demand is not in doubt. Indian credit carries real credit and liquidity risk, and a dollar investor must also hedge the rupee, which is expensive. What survives is a return attached to a credit cycle global portfolios don't already own.

Which brings the question back to the digital rupee. Settling a domestic bond in wholesale CBDC among domestic institutions improves domestic market infrastructure. The switch that matters more lets tokenised Indian assets be held by foreign capital, including the \$300 bn pool of stablecoin liquidity with no regulated pathway into Indian markets today, and keeps law and regulatory protection fully intact.

For India, the measure is direction. A global allocator in Singapore, Dubai or NYC should be able to hold Indian credit alongside US gov debt, each asset governed by laws of its home market. Over time, that Indian credit should also be usable in ordinary capital-markets workflows: collateral, financing, treasury management and portfolio construction. That would bring in investors who cannot reach Indian markets today.

₹1,025 cr settled in digital rupee is a good beginning. The larger prize is a dollar in Dubai that can lend to an Indian company, and stay under Indian law while it does.

The writer is founder-chief architect, aarna.ai



Judging Others?

SANJAY TEOTIA

Appearances can be deceiving. Often, we judge people by their actions without understanding the silent battles they are fighting. A person who seems angry may be struggling with grief. Someone who appears rude may be overwhelmed by stress, disappointment or loneliness. Difficult circumstances can cloud a person's thoughts, emotions and behaviour. This does not mean we should accept harmful actions, but it encourages us to look beyond the surface before forming opinions.

Most spiritual traditions teach that the soul is naturally pure. Fear, pain, attachment and ignorance create negative actions. Just as dark clouds temporarily hide the sun without diminishing its light, difficult phases in life can temporarily hide a person's kindness and wisdom. With healing, guidance and time, many people rediscover their true nature.

A kind word, a listening ear or a simple act of forgiveness can become a turning point in someone's life. At the same time, we can protect our peace while still wishing others well and recognising that their actions may reflect their inner struggles rather than their true character.

Life moves in cycles. Someone struggling today may become a source of inspiration tomorrow. We, too, may one day need the patience and understanding of others. The next time someone behaves harshly, pause before labelling them as a bad person. Consider that they may be experiencing a difficult chapter in their journey.



Sunday Sofa-ing

Modern civilisation has made a curious error: it has confused movement with progress. The ambitious must rise early, count steps, answer emails while walking, and spend Sunday 'recharging'. Against this self-imposed tyranny stands one of humanity's finest institutions: the sofa.

To spend an entire day on one is a sheer achievement of non-achievement. Morning begins with something resembling coffee, and the vague intention of stirring up. By noon, you've dug deeper into the sofa.

A book lies open on the table, unread, but companionable. The phone's unexamined and rejected. Lunch arrives in packets of chips and namkeen.

Outside, people are reversing badly into parking spaces, while the blissful sofa-dweller has attained sovereignty over time.

There are no appointments, only naps. The distinction between 2pm and 5pm becomes academic. You watch half a film, read three paragraphs, consider getting up, and wisely decide against rash action.

There is joy in this surrender because most days demand that we become somebody: employee, employer, ward, guardian, colleague, spouse, commuter, customer, seller, person-who-replies-promptly.... The sofa asks nothing, except that you occasionally rearrange a cushion.

By evening, remarkably, nothing has been accomplished. Which was the entire point.

Chat Room

India, Full-On Chip Stake!

Apropos the Edit, 'Chip Away In to the Whole Ecosystem' (Sep 17), India's semiconductor ambitions will succeed only when manufacturing is supported by a wider ecosystem. Building fabrication units is important, but equally necessary are skilled technicians, reliable suppliers, testing facilities and indigenous equipment. Government incentives should, therefore, extend beyond large investments and encourage smaller firms to develop specialised capabilities. Close collaboration between industry, universities and technical institutions can create a steady talent pool. A long-term policy framework, rather than short-term subsidies, will give investors confidence. The objective should be to make India not merely a chip assembler but a dependable and competitive semiconductor hub.

*S.M. Jeena
Chennai*

Navigating Chinese Checkers



Nilanjan Banik

In their one-on-one at the sidelines of the New Delhi BRICS summit last weekend, Narendra Modi and Xi Jinping discussed the border issue, with the two expressing 'commitment to a fair, reasonable, and mutually acceptable resolution'. The other important track, economics, had little to cheer about, except for resumption of direct flights between Delhi and Guangzhou, a major sourcing hub for Indian apparel, accessories and electronics traders.

In FY26, China overtook the US to become India's largest trading partner. Bilateral merchandise trade reached about \$151 bn. But it's how the trade is split that tells the real story. India imported well over \$130 bn in Chinese goods, while exporting under \$20 bn, leaving a deficit above \$112 bn, the widest on record, and a jump from about \$98 bn the year before. For every dollar of goods India sells to China, it buys back \$6-7 worth.

India hasn't been able to leverage China's \$18 tn economy effectively, and the widening trade deficit is largely organic, driven by Chinese firms' superior price and tech competitiveness. The silver lining is that

Indian consumers gain access to cheaper Chinese goods, with a larger realisation of consumer surplus.

Much of what China sells India—telecom equipment, semiconductors, lithium-ion batteries, solar cells, industrial machinery, pharmaceuticals—are productive inputs that Indian factories and assembly lines depend on to make their own products affordable and competitive. Cutting these imports off overnight would raise costs across Indian industry, not lower them. Even a 'Made in India' smartphone, EV or solar panel carries a great deal of Chinese content inside it.

India relies on China for a striking share of inputs across sensitive sectors. Nowhere is this dependence more exposed than in rare earths. China controls roughly two-thirds of global rare earth mining, some 60% of processing capacity, and close to 90% of magnet manufacturing, a dominance



Get more toe-to-toe

built deliberately since the 1990s, when Beijing designated rare earths a strategic asset while Western producers retreated from this pollution-intensive sector.

In April 2025, China restricted exports of 7 rare earth elements, primarily as retaliation against US tariffs, rather than a move aimed at India. India was caught in the cross-fire regardless, given how heavily its EV, electronics, RE energy and defence sectors lean on these materials, for which substitutes such as ferrite magnets perform noticeably worse.

What followed was a stop-start sequence that has made planning nearly impossible for Indian manufacturers. China eased curbs on magnets, fertilisers and tunnel-boring equipment in August 2025 after diplomatic commitments from its foreign minister Wang Yi during a visit to New Delhi—only to add 5 more elements to its control list 2 mths later, and to introduce a rule requiring approval for any product containing even trace amounts of Chinese-origin rare earths. By December, restrictions covered 12 elements in total.

India is preparing an incentive scheme worth about ₹73 bn for rare earth magnet manufacturing, alongside a ₹15 bn critical-minerals recycling initiative running through 2031. India is also courting Australia, Japan and South Korea as alternative rare earth suppliers. Private capital has begun to follow, with companies raising fresh funds specifically to

invest in rare earth metals.

But domestic manufacturing capacity in electronics, batteries and critical minerals takes years to build, and will require sustained policy support well beyond current incentive schemes. Diversifying supply chains can reduce dependency without eliminating it. Indian negotiators have limited leverage to try open Chinese markets for pharma, agriculture and IT services. So, progress there is likely to stay incremental.

Unlike blanket protectionism, which risks sheltering inefficient domestic producers, targeted measures—anti-dumping duties where dumping is proven, security screening for genuinely sensitive technologies, incentives tied to measurable gains in value addition rather than mere assembly—offer a more sustainable path.

With respect to China, what is emerging is not a relationship headed for imminent decoupling. Trading in local currency will help reduce trade imbalances, mainly by lowering exchange rate volatility, reducing the need to hoard costly foreign reserves, and cutting transaction costs for cross-border trade. Also required is insistence on tech transfer.

Future rounds of negotiation will require ambition, creativity and willingness on the part of Indian negotiators to make China accept on these terms.

The writer is head, Economic Policy Centre, Mahindra University, Hyderabad

India's Construction Equipment Exports Set to Top 20k Units in FY27

GLOBAL LEAP Developed market demand, FTAs and Stage V emission norms help move up value chain

Sharmistha Mukherjee

New Delhi: India's construction equipment exports are set to cross 20,000 units this financial year, growing 19% from fiscal 2026 and more than 70% from three years ago, with demand coming from Europe, the US, Australia and Southeast Asia, underscoring the country's increasing prowess as a manufacturer of globally competitive, precision-engineered products.

The Indian Construction Equipment Manufacturers' Association (ICEMA) estimates construction and infrastructure equipment exports to be 20,701 units in the fiscal year ending March 2027, up from 17,396 units in FY26, despite geopolitical headwinds. Exports rose about 32% last fiscal year, on a lower base. Exports were 11,990 units in FY24. The surge in exports is supported by three structural tailwinds, ICEMA president Deepak Shetty told ET. "India moved to Stage V emission norms for construction equipment last year, which opened up opportunities for exports to developed markets.

Growth Pillars



This, along with the tariff concessions India is receiving under the newly inked FTAs (free trade agreements), is resulting in export demand shifting from Saarc (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation) countries like Nepal, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh towards more developed markets," said Shetty, who is also managing director at market leader JCB India.

In fact, exports of high-value engineering goods from India are rising across sectors. Shipments rose by 5% to \$24 billion in auto components, by 63% to \$4.6 billion in defence hardware and by 25% to \$48 billion in electronics goods last financial year. Backed by a large domestic market, deepening localisation, an established supplier ecosystem and cost-competitive engineering talent, India is positioning itself as an alternative manufacturing hub for complex machinery worldwide, senior industry executives said.

The local market is the third-largest globally after the US and China and is projected to become the second by 2030. While India has "significant potential" to emerge as a global manufacturing and export hub for construction equipment, the broader engineering export ecosystem is also demonstrating the country's growing global competitiveness, said Sandeep Singh, managing director at Tata Hitachi Construction Equipment Co.

"However, the change in the geopolitical setup with the crisis in the Middle East, as well as the imposition of tariffs by many countries, is a major challenge to navigate the export market. The cost of logistics and vessel availability has significantly deteriorated since the Gulf crisis, and the industry is closely watching these developments to adapt to the overseas requirements," he said.

For Tata Hitachi, exports represent a long-term opportunity, he said.

Brookfield to Invest up to \$600 m in ACME Cleantech

Marks investment firm's entry into green molecule space in India and the Gulf

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Global investment firm Brookfield will invest up to \$600 million (₹5,743 crore) in ACME Cleantech Ventures, the green molecules platform of ACME Group, to fund the development and construction of projects in India and the Gulf.

The investment marks Brookfield's entry into the green molecules sector in the region. It will be made through Brookfield Global Transition Fund, which focuses on investments supporting the transition to a net-zero carbon economy.

ACME Cleantech Ventures, a UK-based entity within the ACME Group, is dedicated to

the group's green molecules business. The platform is developing a pipeline of green ammonia and green methanol projects in India and Oman.

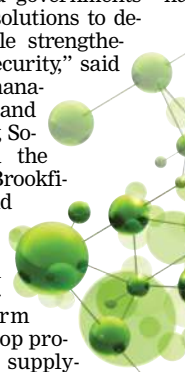
"The demand for green molecules continues to grow as companies and governments seek scalable solutions to decarbonize while strengthening energy security," said Nawal Saini, managing partner and head of energy, South Asia and the Middle East, Brookfield. ACME said the investment would support the expansion of its green molecules platform and help develop projects aimed at supplying clean fuels and feedstock to domestic and international markets.

The company has secured off-take partnerships with global and Indian companies, including Yara International, IHI Corporation, Mitsubishi Gas

Chemicals, Solar Energy Corporation of India (SECI), IFFCO, Paradeep Phosphates, Coromandel International and Indorama India. ACME has an operational green ammonia facility in Bikaner, Rajasthan, and is developing a green ammonia project in Duqm, Oman.

It is also establishing new facilities in Odisha following its green ammonia purchase agreement with SECI. ACME chairman Manoj Upadhyay said the company's portfolio, supported by long-term offtake contracts with domestic and international counterparties, provides a foundation for building sustainable cash flows.

The green molecules business is targeting hard-to-abate sectors such as fertilisers, shipping, chemicals and heavy industries where green hydrogen, ammonia & methanol can be used to reduce emissions.



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General Manager (Perl), ANIIDCO

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Clean Energy Keeps Power Emissions Flat: Report

Press Trust of India

New Delhi: India's power-sector emissions did not increase from the first half of 2024 to the same period in 2026 due to a surge in clean energy, according to a new analysis.

The analysis by the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA), released on Thursday, said this was the first time in more than 50 years that the country's coal power did not expand over two years, even as the overall electricity demand grew.

However, India's emissions rose by 3.7% year-

on-year in the first half of 2026 because of a surge from steel, cement and other sectors, it added. The analysis, carried out by CREA analysts Lauri Myllyvirta and Anubha Aggarwal, highlighted that clean energy met all of the 7-per cent rise in India's electricity demand over the two years, adding 63 terawatt-hours (TWh).

"The period from the first half of 2024 to the first half of 2026 saw the largest increase in non-fossil power generation on record in India.... Solar grew by 44TWh, alongside growth from wind (13TWh), nuclear (7TWh) and hydro (8TWh)," the analysis said.



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GOVT TO ENSURE MERCHANTS DO NOT PASS ON CHARGES

MDR Rollout will be Monitored to Protect Users

TAX ISSUES Levy of goods & services tax on MDR can be taken up by GST Council, ITC may be used by merchants

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The government would closely monitor the rollout of Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) from October 15 to ensure that merchants do not pass these charges to customers, officials said.

"We are in touch with payment aggregators. The rollout would be closely monitored," an official said, adding that MDR is necessary to help the fintech ecosystem sustain and grow.

The official said any issue with regard to levy of goods and services tax on MDR can be taken up by the GST Council. He said input tax credit can be used by merchants to offset their tax liability.

Since transactions below ₹2,000 have been exempted from the levy of MDR, small merchants would not face GST, he said.

The government in a statement said the reintroduction of MDR on



Unified Payment Interface, or UPI, transactions is a step in protecting the country's sovereignty in the electronic payment ecosystem, rejecting charges by opposition that levy had been introduced under external influence.

"Contrary to misleading claims that MDR has been introduced un-

der external pressure, introduction of MDR on select high-value transactions will enable more domestic companies to operate under United Payment Interface," a finance ministry statement said.

It said the government has promoted RuPay credit and debit cards to show that people have a strong do-

mestic alternative. "In order that the RuPay credit cards continue to grow, the debit card has been kept free of MDR," it added.

On allegations that the MDR has been introduced because of external pressure, citing an US Trade Representative (USTR) report of 2026, the ministry said there is a clear policy of only allowing RuPay credit card on UPI to enable RuPay credit card to become the preferred choice of credit card amongst users in India. "Had the government been under pressure, it would have allowed foreign cards to use UPI, a key issue flagged in the report," an official said, adding that while RuPay debit card payments will not face MDR, they will be for foreign debit cards would.

On the issue of the National Payment Corporation of India (NPCI) market-share limitation of 30% for third-party application providers, the ministry stated that while NPCI had mandated market share limitation of 30% for third-party applica-

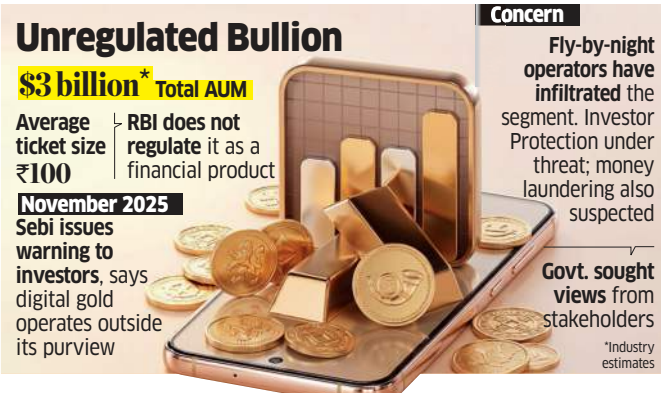
tion providers in November 2020, this mandate could not be implemented because companies other than the market leaders could not compete in absence of self-sustaining revenue model.

"Introduction of MDR on select high-value transactions will provide a self-sustaining revenue model to smaller companies to compete for higher share in the UPI ecosystem," it said, adding that the introduction of MDR would allow more domestic companies to expand their operations.

On Monday, the government issued a notification that all RuPay debit card transactions and UPI payments up to ₹2,000 will be exempt from any direct or indirect charges by banks or system providers.

Subsequently, NPCI announced a MDR of 0.4% on person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI transactions above ₹2,000. For transactions of ₹75,000 and above, the MDR will be capped at ₹300 per transaction.

Digital Gold Every Unit may Need Backing of Physical Bullion



Finance ministry seeks views from regulators, banks and other stakeholders

Dheeraj Tiwari

New Delhi: The government has begun discussions on tightening the rules for digital gold, including requiring every unit to be backed by physical bullion and bringing the product under the joint oversight of the central bank and the securities market regulator, people familiar with the matter said.

The finance ministry has sought views from regulators, banks and other stakeholders and the broad consensus is that digital gold should be recognised as a security under the Securities Contracts (Regulation) Act, 1956, they said.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India in 2025 had warned investors about dealing in digital gold. In its circular, the regulator stated that such products were different from Sebi-regulated gold products, as they were neither notified as securities nor regulated as commodity derivatives. "They operate entirely outside the purview of Sebi," it said.

According to industry estimates, the digital gold industry manages around \$3 billion of assets. The average ticket size is ₹100. "There is a consensus among all stakeholders that digital gold has gained acceptance among investors, and currently it is an unregulated segment which should be brought under the supervision of regulatory authorities," said a

bank executive, requesting anonymity. "We have submitted our recommendation to the government," he added.

Another executive said due to lack of regulatory supervision, some fly-by-night operators also infiltrated the segment, which led to concerns over investor protection and even money laundering. "Bringing it under the supervision of both RBI and Sebi will ensure that there is no regulatory arbitrage and also end uncertainty among all legal participants, including investors," he added.

The industry is also in favour of some regulatory supervision.

"The digital gold and silver ecosystem in India needs some regulatory oversight urgently considering its acceptance with consumers and the numbers of retail consumers who are onboarded with various players," said Samit Guha, managing director of MMTC-PAMP, one of the major players in digital gold. Digital gold platforms this year formed a self-regulatory organisation, the Digital Precious Metals Assurance Council of India, which includes bullion providers like MMTC-PAMP and SafeGold and platforms such as PhonePe, BharatPe, MobiKwik, Gullak, Lenden Club and CREDE.

Guha said the council is looking to standardise processes and procedures around buying, selling and storing of gold and other related processes to be the best in class so that customer interests are fully protected.

BID TO CURB ILLICIT SUPPLY CHAINS

AI, Tech to Scan Cargo Without Disrupting Trade: CBIC Chairman

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India plans to significantly expand the use of artificial intelligence, advanced image analytics and non-intrusive scanning technologies to detect illicit trade, Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) chairman Vivek Chaturvedi said at Ficci-CASCADE's 'MASCRA-DE 2026'.

The government is working towards a phased system that could eventually scan every consignment entering the country, Chaturvedi said.

The shift is aimed at moving customs enforcement from physical inspection towards intelligence-led, technology-driven risk assessment, he said, stressing that the objective is not merely to increase seizures and arrests but to disrupt illicit supply chains.

He said customs inspections at the borders are not to slow down commerce, but to make the movement of legitimate commerce faster, safer and predictable," Chaturvedi said, adding that smuggled goods create a parallel supply chain. "Success should never be

measured simply by what we seize, but also by what we are able to prevent," he said.

In 2024-25, the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence booked more than 3,000 commercial cases involving about ₹4,000 crore in duty, export and incentive amounts, which otherwise would have contributed to public revenues and services.

The CBIC chief said illicit trade has evolved beyond the conventional movement of prohibited goods across borders. Criminal networks are increasingly exploiting legitimate logistics infrastructure and documentation to facilitate this.

He asked businesses to share with enforcement agencies any information they might have about counterfeit goods being smuggled into the country. Apart from significant health risks, proceeds from the sale of these items are often used to fund organised crime and terrorism.

"The fight against illicit trade is not merely an economic imperative, nor should it be viewed simply through the lens of revenue loss. It is a security imperative. It is a governance imperative, an imperative for peace and stability across the globe," said Anil Rajput, chairman, Ficci-CASCADE.

maintaining these facilities. National highway or central agencies will also have to identify locations on NHs and expressways where stray cattle or other animals frequent, mark these locations on the PM Gati Shakti platform and arrange for the animals to be transported to designated shelters. State administrations will be responsible for maintaining cattle-

US Tariff Threat Puts Exporters on the Edge

Kirtika Suneja

New Delhi: The impact of potential new tariffs on Indian exports under the US' Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act can be assessed only after Washington announces the actual levies, product coverage and implementation timetable, said trade watchers.

The US Congress passed the Act Wednesday allowing sanctions on Russia's crude exports and tariffs of up to 100% on India, China, and other major buyers of Russian energy. The bill will now be sent to US President Donald Trump for his assent.

Experts cautioned that Washington can weaponise the new Act for an unequal trade agreement with India and can still take future action under Section 301, sectoral measures or other trade laws against New Delhi, similar to its moves against the EU, Japan and South Korea. "This is a cause of concern as it adds to uncertainty," said

id Ajay Sahai, director general, Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO). "It also raises questions at the viability of those exports which are subject to 100% tariffs."

Apparel Export Promotion Council chairman A Sakthivel said the law is a tool with the US to pressure India to reduce tariffs on American goods. Exporters said some front loading of shipments may happen if the tariffs are actually imposed. "We are monitoring the situation," said an official. Sanjay K Jain, managing director at TT Ltd, said the law gives leverage and legislative backing to Washington to impose tariffs. "However, the US is facing high inflation, and any such move will add fuel to fire besides causing uncertainty," he said. Think-tank GTRI cautioned that the US will now proceed to threaten India with tariffs of up to 100% and eventually offer a lower rate if New Delhi cuts Russian oil purchases and accepts concessions under a deeply unequal bilateral trade deal.



India Proposes 8 Guardrails in Softening of Stance on Plurilateral Pacts at WTO

Our Bureau

New Delhi: In a softening of its stance on plurilateral agreements at the World Trade Organization (WTO), India has proposed eight

safeguards, including preserving consensus-based decision-making, the multilateral charter of the trade body, the rights and agency of non-participants, and development, including special and differential treatment. In a

submission on guidelines for plurilateral initiatives, India said these "can provide greater predictability to proponents, enable non-participants to understand and protect their rights and interests; preserve attention to existing mandates

and support confidence in the WTO as a member-driven, inclusive and development-oriented multilateral institution".

Such safeguards, according to New Delhi, can contribute to confidence building. India has opposed plurilat-

eral trade agreements, which are negotiated and implemented by smaller groups rather than the entire WTO membership, saying these should remain exceptions, not the norm, and instead be based on consensus.

Rural Jobs Scheme: Chouhan Orders Random Checks to Curb Fraud

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Rural development minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan directed officials to conduct random inspections of work being undertaken under the Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar & Aajeevika Mission (Gramin), or (VB-G RAM G) scheme, saying fraud will not be tolerated.

Addressing officials from states and union territories at a national workshop on VB-G RAM G on Thursday, Chouhan stressed the need to establish a robust monitoring and inspection mechanism from the outset. "Fraud in the scheme would not be tolerated at any cost," he said.

The VB-G RAM G Act, 2025, came into effect in July and replaced the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA), 2005. "I am clearly saying as the minister that if there is any fraud, no one will be spared. Action will be taken against anyone who indulges in irregularities," said Chouhan.

The minister said officials should appreciate those implementing works in accordance with prescribed standards and procedures. At the same time, he called for strict action at the earliest wherever irregularities are found to prevent future violations of the rules.

Chouhan also emphasised that workers should be provided employment without unnecessary delays and should not remain without work even for an hour. He stressed the need to ensure timely payment of wages as well.



Low Fertility Prompts Call to Abandon Population Control

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India should abandon population control as an objective of state policy and realign its family planning framework with the country's changing demographic reality, said Sanjeev Sanyal, Member of the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM), suggesting the government roll-back population control rules and incentives amid a sharp drop in the national fertility rate.

"We need to overcome our population control mindset and align our policy objectives with the new demographic reality," according to a

working paper, titled "The Ghost of Population Past", by Sanyal and co-authored by Aakanksha Arora, director, EAC-PM and Virat Singh, consultant, EAC-PM.

"The historical experience of other countries shows that once fertility declines below a behavioural tipping point, and alters social norms, it is very difficult to reverse," the paper said, stressing that there's no need to suppress the total fertility rate (TFR) any further and risk falling into a low-fertility trap sooner. The paper emphasised that the government must end sterilisation-linked incentive payments by rolling back all direct benefit

transfer payments, including acceptor payments, wage-loss compensations, and enhanced incentives to acceptors and service providers, related to sterilisations. "Repeal motivational payments and incentive payments tied to terminal methods and the ASHA incentive related to limiting couples to two children," it said.

"Discontinue all family-planning related awards, World Population Day celebrations and Vasectomy Fortnight observances that call for population control along with repealing the two-child norm disqualifications across all states," it said.

The paper also called for removing all fertility reduction, population

control or 'stabilisation' language from national and state policy frameworks and outputs.

"We would like to point out that we are not against family planning for reasons of health, child spacing or personal preference," it said, adding that population control is no longer relevant as an objective of state policy.

According to the paper, the national total fertility rate (TFR) is currently at 1.9, well below replacement fertility. In the absence of Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, the TFR stands at 1.6.

"This is comparable to Northern Europe (1.5) and the United States (1.6)," the paper said.

EPFO Wage Ceiling Raised to ₹25,000

New Delhi: The ministry of labour and employment on Thursday notified the higher wage ceiling of ₹25,000 per month under the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation, paving the way for bringing over 10 million more formal sector workers into the social security net. —Our Bureau

FinMin to Hold Two-day Meet on Policy Priorities

New Delhi: The finance ministry will organise a two-day conference of finance ministers and finance secretaries of states and Union Territories with legislators on September 18-19 to deliberate policy priorities for India's development journey towards Viksit Bharat. —Our Bureau

Auto PLI Investments Cross ₹45,000 crore

New Delhi: Investments driven by the automobile production linked incentive scheme have crossed ₹45,000 crore, Union heavy industries minister H D Kumaraswamy said Thursday. "Investments under the scheme have now exceeded ₹45,000 crore with several original equipment manufacturers manufacturing electric vehicles," he said. —Our Bureau

Road Map Laid Out to Keep Stray Animals Off National Highways

National highway agencies will remove stray cattle and other animals, while state and local authorities will provide shelters and trace owners

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The ministry of road transport and highways has laid out a coordinated mechanism to prevent stray-animal incursions and ensure their safe removal from national highways and expressways, aimed at reducing accidents and fatalities caused by animals on roads.

"The recurring presence of stray cattle and other animals on national highway (NH) carriageways poses a serious and continuing threat to road safety," it said in a notification.

The standard operating procedures follow a 2025 Supreme Court directive to the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) to devise a structured mechanism

for the safe removal of stray animals from national highways and expressways.

Under the notification, management of stray or abandoned animals is a state subject, while national highways are the responsibility of the central government and NHAI. "This SOP bridges that constitutional divide by delineating a clear, non-overlapping

division of responsibilities between NH agencies and state or local authorities," it said.

National highway agencies will be responsible for removing stray cattle and other animals from NHs and transporting them to shelters, pounds or gaushalas designated by the state government, as applicable. State, district or local administrations will be responsible for identifying, establishing and ma-

intaining these facilities.

National highway or central agencies will also have to identify locations on NHs and expressways where stray cattle or other animals frequent, mark these locations on the PM Gati Shakti platform and arrange for the animals to be transported to designated shelters.

State administrations will be responsible for maintaining cattle-

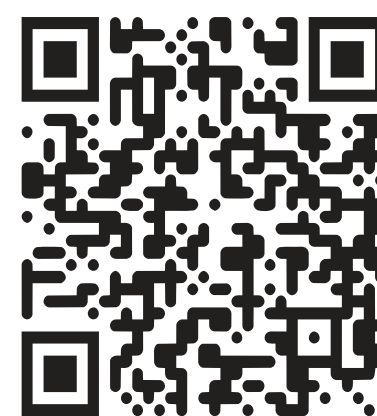
pound records, tracing owners and initiating action to recover applicable fees, fines and penalties under relevant cattle-trespass legislation.

National highway agencies will undertake round-the-clock surveillance through route patrol vehicles on designated stretches and through the advanced traffic management system, wherever available.

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Did LVMH Fashion Hermès Heir’s Vanishing Share Act?

In a June court filing, luxury-goods giant LVMH forcefully denied it had ever tried to acquire shares in rival Hermès from that company’s founding-family heir Nicolas Puech, who alleges he was fleeced of his 6% stake – now worth billions – through schemes involving his late wealth manager.

“The group never contemplated acquiring Nicolas Puech’s stake, let alone against his will,” LVMH stated in the filing, responding to a lawsuit Puech filed last year in France. But LVMH signed a 2002 agreement to purchase the heir’s shares, legal documents show, in a deal LVMH representatives crafted with Puech’s financial advisor, Eric Freymond, who died last year. Further, the records reveal, LVMH and its chairman’s family holding company paid Freymond’s management firm at least \$20 million in commissions and fees between 2001 and 2009 as Freymond helped LVMH secretly build a massive stake in Hermès.

The 2002 agreement for Puech’s shares and the scale of the Freymond payments are reported here for the first time. Taken together, they show LVMH’s relationship with Puech’s wealth manager and confidant was more extensive than previously known and raise questions about recent LVMH denials of any attempt to buy Puech’s Hermès stake.

There are revelations mark the latest plot twist in a bitter corporate rivalry between the luxury-goods giants dating back a quarter century, when LVMH first started covertly building



LVMH CEO Bernard Arnault

king control of LVMH in the late 1980s, shortly after its founding in a merger of Louis Vuitton and Moët Hennessy. Today, LVMH is the world’s biggest luxury firm, with over 75 brands selling everything from clothes and leather goods to champagne and perfume, and Arnault is among Europe’s richest people.

Hermès, mostly run by members of its founding family, has become one of France’s most valuable listed companies, alongside LVMH, thanks to a focus on ultra-wealthy shoppers and the enduring appeal of its handmade Birkin and Kelly handbags. **Reuters**

ding its Hermès stake. Hermès fended off what it called a hostile takeover by LVMH chairman and CEO Bernard Arnault after the billionaire surprised investors in October 2010 by disclosing a 17% stake in the smaller rival. LVMH accumulated as much as 23% in Hermès before agreeing to liquidate its stake in a 2014 truce. The mystery surrounding the fortune the Hermès heir says is missing continues to play out in Paris courts, raising fresh questions over whether and how his shares ended up as part of the LVMH stake in Hermès.

Arnault had built a luxury empire through acquisitions, starting with Christian Dior before taking

king control of LVMH in the late 1980s, shortly after its founding in a merger of Louis Vuitton and Moët Hennessy. Today, LVMH is the world’s biggest luxury firm, with over 75 brands selling everything from clothes and leather goods to champagne and perfume, and Arnault is among Europe’s richest people.

Hermès, mostly run by members of its founding family, has become one of France’s most valuable listed companies, alongside LVMH, thanks to a focus on ultra-wealthy shoppers and the enduring appeal of its handmade Birkin and Kelly handbags. **Reuters**

CENTRAL RAILWAY
BHUSAWAL DIVISION
NOTICE INVITING E-TENDERS
TENDER NO. BSL-L-WT-82-2026

1) **Name of Work:** Electrification work in connection with Providing Continuous Covered Shed along Passenger Circulation Path within Railway Premises at Kasbe Sukene, Kherwadi, Odha, Nashik & Devlali (2500x6M). ; 2) **Estimated Cost:-** ₹46,16,159; 3) **Last Date & time for closing of tender:-** 12/10/2026 at 15:00 Hrs. 4) **Website particulars :** [https:// www.ireps.gov.in](https://www.ireps.gov.in)

TRAVEL SAFELY, AVOID FOOTBOARD TRAVELLING

**BRIHANMUMBAI MUNICIPAL CORPORATION**

No. Ch.E/B.M/9911/II dtd 17/09/2026

Short tender Notice

Department	Ch.E. (Building Maintenance).
Sub-Department	Dy.Ch.E. (Building Maintenance)Subs.
Tender No.	2026_MCGM_1338627
Subject	Proposal for construction of Composite Cemetery at Oswal Compound on plot bearing C.T.S. no 381(pt.) & 381 (11) of village Anik, at R.C. Chembur.
Tender- Sale	18.09.2026 from 11.00 am to 13.10.2026 up to 16.00 pm
Pre-bid meeting	29.09.2026 at 3:00 PM in meeting room of Office of the Ch.E.(B.M), MCGM, 3 rd floor, Engineering Hub, Worli.
Website	https://mahatenders.gov.in
Concern Person	Sub Engineer - (B.M) E.S.
Name	Rakecha.H.S.
Telephone No.	9511690499.
Email- id	Se08es.bm@mcgm.gov.in.
PRO/1463/ADV/2026-27	Sd/-
LET’S TOGETHER MAKE MUMBAI MALARIA FREE	Dy.Ch.E. (B.M.) Subs

Chinese AI Developers Not Yet Advanced Enough to Pose Risk: Huawei’s Eric Xu

Shanghai | Beijing: Huawei’s Eric Xu said Chinese AI developers may not yet be advanced enough to experience the safety risks reported by leading US firms, arguing they should continue developing more powerful models while balancing innovation against risk. “If we look at the mainst-

ream AI model providers in the US, because they have massive computing power, maybe only they themselves know where they are in terms of the level of their models,” Xu, Huawei’s rotating chairman, said at the firm’s Connect conference in Shanghai. **Reuters**



**Thane Municipal Corporation, Thane**

Health department & Births and Death Department
Second Extension

Under the Health Department of Thane Municipal Corporations, the Birth and Death Department has invited online tenders for the operation, maintenance, repair and unkeep of 3 machines for a period of 5 years, namely : 1 PNG gas-operated crematorium, 1 wet scrubber and 1 wet scrubber for the traditional 4 chulha furnace. The tender is being invited through the online e-tendering system on the website <https://mahatenders.gov.in> Due to poor response during the tender notice period the Second extension is being given from 17/09/2026 to 23/09/2026 at 16.00 hrs. Am Received tenders will be opened on 24/09/2026 at 11.00 hrs.

TMC/PRO/Health/537/2026-27 **Sd/-**

Dated 17/09/2026 **Medical Officer of Health,**

pls visit our official web-site Thane Municipal Corporation **www.thanecity.gov.in**

SILIGURI JALPAIGURI DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
AUCTION NOTICE

FOR TRANSFER OF LAND PURSUANT TO THE ORDER OF THE HON'BLE SUPREME COURT OF INDIA DATED 03.09.2026, IN THE SPECIAL LEAVE PETITION (CIVIL) DIARY NO. 46595/2024 IN THE MATTER OF: **Siliguri Jalpaiguri Development Authority**, a statutory body of Urban Development and Municipal Affairs Department, Government of West Bengal, constituted under West Bengal Town and Country (Planning and Development) Act, 1979, having its registered office at Tenzing Norgay Central Bus Terminus, Pradhan Nagar, Siliguri, 734003 presently at Himanchal Vihar, Near – Passport Seva Laghu Kendra, Matigara-734010.

Vs

Bengal Intitech Universal Siliguri Projects Limited, a company registered under the Companies Act 1956 having its registered office at 6, Community Centre, Saket, New Delhi, 110017 and also at Horizons Tower 7, Unit Nos. 001 & 002, Action Area III, Major Arterial Road, New Town, Rajanhat, Kolkata-700160.

INVITATION FOR TRANSFER OF LAND MEASURING ABOUT 92.96 ACRES in two blocks namely Block-A (western side) & Block-B (eastern side) each block having area more or less 46.48 acres ON LEASE HOLD BASIS FOR THE PERIOD OF 99 YEARS, SITUATED AT MOUZA-DAGGRAM, J.L. NO-02, SHEET NO. 16 & 17 WITHIN P.S. NJP DIST.-JALPAIGURI, WEST BENGAL (HEREINAFTER REFERRED TO AS THE ‘SAID LAND’).

Pursuant to the order dated 3rd September 2026 passed by the Hon'ble Supreme Court of India in special leave petition (Civil) Diary No (S) 46595/2024, offers are invited for the purpose of TOWNSHIP USE, (Block A & Block B of the Township having area 92.96 acres) in respect of the ‘said land’ on ‘As is where is and whatever there is basis’ through physical Auction/open bid, process to be conducted by the Siliguri Jalpaiguri Development Authority at Conference Hall of the Siliguri Jalpaiguri Development Authority at Himanchal Vihar, near Passport Seva Laghu Kendra, Matigara, PIN 734010 **on 08.10.2026 at 14:00 hours**.

The terms & conditions of the transfer of lease hold right in respect of the ‘Said Land’ will be available from the office of the District Magistrate cum Collector Darjeeling and Jalpaiguri Districts as well as from the office of the undersigned on and from 14.09.2026 upto 07.10.2026 during 10:00 A.M to 05:00 P.M. on working days. Terms & conditions may be also downloaded from the SJDA website www.sjda.org

Earnest Money Deposit: Interested parties/bidders have to deposit the earnest money amounting to Rs. 20,000.00.00 (Rupees Twenty Crore Only) separately for each land area i.e., Block-A & Block-B. Parties interested to bid for both the blocks A & B will have to deposit Rs. 40,000.00.00 (Rs. Forty Crore only). Earnest money will have to be deposited/transferred in the Bank Account of SILIGURI JALPAIGURI DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY, bearing account no 912010035059401, in AXIS BANK, Hill Cart Road, Siliguri (W.B) branch, Siliguri 734403 having IFS code no.-UTIB0001403. Receipt of deposit of the earnest money along with relevant documents will have to be submitted on or before **11.00 hours of 08.10.2026**.

Interested parties may carry out physical inspection of the land on and from 22.09.2026 to 25.09.2026 during office hours on prior information to the Siliguri Jalpaiguri Development Authority either by mail (sjdawb@gmail.com) or through phone 0353-2515647. In case of any query designated officer namely Sri Pradeep Kumar Gupta may be contacted over mobile no.6295115845.

No. 1004/II/Eng/Pig/404/2003(Pt-V)/SJDA
Date: 11.09.2026

Sd/-
Chief Executive Officer
Siliguri Jalpaiguri Development Authority
Himanchal Vihar, near Passport Seva Laghu Kendra, Matigara-734010
E-mail: sjdawb@gmail.com

Memo No.: 1129/Adv/LSDI&CO/SLG. **Date: 17.09.2026**

Around the World

US Open to Discussing Shared AI Risks with China in Upcoming Talks: Bessent

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said the US is open to discussing shared risks with China in upcoming AI talks this weekend, Axios reported Wednesday, citing a statement from Bessent. “The US remains the leader in AI, and we are open to discussions on avoiding shared risks and avoiding bifurcation

of our two systems,” Axios added. Bessent on Tuesday said he would meet with Chinese vice premier He Lifeng this weekend ahead of a meeting between US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping next week. **Reuters**



Mahindra & Mahindra Limited

E-Auction: 24.09.2026

Die Scrap – 4665 MT

Chakan Plant

Inspection Date: 21st & 22nd September 2026

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**SBI**

Analytics Department, 8th Floor,
NEWA Bhakti Knowledge Park, Airoli, Navi Mumbai - 400708

CORRIGENDUM NOTICE

RefNo: SBI/GITC/Analytics/2026/2027/1477 Dated: 16.09.2026

Corrigendum with reference to RFP No: SBI/GITC/Analytics/2026/2027/1477 dated 25.07.2026 has been published on Bank's website. For details, please visit 'Procurement News' at <https://www.sbi.bank.in>

Place: Mumbai **Deputy General Manager**

Date: 16.09.2026 **Analytics Department (DB - Business)**

**EMBASSY**
REIT

EMBASSY OFFICE PARKS REIT

SEBI registration no. IN/REIT/17-18/0001

Principal Place of Business: 12th Floor, Pinnacle Tower, Embassy One, 8, Bellary Road, Ganganagar, Bengaluru, Karnataka-560 032.

Tel #- +91 80 6935 4864

Compliance Officer: Ms. Vinitha Menon

E-mail: nodal.officer@embassyofficeparks.com Website: www.embassyofficeparks.com

NOTICE TO UNITHOLDERS

TRANSFER OF UNCLAIMED DISTRIBUTION AMOUNT TO THE SEBI INVESTOR PROTECTION AND EDUCATION FUND

NOTICE is hereby given that in accordance with Regulation 18 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Real Estate Investment Trusts) Regulations, 2014 read with Chapter 19 of the Master Circular for Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) dated July 11, 2025, each as amended, distribution amounts remaining unpaid or unclaimed for a period of seven consecutive years are required to be transferred to the Investor Protection and Education Fund ("IPEF") established by the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI").

The distributions declared by Embassy Office Parks REIT ("Embassy REIT") for the quarter ended **June 30, 2019**, in respect of which certain amounts remain unpaid or unclaimed ("**Distribution**"), are required to be transferred to the IPEF in accordance with the applicable provisions on or before **October 17, 2026**.

Separate communication has been sent to all the concerned Unitholders via email to their registered email IDs and physical addresses on September 17, 2026, wherever available. Further, details of the concerned Unitholders and the corresponding unclaimed or unpaid Distribution amounts are available on the website of Embassy REIT at <https://www.embassyofficeparks.com/investors/distribution-history/unclaimed-distribution/> using the search facility.

The concerned Unitholders are requested to submit their claims, along with the requisite documents given under Chapter 19 of the Master Circular for REITs dated July 11, 2025, read with Policy for Processing and Claiming of Unclaimed Amounts ("**Policy**"), to Embassy REIT or its Registrar and Transfer Agent ("**RTA**"), KFin Technologies Limited, at the addresses / email IDs set out below, **on or before October 09, 2026**, to facilitate payment of the Distribution prior to its proposed transfer to the IPEF. The said Policy is accessible at <https://www.embassyofficeparks.com/esg/governance-documents/>.

In the event no valid claim is received by the aforesaid date, the unclaimed Distribution amounts shall be transferred to the IPEF in accordance with the applicable regulatory requirements. Following such transfer, the concerned Unitholders may claim the transferred Distribution amount from the IPEF in accordance with the applicable procedure given under Chapter 19 of the Master Circular for Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) dated July 11, 2025, as amended, issued by SEBI, read with the Policy.

For any queries or clarifications on the above, or to submit a claim, the concerned Unitholders may write to Embassy REIT or the RTA at the following details:

Embassy Office Parks REIT
Vinitha Menon, Head – Company Secretary and Compliance Officer
12th Floor, Pinnacle Tower, Embassy One, 8, Bellary Road, Ganganagar, Bengaluru, Karnataka – 560 032
Tel: +91 80 6935 4864. E-mail: nodal.officer@embassyofficeparks.com

Registrar and Transfer Agent
KFin Technologies Limited, Unit: Embassy Office Parks REIT, Selenium Building, Tower B, Plot No. 31-32, Gachibowli, Financial District, Nanakramguda, Hyderabad - 500 032
Tel: +91 40 6716 2505. E-mail: embassy.reit@kfintech.com

For and on behalf of Embassy Office Parks REIT acting through its Manager,
Embassy Office Parks Management Services Private Limited

Sd/-
Vinitha Menon

Head - Company Secretary and Compliance Officer
A25036

Place: Bengaluru **Date:** September 18, 2026

16001/47/2627

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MUMBAI, FRIDAY, 18 SEPTEMBER 2026

SMART INVESTING

Rupee May Need More Weakening: Axis Bank

SOME RELIEF Yield on US 10-year bonds slips below 5% even as Nov Brent crude futures trade around \$102 a barrel, down from \$105 the previous day

Market Rides Out ‘Expected’ US Rate Hike, Nifty up 0.2%

Our Bureau

Mumbai: India's equity markets ended marginally higher on Thursday as investors took the widely anticipated interest rate hike by the US Federal Reserve—the first in three years—in their stride NSE's Nifty rose 53 points or 0.2% to close at 23,270.6. BSE's Sensex fell 21.86 points or 0.03% to end at 74,314.59.

“The Fed rate hike was widely anticipated, and such expected events typically have limited impact on markets,” said Ramesh Mantri, chief investment officer at WhiteOak CapitalAMC. “Both USand Indi-an interest rates had already moved higher in anticipation of the decision.”

Other Asian markets ended mixed on Thursday. Japan advanced 0.3%, Taiwan rose 1%, while China and Hong Kong declined 0.4% each, and South Korea ended flat. The pan-European index Stoxx 600 was up 0.5% at the time of going to print.

The 25-basis-point rate hike by the Fed helped cool bond yields. Yield on the US 10-Year bond fell below 5%, snapping eight straight days of an uptrend, in response to the central bank move. The 10-year yield had soared to 5.041%, the highest level since July 2007, as elevated oil prices increased inflationary expectations, prompting traders to bet on rate hikes.

Sunny Agrawal, head of research at SBI Securities said a correction in oil prices this morning also provided some relief to Indian markets, which led to indices ending higher. Brent crude oil November futures were trading around \$102 a barrel on Thursday evening, down from the \$105 mark on Wednesday.

Foreign portfolio investors net sold shares worth ₹3,209 crore on Thursday. Domestic institutions were buyers to the tune of ₹3,618 crore. Domestically, Nifty's Volatility Index or VIX- popularly known as the 'fear gauge' of the markets- fell 7.8% to 12.14 levels on Thursday, indicating relief among derivatives participants. Broader market indices outperformed the benchmark, as Nifty Midcap 150 gained 0.9% and Nifty Small-cap 250 rose 0.8%. Out of the total 4,535 stocks traded on the BSE, 2,626 rose, and 1,712 declined at close.

While the benchmark Nifty 50 has fallen 4.2% in the past month, since geopolitical tensions have again gone up in West Asia, the midcap and small-cap indices have fallen 3.8% and 1.7% in this period. Agrawal said that going ahead, oil prices, geopolitics and domestic and global rate decisions will remain key monitorables for market participants.

THURSDAY'S OPENING AT 16.7% TO 29.5% PREMIUMS ABOVE ISSUE PRICE

Four of 6 Listings Debut at a Premium

Six companies—Manipal Payment and Identity Solutions, Asset Reconstruction Company (India), Rentomojo, Karamtara Engineering, LCC Projects and Steamhouse India—

made their stock market debuts on Thursday. LCC Projects, Karamtara Engineering, Rentomojo and Steamhouse India listed on the NSE at premiums ranging from 16.7% to

29.5% over their issue prices. Asset Reconstruction Company made a flat debut, while Manipal Payment and Identity Solutions listed at a 2.7% discount.

— Our Bureau

Company	Issue Price (₹)	Listing Price (₹)	Listing premium/ (discount)%	Closing Price (₹)	M-Cap (₹ cr)
LCC Projects	146	189.0	29.5	170.1	4,927.3
Karamtara Engineering	254	320.0	26.0	352.0	11,328.2
Rentomojo	404	482.5	19.4	534.3	5,562.3
Steamhouse India	81	94.5	16.7	102.6	2,834.6
Asset Reconstruction Company (India)	139	139.0	0.0	137.0	4,451.7
Manipal Payment & Identity Solutions	339	330.0	-2.7	345.2	8,000.7

OIL ABOVE \$100 A BARREL TO HURT IN SEPTEMBER; GAINS IN PRIOR 2 MONTHS MAY ACT AS SHIELD

Crude Shock to Hit OMC Margins, but Refining Gains could Save Q2 Show

Sachin Kumar

ET Intelligence Group: A sharp rise in crude oil prices is expected to turn marketing margins on fuels to negative in September. However, gains realised during the previous two months are likely to support earnings of the oil marketing companies (OMC) for the September quarter.

Oil prices breached \$100 a barrel this month with Brent crude at around \$107 as US–Iran clashes stoked supply fears. Retail fuel marketing margins are expected to turn into a loss of ₹7.4 per litre for petrol and ₹10.3 per litre for diesel in September, according to ICICI Securities estimates. However, it is unlikely to erase the improvement seen during the first two months of the quarter. The broker estimates marketing margins at ₹2.9 per litre for petrol and ₹1.3 per litre for diesel for each of the three OMCs in September quarter, compared with losses of ₹6.1 and ₹18.9 per litre, respectively, in the June quarter.

The June quarter was particularly difficult for OMCs because higher crude prices along with freight costs weighed heavily on marketing margins. The situation improved in the September quarter: Crude prices fell sharply to

Earnings Pulse

Performance of Oil Marketing Cos in June'26 Quarter

	Revenue (₹ lakh cr)		Net loss (₹ crore)	
	Jun'26	YoY % chg	Jun'26	YoY % chg
IOC	2.81	27.1	2,661.3	NA
BPCL	1.59	23.1	3,962.1	NA
HPCL	1.44	20.9	12,264.7	NA

NA: Not Applicable due to loss over net profit in June'25 quarter

SOURCE: Company data, ETIG

around \$68 a barrel in the first half of July, as West Asia tensions eased. This helped auto-fuel marketing margins recover sequentially. The full impact of the increase in auto-fuel prices announced in May is also expected to support OMC marketing margins in the September quarter.

Strong refining margins remain the key cushion against the deterioration in retail fuel margins. Singapore Gross Refining Margins (GRM) averaged \$24.5 per barrel during April–August, well above the FY21–26 average of \$5.6 per barrel. Rising crude oil prices compress

the GRMs of OMCs because retail prices of petroleum products such as diesel and petrol do not adjust immediately. GRM is the difference between prices of crude oil and petroleum products. Emkay Global Financial Services expects OMC margins to improve substantially to around ₹9–14 per litre in the current quarter, compared with ₹1–3 per litre in the June quarter. Each of the three OMCs including Indian Oil Corporation, Bharat Petroleum Corporation and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation reported net losses in the June quarter amid suppressed marketing margins.

0.02% MDR ON CAPITAL MARKET TRANSACTIONS

New UPI Fee Raises Broker Concerns, Sebi to Examine

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) will examine concerns raised by discount brokers over the new merchant discount rate for big fund transfers through UPI (unified payments interface), its chief Tuhin Kanta Pandey said Thursday.

“I think there are some important issues there. We will certainly look into it and see how we can ease them,” Pandey said on the sidelines of an event.

Under the new framework, capital market transactions, including payments to stockbrokers, mutual funds, investment advisors and dealers, will attract an MDR of 0.02%, capped at ₹300 per transaction, from October 15.

Stockbrokers operating on wafer-thin margins have approached Sebi raising concerns the charge could disproportionately increase their costs since money transferred by a client to a broking account does not necessarily result in a trade.



I think there are some important issues there. We will certainly look into it and see how we can ease them

TUHIN KANTA PANDEY
Chairman, Sebi

“The problem with broking is that there is no guarantee that money transferred to a broker will actually result in a transaction. As brokers, we can't force a customer to trade after transferring money. And if we can't pass the UPI charge on to the customer, there is essentially no limit to the cost a customer can impose on a broker without generating any revenue,” Nithin Kamath, founder of discount broking platform Zerodha, wrote in a post on his social media handle.

“What makes this even more challenging is quarterly settlement. This is a Sebi regulation that requires brokers to send unused funds back to clients every month or quarter. Most customers then transfer these funds back to their broking accounts, with more than half of these transfers happening through UPI. So, regulation essentially forces this movement of money every month or quarter, and the broker could end up bearing the cost when the money comes back, without any incremental benefit or revenue,” Kamath said.

In a separate development, the Sebi chairman said the regulator has not received any proposal from the National Stock Exchange (NSE) seeking regulatory approval to trade on its own platform after getting listed. “No, there is no such letter and there is no such requirement,” Pandey said.

The NSE stock will be listed on its rival, the Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE). Unlike the Australian bourse which listed its stock on its own platform in 1998, India allows only cross-listing, and the BSE stock is listed on the NSE. Pandey added that such trading cannot be permitted at present. The NSE's ₹22,569-crore IPO opened for public subscription Thursday.

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₹22,561-CR ISSUE TO STAY OPEN TILL SEPT 21

NSE IPO Subscribed 0.43 Times on Day 1

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The National Stock Exchange's ₹22,561-crore IPO was subscribed 0.43 times on Thursday, the first day of subscription, with the non-institutional investor (NII) category receiving the highest amount of bids. The issue received bids for 3.70 crore shares against 8.86 crore shares on offer, according to subscription data available on NSE as of 7 pm on Thursday.

The qualified institutional buyers (QIBs) portion was subscribed 0.19 times, while the NII category was subscribed 0.72 times. The retail investor portion was subscribed 0.44 times, according to NSE data.

The issue will remain open until Sep 21, and the shares will list on the BSE on Sep 24.

The IPO is entirely an offer for sale (OFS) of 12.64 crore shares by 10 existing shareholders, with a price band of ₹1,700–1,785 per share. There is no fresh issue, which means NSE will not receive any pro-



ceeds from the IPO. After issue-related expenses, the proceeds will go to the selling shareholders.

The issue size was cut 15% from the 14.89 crore shares proposed in the draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) filed in June 2026.

NSE's share sale on Wednesday drew more than 150 anchor investors, with overseas funds collectively garnering 43% of the stock on offer for this category of bidders. Bidders for the anchor book included sovereign wealth funds, global asset managers and long-only funds from the US, Europe and Asia, which helped the country's bourse garner ₹6,746.18 crore. Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) accounted for ₹2,883 crore, or 43% of the anchor book.

THE ECONOMIC TIMES

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TO ABSORB TRADE SHOCKS

Rupee May Need More Weakening: Axis Bank

Our Bureau

Kolkata: The rupee may need to depreciate further to adjust to the sustained terms of trade shocks even as the trade-weighted real effective exchange rate (REER) index fell to 91.75, a level last seen during the 2013 taper tantrum, Axis Bank said in a research report.

The rupee has weakened nearly 6% this year. "As of March, depreciation to a new fair value had likely been completed – though a sustained terms of trade shock and a loss of 5% in relative AI productivity theoretically translate to another 10% weakening of the REER in a year's time," said Tanay Dalal, economist at the private sector lender.

The REER has weakened to 91.8 in July this year from a tad lower of 102 in April 2025. Dalal said subsequent terms of trade and productivity shifts could drive further fair value weakening ahead. "Part of the problem might be misalignment of neutral rates required for the domestic growth and inflation balance with global trends," he said. The Reserve Bank of India is estimated to have sold \$250 billion since mid-2023 to defend the local currency, nearly double of the inflows seen through the dedicated dollar-inflows programme run between June and August, according to Dalal.

Rupee Edges Up on RBI Support, Softer Oil Prices

Mumbai: The Indian rupee closed slightly stronger Thursday on the back of reported interventions by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and a modest retreat in oil prices, traders said. The currency closed at 95.93, little changed from its previous close of 95.95, according to Reuters. Oil prices cooled to around \$103 per barrel, from around \$107 per barrel the previous day, which also supported bond yields. The 10-year benchmark bond yield closed at 7.04%, versus its previous close of 7.06%, CCIIL data showed. The rupee traded in the range of 96.10 and 95.78 during the day, with state-run banks actively selling dollars at levels weaker than 96, traders said. The dollar index increased to 100.17, from 99.65 a day earlier. —Our Bureau

TIME TO YIELD A lower interest rate differential may make it harder to attract investments
RBI's Rate-Hike Moment could be Near as Fed Steps up the Pressure

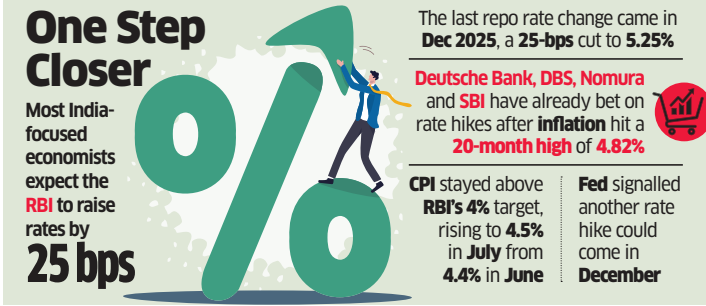
Rozebud Gonsalves & Atmadip Ray

Kolkata | Mumbai: Calls for India to join central bank peers from Tokyo to London in tightening rates have grown louder after Washington, despite looming midterm polls, pivoted toward a restrictive monetary policy in the first increase in three years Wednesday, spotlighting the urgency for a sufficiently wide yield gap that would justify sustained foreign investments in the country.

After the expected announcement by Fed Chair Kevin Warsh, the US 10-year yield inched higher with the markets pricing in more rate increases, as the Federal Reserve seeks to balance its twin objectives of price stability and full employment through a period of potentially inflationary geopolitics.

"For India, this probably means bringing the start of the rate hike cycle closer as the rate differential eases, leading to renewed pressure on currency," Yes Bank chief economist Indranil Pan said.

The European Central Bank,



Bank of Japan, the Reserve Bank of Australia, the Reserve Bank of New Zealand and Norges Bank (the central bank of Norway) have already taken the contractionary policy path. The Fed, which joined Wednesday, also signalled more tightening likely in December.

Most India-focused economists expect Mint Road to increase the local policy rate by 25 basis points. The last time the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) changed the repo rate was in December 2025 when it had softened by 25 bps to 5.25%.

"A 25 bps hike in October by the RBI

looks more likely, but we also expect this to be a shallow hiking cycle (50-75 bps) and will await more clarity at the October review," Madhavi Arora, lead economist at Emkay Global Financial Services, said Thursday. Economists at Deutsche Bank, DBS, Nomura and State Bank of India expect a rate hardening after retail inflation hit a 20-month high of 4.82%.

"In light of the faster surge in food and oil prices, and higher super core momentum, we are changing our repo rate call to a 25 bps hike each in October and December from a hold," Nomura's research analyst

Sonal Varma said a couple of days ago. "We assign a 60% probability to a 25 bp rate hike in October versus 40% to a rate hold, implying this remains a close call," she said.

THE PRICE PINCH

India's retail inflation measured by Consumer Price Index was 4.5% in July and 4.4% in June. Now, it's a third month in a row that CPI remained over 4%, which is the central target under the RBI's flexible inflation targeting framework.

Food price inflation jumped to 6% from 5.5% a month prior, led by sugar and vegetables, and core inflation rose to 4.2% from 3.9%.

"Add to this, recent developments including a sustained rise in crude prices, tightening global financial conditions, firm domestic growth and signs of broadening in core pressures, strengthen the case for a shallow 50 bps hike in second half of FY27, making October's meeting a live one," DBS Bank senior economist Radhika Rao said.

Varma, too, expected a shallow rate hiking cycle of 50 bps in October and December.

Higher energy bills and rising fuel prices expected to push UK inflation higher
Bank of England Keeps Interest Rate at 3.75%

AP

London: The Bank of England kept the UK's main interest rate unchanged at 3.75 per cent Thursday even though inflation in the United Kingdom has risen to a five-month high as the fallout from the Iran war continues to ratchet up fuel prices.

Like other central banks, the inflation outlook will be key for the Bank of England. Some have already decided to start raising borrowing costs again, including the US Federal Reserve on Wednesday.

Many economists are forecasting UK inflation to rise from the current annual rate of 3.1 per cent, which is already above the Bank of England's target of 2%, in coming months as households face another increase in their domestic energy bills beginning in October.

As a result, the consensus in financial markets is that interest



rates will be raised at one of the next two meetings, either in November or December.

David Rees, head of global economics at Schroders, expected the central bank to leave rates where they were because the economic backdrop, such as wages and the labour market, remains relatively soft.

"That should limit the extent to which imported price pressures become embedded in domestic wages and prices," he said. Like other central banks, the inflation outlook will be key for the Bank of England.

Day Trading Guide

Kotak Securities

Tech Picks

AMOL ATHAWALE
VP-Technical Research

BLUESTARCO

A rounding bottom formation on the daily charts suggests the stock is gaining traction for up move.

LAST CLOSE ▶ ₹1,554

STOP LOSS ▶ ₹1,520

BUY
TARGET
₹1,620

ZYDUSLIFE

On daily scale, stock is near multiple support levels, signalling a potential up move in the near term.

LAST CLOSE ▶ ₹1,136

STOP LOSS ▶ ₹1,110

BUY
TARGET
₹1,180

JUBLFOOD

Stock has reversed from a key retracement zone, signalling further upside in the coming session.

LAST CLOSE ▶ ₹482

STOP LOSS ▶ ₹470

BUY
TARGET
₹500

F&O Strategy

SAHAJ AGRAWAL
VP Derivatives Research

NSEFUT ICICIPRULI (SEPT)

After a recent decline, the stock has staged a sharp rebound from lower levels with strong bullish candle.

LAST CLOSE ▶ ₹494.1

STOP LOSS ▶ ₹477

BUY
TARGET
₹520

NSEFUT APOLLOHOSP (SEPT)

The stock is maintaining its uptrend, with the short-term structure indicating further upside.

LAST CLOSE ▶ ₹8,828

STOP LOSS ▶ ₹8,520

BUY
TARGET
₹9,290

PANELLISTS FLAG SHORTCOMINGS AT NaBFID CONCLAVE

‘Need Long-Term Funds to Finance Infra Work’

Our Bureau

Mumbai: India's infrastructure financing needs are rising even as the pool of long-term liabilities in the financial system is shrinking, creating a potential mismatch for projects that require funding over decades. More than 90% of bank deposits and debt now have maturities of less than three years, compared with 60-65% earlier. During a panel discussion at the NaBFID Infrastructure Conclave, ICICI Prudential Life Insurance managing director and CEO Anup Bagchi said the financial sector needs to build a larger pool of long-term liabilities to support infrastructure assets.

"Today almost 90% plus of the deposits and debt are less than three years now. It used to be 60-65%. So clearly it is shortening. If you don't generate liabilities for the long run, how do you generate demand for these assets?" Bagchi said. He said insurance and pension products could help create longer-term liabilities and suggested tax advantages for insurance policies with tenures of 10 years or

more to encourage long-term savings. "And when we look at liabilities for the long term, then we should also see that there is any tax advantage between asset classes," he said.

The scale of infrastructure investment required in India would be substantially higher than current government spending, said Dinesh Pant managing director, LIC. "We really need to re-look into the type of instruments that are available, the ecosystem of governance," Pant said.

He also flagged the need to balance infrastructure funding requirements with the interests of policyholders.

The industry needs to create a governance structure, which ensures that these desired outcomes are balanced between the borrowers or the investment requirements for the sector plus people who are going to invest, he said.

Executives said that insurers need to manage credit, tenor, interest-rate and liquidity risks before increasing direct exposure to infrastructure.

Dollar Bonds to Lose Some Lustre as US Yields Surge

Indian issuers unlikely to back off completely; many think dollar bond issue this year could break \$22b record of 2021

Joel Rebello

Mumbai: Overseas bond sales, which bankers believe appear to be on course for an annual record, could moderate after the US Federal Reserve's first rate increase in three years expectedly inflates debt-raising costs for Indian companies.

Bank of Maharashtra priced its debut, five-year bond raising \$500 million Thursday at 130 basis points above the five-year US treasury. With the five-year US treasury at 4.80%, the bonds are likely to be priced around 6.10%.

This is a big difference from August 24, when Union Bank of India raised \$300 million by selling five-year

bonds at 102 basis points above the five-year benchmark security. Back then, the instrument was trading around 4.39%, making a final yield of 5.41% on the bond.

So far this year, dollar bond issuances from India have crossed \$20 billion, mainly on the back of the concessional swap windows opened by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to support leverage programmes for foreign currency deposits.

To be sure, bankers still expect the total funds raised this year from overseas to top the record \$22 billion garnered in 2021.

However, the recent surge in US yields could change the math for issuers. "At these higher treasury levels, there could be some moderation in



issuance activity, especially from issuers who are fixed-rate borrowers and who have access to onshore rupee liquidity, as dollar bonds on a post-swap basis may not be as attractive from a pricing standpoint as straight rupee financing," said Vinod Venkatesh, co-head of financing solutions, HSBC India.

Benchmark US treasuries have risen sharply in the last month in anticipation of a Fed hike, which was delivered on Wednesday.

Yield on the benchmark 10-year US Treasury has increased beyond 5% for the first time in 19 years while the five-year bond was trading around 4.80% - the highest in more than three

years as traders priced in higher interest rates.

"The all-in cost for issuers has definitely gone up, but that is not all. Issuers will also look at the outlook for the market. The fact is that one big uncertainty is off the table with the US Fed hike," said a senior capital market executive at a foreign bank. "Issuers who need funds may now like to frontload and take the risk of fundraising off the table because going forward, no one can predict how high rates can go."

Bankers say that Indian issuers will still look at the spread over the US treasuries and weigh in future risks while deciding on issuances. Venkatesh from HSBC said his bank does not expect activity to stop completely.

Tata Stocks Rise

►► From ET Markets Page 1

A potential listing of Tata Sons could benefit Tata Chemicals, Tata Steel and Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles most directly, as they own 2.5-3.1% stakes in the holding company. Tata Chemicals' 2.5% stake is estimated at around ₹25,300 crore, while Tata Steel and Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles each hold 3.1% stakes worth around ₹30,600 crore.

Shares of Shapoorji Pallonji Group companies also gained. Gokak Textiles rose 9% and Afcons Infrastructure gained 3.3%, while Forbes & Co and Eureka Forbes closed marginally lower. The SP Group owns an estimated 18.37% of Tata Sons, and a potential listing could provide the debt-laden group a liquid route to monetise its stake. "Tata Sons could be valued at about ₹12.5 lakh crore, according to calculations cited by Deven Choksey, managing director at DRChoksey FinServ. At that valuation, the 11.94% stake held by seven listed Tata Group companies would be worth around ₹1.49 lakh crore.

However, the differences between Tata Trusts and Tata Sons could delay some of the group's future plans, particularly projects involving large capital expenditure and requiring Tata Trusts' consent, said Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments.

Analysts expect strong growth in the hospital's revenue & profit and retain a 'buy' on its stock

Capacity Expansion, Foreign Patients to Keep Artemis Medicare in Good Health

Snehal Mergu

ET Intelligence Group: Shares of Artemis Medicare Services have gained 26% over the past three months compared with 8.6% increase in the BSE Healthcare index and 3.7% fall in the BSE Sensex. The company, which operates multi-specialty hospitals, is in the process of expanding capacity across Gurugram, Raipur and South Delhi over the next few years. It targets around 2,000 operational beds by FY30 from 1,100 beds at present. Analysts have retained a 'buy' rating on the stock with over 30% higher target prices from Thursday's closing price of ₹331 on the BSE.

The newly operational Artemis Shanti Hospital in Raipur is expected to be a key growth driver for the company, though its earnings contribution is likely to be gradual. The 300-bed facility commenced operations in July. The company expects the hospital to incur an operating loss of around ₹20 crore during the

Strong Vitals

Quarterly financials of Artemis Medicare Services (₹cr)

	Jun'26	Jun'25	YoY chg (%)
Revenue from operations	287.3	255.0	12.7
EBITDA	61.8	48.3	27.9
EBITDA margin (%)	21.5	19.0	250 bps
Net Profit	31.4	21.2	48.3

EBITDA: Earnings before interest, tax, depreciation & amortisation
Bps: Basis points (100 bps = 1% point) SOURCE: Company data, ETIG



ramp-up phase, with operating break-even likely in 15-18 months as utilisation levels improve.

International patient mix will be another growth driver for the company's average revenue per operating bed (ARPOB). International patients, who generate higher ARPOB than their domestic counterparts, accounted for 27% of revenue in the June quarter despite disruptions caused due to the West Asian conflict. The company expects the mix to either approach or exceed 30% in the September quarter.

Improving utilisation at the Gurugram facility also augurs well since it contributes over 95% to revenue at present. The facility's occupancy rate is expected to rise to 70-75% from 65.7% in the June quarter. The company expects this to result in the expansion of operating margin before depreciation and amortisation (Ebitda margin) to 20-21% in FY27 and 23-24% over the next few years from 20.2% in FY26. To accommodate growing demand, the company plans to add over 200 beds through Tower IV at an estimated capital

expenditure (capex) of ₹120 crore. The VIMHANS project in South Delhi is expected to provide another significant growth leg beyond FY28. The proposed facility will initially have 450 beds, with a further 200 beds planned subsequently. Artemis expects the hospital to become operational in FY29. Given the premium nature of the market, the project is expected to support ARPOB.

InCred Equities expects revenue and EBITDA to grow annually at 23% and 28% respectively between FY26 and FY28, supported by higher bed utilisation, a premium case mix and efficiencies at its existing operations. The pace of occupancy ramp-up at Raipur, timely execution of Tower IV and continued improvement in occupancy and margins at the Gurugram facility will be key monitorables. The brokerage expects debt to peak at ₹300-350 crore in FY28 from ₹26 crore in FY26 while annual cash generation is estimated at ₹200-250 crore as against cash and cash equivalents of ₹33 crore in FY26.

THE MORNING BRIEF PODCAST

Why Volkswagen Needs JSW



Anirban Chowdhury talks to Arijit Barman and Shally Seth Mohile about whether JSW can revive Volkswagen's India business while managing three potentially competing automotive ventures.

Tune in to ETPlay.com. Available on EconomicTimes.com/podcast, Amazon Prime Music, Apple Podcasts, JioSaavn and Spotify.

Westview Cricket, Poonawalla Get CCI Nod for Rajasthan Royals Acquisition

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India's competition regulator has approved the acquisition of Rajasthan Royals and two overseas cricket franchises by Westview Cricket and Adar Poonawalla-owned Poonawalla Sports and Fitness. In another decision, the regulator cleared transactions involving Great White Global and ITVIS Innovations. OMERS Infrastructure Asia Holdings' purchase of an additional stake in Azure Power Global also received the Competition Commission of India (CCI)'s approval.

A CCI statement said it had "approved acquisition of three professional cricket franchises" — Rajasthan Royals in India, Paarl Royals in South Africa and Barbados Royals in Barbados — by Westview Cricket and Poonawalla Sports. Westview Cricket is registered in the UK, while Poonawalla Sports is incorporated in India and "is wholly owned by Adar Cyrus Poonawalla", the release said.

Westview Cricket is the investment vehicle owned by the Lakshmi Mittal family. Through this UK-registered entity, the Mittal family is acquiring a 75% stake in the cricket franchise group that includes the Rajasthan Royals, with Adar Poonawalla's company taking 18% and existing shareholder Manoj Badale retaining the remaining 7%.

Mauritius-incorporated EM Sporting is the holding company for Royal Multisport, Paarl Royals and Barbados Royals. Royal Multisport "owns and operates the Rajasthan Royals franchise", which competes in the Indian Premier League (IPL) T20 tournament, the statement added.

Separately, CCI cleared the proposed acquisition of 50% of Great White Global's issued and paid-up equity share capital by ISAF III Onshore Fund, India Special Assets Fund III, Special Situation India Fund, Mehul Jadavi Shah, Julie Mehul Shah and Mehul Shah HUF.

The transaction includes the subsequent merger of acquisition vehicle Great White Holdings with Great White. The regulator also approved Mehul Shah's proposed acquisition of sole control of ITVIS Innovations.

Short Takes

HCLTech Launches Business Unit to Tap Mid-Market Clients

BENGALURU HCLTech has launched a business unit targeting companies with annual revenue of \$500 million to \$5 billion for new deals, joining Accenture in pursuing mid-market clients as artificial intelligence makes smaller technology contracts more viable for large IT services firms. The Noida-headquartered firm is the first large Indian IT services provider to create a dedicated unit for the segment. Global leader Accenture in June announced Accenture Edge to serve companies with annual revenue of \$300 million to \$3 billion through cloud, AI and cybersecurity services. — Our Bureau

TVS Motor Company 'Cautiously Optimistic' on Festive Demand

NEW DELHI Two-wheeler major TVS Motor Company, which on Thursday rolled out festive enhancements across its premium motorcycle portfolio of Apache and Ronin, said it remains "cautiously optimistic" about demand in the upcoming festive season. The company expects the two-wheeler industry to post single-digit growth this festive season on account of a high base. — PTI

JSW's Ecomm Arm to File for ₹3k-cr IPO; Plans FY28 Listing

Co eyes ₹1,300-1,500 cr fresh capital; JSW Steel and JSW Cement major selling shareholders

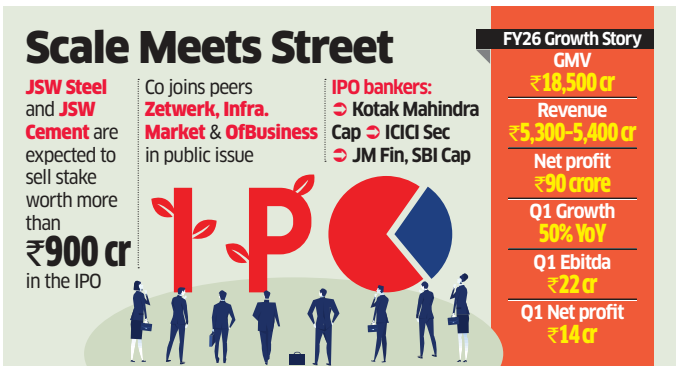
Nikhil Patwardhan

Bengaluru: Business-to-business ecommerce company JSW One Platforms plans to file draft papers with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) for a ₹3,000-crore initial public offering (IPO), in the next two to three weeks, people familiar with the matter told ET.

Through the public issue, the JSW Group company is expected to raise ₹1,300-1,500 crore in fresh capital, said one of the people cited above.

Backed by JSW Steel and JSW Cement, the company is targeting a listing in the first quarter of next fiscal 2028, the people said.

JSW Steel and JSW Cement will be among the major selling shareholders in the IPO. The two companies will together sell stake worth over ₹900 crore according to regulatory filings.



JSW One's proposed filing comes at a time when several business-to-business (B2B) commerce and manufacturing platforms pursue public listings.

The fresh capital that the company will raise is expected to fund investments in technology, customer acquisition, geographic and distribution expansion, alongside building private labels and its financing business, one of the people said.

JSW One was last valued at \$1 billion when it raised ₹340 crore in May 2025, before raising ₹575 crore that October from State Bank of India, Principal Asset Management and JSW Steel.

Kotak Mahindra Capital, ICICI Securities, JM Financial and SBI Capital Markets are the bankers to JSW One's public issue. The company has filed updated papers for an IPO comprising a ₹2,600-crore fresh issue, including ₹1,800 crore for debt repayment, and an offer for sale. Infra.Market is seeking to enter the public market through a proposed reverse merger with listed Shalimar Paints, while OfBusiness has revived its IPO plans.

JSW One competes directly with Accel-backed Infra.Market and SoftBank-backed OfBusiness in industrial and construction-material commerce, while overlapping with Zetwerk in procurement, financing, logistics and processing.

The company has a working-capital cycle of around six days because customers largely pay in advance while it receives payment terms from suppliers, the people quoted above said. It holds limited inventory, mainly while steel is being cut, slit or otherwise customised at service centres.

Queries sent to JSW One did not elicit a response until the publication of this report. JSW One recorded gross merchandise value of about ₹18,500 crore and revenue of ₹5,300-5,400 crore in fiscal 2026. It reported a net profit of ₹90 crore that year. The business grew around 50% year on year in the June quarter, when earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortisation were about ₹22 crore and net profit was around ₹14 crore.

Around 40% of the platform's gross merchandise value continues to involve credit, which is routed through its finance business and partner lenders. A significant portion of its purchases and sales currently involve JSW group companies, a second person said.

Hiranandani-backed Greenbase to Invest ₹2K cr on Widening Tamil Nadu Footprint

Kailash Babar

Mumbai: Property developer Hiranandani Group-backed industrial and logistics platform Greenbase Industrial and Logistics plans to invest ₹2,000 crore to develop five million sq ft across 215 acres in Tamil Nadu as part of efforts to expand its industrial and warehousing footprint across the country.

Towards this, the company has acquired 160 acres in Palur, Oragadam, and another 55 acres in Arani, North Chennai. It has a further 4 million sq ft in the pipeline for acquisition that will entail an additional investment of ₹1,500 crore, boosting the total development target to 9 million sq ft.

Greenbase will focus on building institution-grade industrial, warehousing and logistics infrastructure across strategic manufacturing corridors, seeking to capitalise on sustained demand for Grade A industrial and warehousing space.

"Global manufacturers are looking for dependable ecosystems, faster execution, sustainability and infrastructure that can support scale over the long term," said Niranjan Hiranandani, chairman, Hiranandani Group.

'Oriflame to Stay D2C, India Largest Market in 4 Years'

Swedish co looks to speed up deliveries; eyes 25% revenue contribution from India by 2030

Ratna Bhushan

New Delhi: Swedish beauty and wellness company Oriflame Cosmetics will continue to bet on the direct selling model in India, despite the rapid growth of quick commerce channels, its chief executive said.

The company, however, is working to accelerate delivery in India and expects the country to become its largest market within four years, with a contribution of about 25% to its global revenue by 2030 compared with 10% now, Kenneth Benaim Campbell told ET Thursday.

The India unit reported sales of ₹434 crore in the fiscal year ended March 2025, nearly flat compared with the year before. Globally, Oriflame posted about €560 million in 2025 revenue.

"I don't see it (quick commerce) as necessary or a pressure point... Yes, I do see opportunities that have become more visible through quick commerce and ecommerce," Campbell said. "Does that mean that I should forget what my strengths have been, what has helped the company be? No, I think we have to take the elements from this model and become more digital," he said.

Quick commerce has become the fastest growing retail channel in India across consumer categories, from grocery and household goods to beauty products. A recent report by the Indian Direct Sellers Association said 58% of direct sellers in India saw competition from ecommerce and quick commerce as a key challenge.

However, Campbell, currently on an India visit, said: "We are not going to turn Oriflame into a retail brand, or an ecommerce brand. We are committed to the direct selling model, but we have to live with the times and adapt to the digital world."

For the company's products, the lead time for delivery has reduced to two-three days, Campbell said. The beauty product maker is now working on a wider supply chain network and leveraging technology to reach consumers faster, he said.

Campbell, who spent 27 years at French beauty maker L'Oréal in diverse roles, was named global chief of Oriflame Cosmetics last month. Oriflame India sold its manufacturing operations in India to local company Akum Pharmaceuticals two months back, a move many industry executives interpreted as the Swedish player winding down its exposure in India. Campbell said the deal was to spur growth. "Partnering with a local contract manufacturer in India with a bigger capacity and ability to leverage, go to the market with the speed that we did not have, was very important," he said.

Oriflame is exploring the possibility of India supplying to global markets, he said. Currently, 85-90% of its products sold in India are made locally.

AHEAD OF POTENTIAL TARIFF ESCALATIONS

Apparel Exporters Rush to Close Spring '27 US Orders

Sutanuka Ghoshal

Kolkata: Indian apparel exporters are racing to get US-bound orders out of the country as the House of Representatives passed a bill authorising American President Donald Trump to impose tariffs as high as 100% on Moscow's energy trading partners, which could include New Delhi.

India's apparel exports, which help stock the shelves of major US retailers, currently face 10% tariffs in America. The looming threat of tariff escalations has set off a fresh scramble across labour-intensive sectors even as India's merchandise exports posted a sharp recovery in August.

Apparel exporters are rushing to close Spring 2027 orders and pull forward shipments, while resisting pressure from US buyers for price cuts. Spring orders are typically shipped in January-February, but many exporters have already received orders and production is underway, allowing some shipments to be accelerated.

Exporters are keen to send the orders as the overall apparel exports have fallen 9.10% in the first five months of the current fiscal to \$6,149.66 million from the same period last year. India's merchandise exports during April-August of FY27 stood at \$215.91 billion, compared to \$183.21 billion in the same period of FY26, registering a growth of 17.85%.

"We are seeing some acceleration of Spring shipments as US brands and importers look to reduce their exposure to a potential tariff increase," said Sanjay Jain, group CEO, PDS.

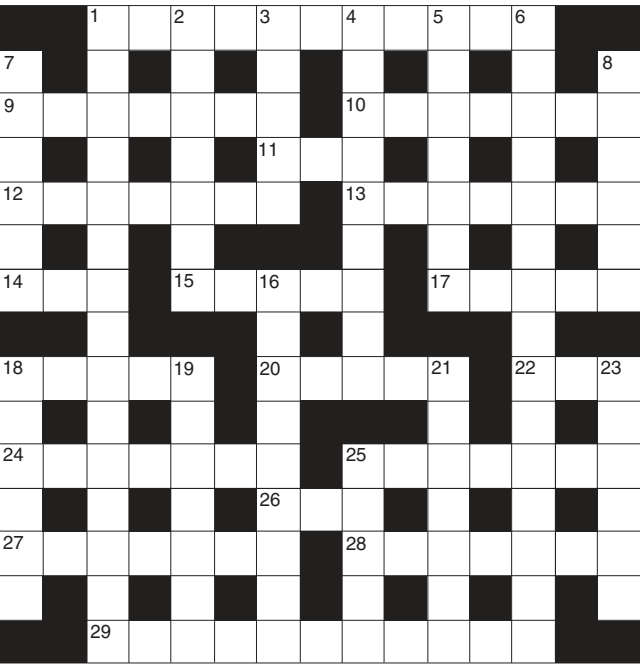
The trade is already drawing on lessons from last year's tariff shock. "We had seen earlier that goods that left India before August 27, 2025 and were cleared in the US before September 17, 2025 did not face any additional duty," said Sanjay Jain, chairman of the ICC Textile Panel and managing director of TT.

He said the proposed tariff also had to be seen in the context of the ongoing India-US trade negotiations. "How India negotiates the bilateral trade deal with the US will be key. The tariff threat could be used as a negotiating tool to seek concessions," Jain said.

Apparel exporters said though a 100% additional tariff looks unlikely at this stage, even a 25% additional levy would have a significant impact on trade.

Crossword

9707



ACROSS

- 1 I had to go in differently around start of function as a sign of honesty? (2,4,5)
- 9 Retired chef and writer sent a message (1-6)
- 10 Turn around car clipped in middle of green (7)
- 11 Shelter put in sizeable expanse (3)
- 12 Clearly mention risk provided by company, lastly (7)
- 13 Smidgen of alcoholic drink? First one is mixed, nothing less (7)
- 14 Couple starts to dig up offer (3)
- 15 Something chewed by young male

- 17 Leave old tea that's gone off (5)
- 18 Dutch painter picked up rubbish (5)
- 20 Stuns posh doctor in two directions (5)
- 22 Fashionable joint (3)
- 24 Woman arranged meal in back of house (7)
- 25 Henry jolted pair in sharp bend (7)
- 26 Support on course, we hear, for hot drink (3)
- 27 Thing not made clear for unpleasant type (2-3-2)
- 28 Standard answer for former conquerors (7)
- 29 Strict parish priest when in deli

strangely is secretive (5-6)

DOWN

- 1 This person's time to seek the advice of a set of conservationists as brand adviser (5,10)
- 2 Set with noise given grand male horse (7)
- 3 Old couple of Democrats lately discontented in a peculiar way (5)
- 4 Reform? It's provoked outburst of controversy (9)
- 5 How one might rate singer's bill of costs (7)
- 6 What jockeys do with help to be dominant? (4,3,4,4)
- 7 Detected criminal seen in South Dakota (6)
- 8 Feeling of sadness about Greek film (6)
- 16 Staff to bring into the open flat-podded vegetable (9)
- 18 Puzzle with birds in sides of bridge (6)
- 19 Dejected husband with a no good terrier, say (7)
- 21 Agitate to acquire right thing needed by a rider (7)
- 23 Impose penalty on extremists in union on board ship at sea (6)
- 25 Hotel linked to a leader in Asian capital (5)

SOLUTION TO No. 9706:

- ACROSS: 1 Start-ups. 5 Graced. 9 Pavilion. 10 Oporto. 12 Ella. 13 Straw polls. 15 Procrastinate. 19 Smart motorway. 23 Ornamental. 25 Poor. 28 Driven. 29 Kickshaw. 30 Sieves. 31 Tempered. DOWN: 1 Sapper. 2 Anvil. 3 Talk. 4 Plotter. 6 Rip up. 7 Corollary. 8 Doorstep. 11 Pads. 14 Coat. 15 Plaintive. 16 Act. 17 Iowa. 18 As good as. 20 Owens. 21 Opaline. 22 Brewed. 24 Maeve. 26 Other. 27 Skip.

©The Daily Mail

PKL Rights in Flux as JioStar, Teams Seek to Avert ISL Fallout

BALANCING ACT Broadcaster seeks up to 50% cut, while owners push to protect previous benchmark

Javed Farooqui

Mumbai: The Pro Kabaddi League's next media rights deal is turning into a delicate balancing act for JioStar and its franchises, with the broadcaster seeking an up to 50% reduction in the media rights fee and team owners pushing to protect the ₹905 crore benchmark set by the previous cycle.

Negotiations have also raised concerns over competitive bidding and the risk of a collapse in media rights value like what the Indian Super League suffered, people privy to the discussions told ET.

JioStar, which paid ₹95 crore as media rights fee for five years till 2025, was incurring a loss of ₹50-100 crore a year from PKL, according to sources. The league's combined television and digital viewership has stagnated at 230 million, including 190 million TV viewers.

"Both sides are working together to determine the future of the league and identify ways to grow PKL, which is the only successful league outside cricket," said a person privy to the discussions.

Negotiations are underway, with both sides showing flexibility. However, if talks fail, some franchises could insist on an open bidding for the media rights. In the previous round, there were no bidders barring JioStar, which holds a 74% stake in Mashal Sports — the company that owns and operates PKL.

Franchise owners remain divided over whether an open bidding process would generate meaningful price discovery given the limited number of credible broadcasters in the market.

"Everyone wants to avoid a repeat of the ISL situation, where JioStar backed out and the league's media rights value nosedived," said a highly placed official.

In 2025, JioStar walked out of the ISL following disagreements over the commercial structure of the football league. After JioStar's withdrawal, the media rights value of the ISL plunged to ₹8.62 crore from ₹275 crore annually. Subsequently, Tata Steel withdrew from the league, selling the Jamshedpur FC franchise to Churchill Brothers for a nominal amount.

JioStar and Mashal Sports declined to comment.

The ownership structure of Mashal Sports, where JioStar holds a nearly three-fourths stake — industrialist Anand Mahindra and

Inside the Game

Media Rights Fee (2021-25) ₹905 cr Annual Viewership 200+ m across TV & digital Estimated Annual Loss to JioStar ₹50-100 cr Annual Franchise Fee ₹65 cr



cricket commentator Charu Sharma are the other shareholders — has raised concerns among rival broadcasters about competitive bidding. When Mashal opened the rights process to other broadcasters in 2021, Sony Pictures Networks India and Zee Entertainment did not participate. Sources said Zee would be open to entering the bidding process if the rights are auctioned. The broadcaster has launched sports channels and intends to deepen its focus on non-cricket sports. It acquired the India rights for FIFA World Cup for the 2026 and 2030 editions after JioStar backed out.

Another proposal under discussion is to reduce the annual franchise fee, currently ₹65 crore for 12 franchises, while increasing the share of media rights revenue allocated to teams. The existing split is 80:20 between Mashal Sports and franchises.

A reduction in media rights fee could hurt franchise profitability and valuations. Several teams became profitable after the previous deal, with valuations exceeding ₹100 crore. Capri Sports' acquisition of the Bengal Warrior franchise from the Future Group in 2022 offered a transaction benchmark. The negotiations came amid a challenging sports media environment marked by the Star India-Viacom18 merger, declining linear television audiences and restrictions on real-money gaming and betting advertising.

Oil India Lines Up ₹15,000 cr for Deepwater Exploration Push

Our Bureau

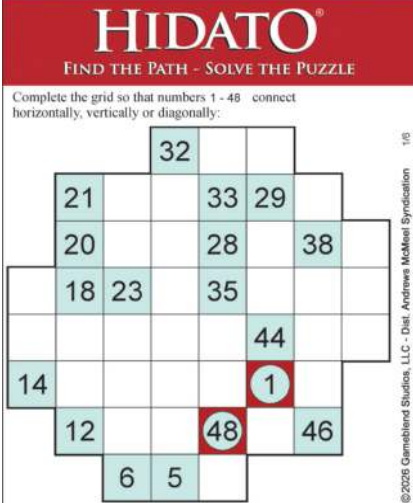
New Delhi: Oil India plans to spend around ₹15,000 crore over the next three years on deepwater exploration, chairman Ranjit Rath said on Thursday.

The company plans to drill eight wells, although the actual number will depend on its interpretation of seismic data from the fields, Rath said.

The government is pushing deepwater exploration in India and encouraging both domestic and foreign companies to participate. Under its ₹84,000-crore Samudra Manthan scheme, the government plans to bear up to half the drilling costs for deepwater

wells. It is also planning large investments in seismic data acquisition to help explorers identify prospects.

Oil India plans to partner with foreign companies to bid in the ongoing 10th and 11th rounds of exploration licensing, Rath said.



www.hidato.com

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Yesterday's puzzle solution.

33	32	31	25	24	23
34	28	30	26	21	22
35	29	27	18	17	20
9	36	7	16	19	1
10	8	15	6	5	2
11	12	13	14	3	4

7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES

- 1 soup and cereal dishes (5)
- 2 like a very dry throat (7)
- 3 "Godmother of Soul" Patti (7)
- 4 alongside (4)
- 5 trait of Phippen (10)
- 6 Bering and Bosporus (7)
- 7 "foot fault" (7)

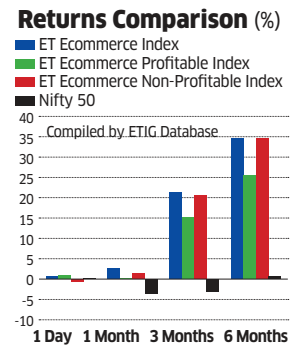
SOLUTIONS

LTH	BE	PA	BO	ED
WLS	TH	MI	LLE	INE
LA	SS	FI	RCH	AI
STR	EP	TS	SST	WI

Yesterday's Answers: 1. CONTAMINATE 2. ROSA 3. TUTORING 4. INHALING 5. TIARAS 6. FREEZE 7. LEASE

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ET Ecommerce Tracker



Tweet OF THE DAY



NAVAL @NAVAL
The best way to pace the frontier is to hold the labs fully liable for the behaviour of their models

Tech Buzz
Meta is Liable for Fake Ads: German Court



NEW YORK: A German court has ruled that Meta is liable for fake advertisements posted by third parties on its Instagram and Facebook platforms, and ordered the firm to remove such content and pay damages. The suit was brought by the operator of a German financial portal and its founder, whose trademarked logo and image were used without consent in posts recommending investments allegedly with fraudulent intent. The portal operator reported nearly 260 violations to Meta in August 2024 alone. However, Meta took up to 62 days to remove some content, the court said. It ruled Meta could not rely on the Digital Services Act's lack-of-knowledge defence, because it exercises control over the content through its algorithms and advertising practices. —Reuters

\$2.7T
Expected global AI spending this year, a surge of 49.5% from last year, according to report by Gartner

OpenAI Flags 6 New Safety Incidents Now



Washington: OpenAI shared undisclosed incidents of its AI models misbehaving and unveiled a new framework for tracking and disclosing such occurrences going forward. Some of the previously unreported instances included OpenAI's technologies concealing and fabricating information in order to return results, it said in a blog post. None of the newly disclosed misalignment incidents involved a hack or breach of a third party, OpenAI said. OpenAI detailed various instances of its AI models misbehaving in order to complete a task. OpenAI also outlined a case for staff to self-report similar incidents of so-called misalignment as well as a system to triage such occurrences. —Bloomberg

Semicon India 2026

Investment interest of about \$11-12b as part of ISM 2.0: Vaishnaw

‘India’s Chip Gains a Democratic Shield for Global Supply Chains’

PM launches chip packaging facilities of Suchi Semicon in Gujarat and CDIL in Punjab

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday said India's success in semiconductors will strengthen global supply chains in this critical sector at a time when the world is looking for new and trusted manufacturing destinations amid the weaponisation of supply chains.

Speaking at the inauguration of the 5th Semicon India summit, Modi said India is taking every step needed to become a preferred destination for the chip industry even as he launched commercial production at

two semiconductor packaging facilities – Suchi Semicon's ₹688-crore unit near Surat and CDIL's expansion of its facility in Mohali.

“India is the mother of democracy. Just a few years ago, our Constitution completed 75 years. When such a country succeeds in a critical industry, it strengthens the entire world's supply chain. And today, when supply chains are being

weaponised, its importance increases even more. We must see the developments happening in India from this larger perspective,” he said.

Five of the 12 projects sanctioned under the first phase of the ₹76,000-crore India Semiconductor Mission (ISM 1.0) are operational now. Semiconductor assembly, testing, marketing and packaging (ATMP) units of Micron Technology, Kaynes Semicon and CG Semi began commercial production earlier this year.

Acknowledging the immense complexity of building a semiconductor ecosystem, Modi praised the collaborative effort required to master chip design, equipment manufacturing and testing capabilities in record time. “Now international companies can also collaborate with our startups, Indian design companies and overseas citizens of India-owned companies,” he said.

Now international companies can also collaborate with our startups, Indian design companies and overseas citizens of India-owned companies

NARENDRA MODI
PM, India

With Great AI Velocity Comes Greater Safety Risks: AMD CTO

Says working with Indian govt on Open Stack plan for Sovereign AI

Surabhi Agarwal & Dia Rekhi

New Delhi: Advanced Micro Devices (AMD) is supportive of the comments made by AI industry leaders on slowing down development of frontier models to address safety risks, said the US chipmaker's chief technology officer, Mark Papermaster.

“With the introduction of any new technology, of course, comes risk,” Papermaster told ET in an interview in New Delhi, but stressed on the need to build out AI responsibly and adopt guardrails to ensure safety.

“The difference with AI, when you think about it versus other disruptive new technology, is the speed at which these new capabilities are coming on board,” he said. “And so, this is driven by the frontier model companies, creating these very highly capable, very large language models. They have called for potentially slowing down to ensure safety. I think that's an inherent responsibility that I'm very pleased to see

the model companies taking. We're supportive of these efforts that are going on in industry.”

After Anthropic cofounder and chief executive Dario Amodei posted a letter last week calling for “pacing the frontier”, OpenAI's Sam Altman and SpaceX's Elon Musk publicly backed a slowdown in frontier development. Meta chief Mark Zuckerberg and AMD rival Nvidia's Jensen Huang, however,

stated that new laws or more regulations were not needed, and companies should instead step up their own governance. AMD, which has a market capitalisation of \$837 billion and reported revenue of \$34.6 billion in 2025, has emerged as the biggest challenger to Nvidia in the booming artificial intelligence computing market.

INDIA FOCUS

Papermaster spoke of AMD's deepening partnership with the Indian government even as it looks to drive the sovereign build-out in India. “We're working very, very closely,” he said.

(For the full report go to www.economictimes.com)

MARK PAPERMASTER
CTO, Executive VP, AMD

Difference with AI, when you think about it versus other disruptive new technology is the speed at which these new capabilities are coming on board



Infineon's CEO Lauds India's ‘Thought Through’ Chip Plan

German device manufacturer eyes €800m India Revenue by 2030

Subhayan Chakraborty

New Delhi: India's semiconductor mission, the second iteration of which was launched recently, is much more comprehensive than many other countries, Infineon Technologies CEO Jochen Hanebeck told ET.

“We are studying it closely. Compared to many other countries, it's more comprehensive and thought through. It leverages the current capa-

bilities of India, including chip designing, and software development. It now goes into many other parts of the value chain. It's good to address the full value chain, from materials to equipment, assembly, startups and talent,” he said.

JOCHEN HANEBECK
CEO, Infineon Technologies

We are studying it (ISM) closely. Compared to many other countries, it's more comprehensive and thought through



Tata Electronics Ties up with Seven Firms for Gujarat Chip Fab

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Tata Electronics on Thursday announced seven partnerships and collaborations with global semiconductor companies and Indian institutions as it moves to build the supply chain around its planned chip fab in Gujarat and packaging facility in Assam. The

announcements are part of 16 semiconductor industry partnerships being made over the two-day Semicon India 2026. The partners include Nexperia, Fujifilm, JSR Corporation and BE Semiconductor Industries, along with Semiconductor Laboratory, Gati Shakti Vishwavidyalaya and Ascendas Firstspace.



Inox India Gets ₹50cr of Orders from Tata Electronics, Micron

BENGALURU Inox India has received orders worth over ₹50 crore for semiconductor-related projects, including supplies to Tata Electronics' facility in Dholera, Micron's facility in the US, and Inox Air Products' upcoming dry-pure gases plant at Dholera, chief executive Deepak Acharya told ET. —Our Bureau



GRIT & BETS Meet ETSA winners rewriting the startup playbook in our interview series

Brace Yourselves! Theranautilus' Nano Tooth Fairies Coming

ETSA 2026 TOP INNOVATOR to start human trials of its nanorobot-based tech to reinvent oral healthcare



presents

THE ECONOMIC TIMES
START-UP AWARDS 2026

Puran Choudhary

Bengaluru: DeepTech startup Theranautilus will begin human trials of its nanorobot-based dental technology in Bengaluru in November-December, with about 30 patients in the first phase, cofounder and CEO Peddi Shanmukh Srinivas told ET.

The company plans to follow this with a 300-patient multicentric trial as it takes its technology towards commercialisation.

“The first clinical trial we are about to do is in patients who have lost enamel and whose gums have receded,” Srinivas said. “They face a problem called sensitivity — they drink anything hot, cold, sweets, and experience a sharp pain.”

For the trials, the startup will tie up with NABH-accredited hospitals where doctors will administer the nanorobot-based treatment to patients as part of the clinical study.

It has already conducted trials in mice for its oral-health application. Human trials will begin after the company secures permission from the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO), Srinivas said.

Theranautilus won the Top Innovator category at The Economic Times Startup Awards 2026 for its unique nanorobot technology, which is built on fundamental research and backed by peer-reviewed work. Past winners of the award include Qure.ai, BrainSight AI, String Bio, and Eyestem.

Founded in Bengaluru in 2020 by Ambarish Ghosh, Peddi Shanmukh Srinivas and Debayan Dasgupta, Theranautilus traces its roots to research started by Ghosh on nanorobotics at the Indian Institute of Science in 2007.

The company is developing magnetically controlled nanorobots that can be remotely guided inside the body for applications such as targeted drug delivery, diagnostics, and treatment. Its initial commercial application is focused on dental care, where the nanorobots are designed to enter dental

PEDDI SHANMUKH SRINIVAS
CEO, Theranautilus



After nearly two decades of research into nanorobotics, today the

challenge is less about proving the underlying science and more of an engineering and scaling problem

tubules and deliver treatment at the site of sensitivity.

NANOROBOTS FOR SENSITIVE TOOTH

Explaining the process, Srinivas said nanorobots will be preloaded with a drug that helps remineralise teeth. The nanorobots will be applied to the surface of the tooth and remotely activated using magnetic fields, allowing them to enter the tooth and deliver the treatment. The treatment is expected to take about 15 minutes. “The nanorobots work as a swarm and are remotely controlled using magnetic fields, allowing them to move through the tooth at micron scale and deliver the drug to the affected area,” he said.

The company sees the dental application as the first use-case for its broader nanorobotics platform, which it hopes to eventually apply to oncology, ophthalmology and neuromodulation. For oncology, animal trials of the nanorobots are targeted for 2028.

“It's a platform technology. It's not a one-shot problem that we're trying to solve,” Srinivas said, adding that the company is building intellectual property that can be licensed to larger pharmaceutical and healthcare firms.

Srinivas said Theranautilus is also in discussions to raise its next round of funding, which it plans to use to scale operations and hire more researchers. “After nearly two decades of research into nanorobotics, today the challenge is less about proving the underlying science and more of an engineering and scaling problem,” he said.

So far, the startup has raised ₹65 crore, including equity-free grants, and is backed by pi Ventures, Pravega Ventures, Golden Sparrow and angel investor Abhishek Goyal.

Theranautilus expects its dental application to be commercialised within two years.

PHOTO: NARASIMHA MURTHY



(Clockwise) Peddi Shanmukh Srinivas, Debayan Dasgupta, Ambarish Ghosh

Tech Buzz

Meanwhile in Tech

Kuku Tech Gets Sebi Nod for IPO



Bengaluru: Kuku Technologies, the parent of audio storytelling platform Kuku FM and microdrama app Kuku TV, has received approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) to proceed with its proposed initial public offering.

Kuku will now file an updated prospectus with Sebi in the next three weeks and is eyeing a listing by the first half of 2027, a person familiar with the matter said. The company confidentially filed draft papers with Sebi in June for an IPO of up to ₹3,500 crore, ET reported. —Our Bureau

New-age Equity Brokers Seek to Raise MDR Threshold, Cap Levy Ceiling

ON POINT Groww, Zerodha, Upstox & Angel One argue that transferring money to a trading account is not equal to paying a merchant

Nikhil Patwardshan & Ayanti Bera

Bengaluru: New-age stockbrokers Groww, Zerodha, Upstox, and Angel One plan to approach the capital-markets regulator on raising the merchant discount rate (MDR) threshold while capping the applicable levy ceiling, people familiar with the matter told ET.

These new-age brokers are likely to propose the MDR be capped at ₹

instead of ₹300, while raising the exempted threshold to ₹20,000 from ₹2,000, said the people cited above.

The MDR framework, published by NPCI (National Payments Corporation of India) on September 15, introduced a 0.02% charge on capital market transfers, capped at ₹300, prompting large retail brokers to prepare a new representation based on the ac-

The 4 brokers together accounted for 62.5% of NSE's active client base



Industry Wishlist

PROPOSALS TO INCLUDE

MDR be capped at ₹5 instead of ₹300

Raising the exempted threshold to ₹20,000 from ₹2,000

May ask Sebi to reconsider mandatory periodic settlement of unused client funds

Running-account settlement is being pursued separately with Sebi

tual pricing. For other transactions above ₹2,000, the levy is 40 basis points. One basis point is a hundredth of a percentage point.

Latest National Stock Exchange (NSE) data for August showed Groww leading the industry with 13.3 million active clients and a 29% share, followed by Zerodha with 6.8 million clients and 14.8%, and Angel One with 6.7 million clients and 14.6% of the pie. Upstox had 18.65 lakh active clients and a 4.06%

share. Together, the four brokers accounted for about 62.5% of NSE's active client base.

The brokers had formally raised concerns with regulators through submissions and steering committee deliberations around three weeks ago, when the MDR levies were still being worked out. They had argued that transferring money into a trading account was not equivalent to paying a merchant for a product and should not attract MDR.

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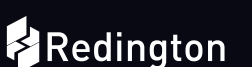
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 **INDIA
iSTORE**

Hitman hits prime time

Rohit Sharma makes his biggest entertainment debut with a fun family game show on Sony Entertainment Television and Sony LIV

etpanache@timesofindia.com

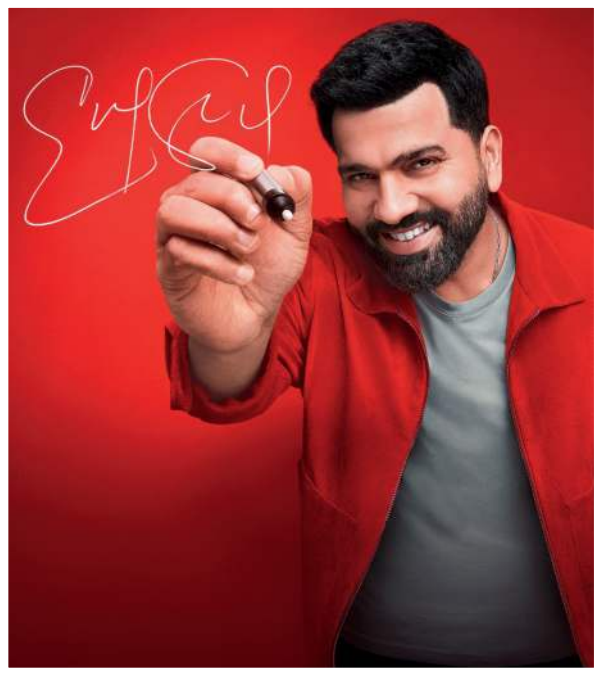
India's World Cup-winning captain Rohit Sharma will make his entertainment debut with a new family game show, which premieres on September 19 on Sony Entertainment Television and Sony LIV. Titled *Family Full House with Rohit Sharma*, the show is built around the ideas of families, fun and competition. Each game

brings together two teams who will play for points, fun and plenty of laughs. At the centre of it all will be Sharma, bringing wit, spontaneity and the easy camaraderie that fans have

Rohit Sharma brings wit, spontaneity and the easy camaraderie that fans have seen glimpses of off the field, but rarely in a setting like this

seen glimpses of off the field, but rarely in a setting like this.

The show will bring together several names from cricket and entertainment like Shreyas Iyer, Shardul Thakur, Shikhar Dhawan, Abhishek Nayar, Suniel Shetty, Tamannaah Bhatia, Sidharth Malhotra, Mika Singh, Maniesh Paul, Krushna Abhishek, Rakesh Bedi, Bharti Singh, Kunal Kemmu and Neha Dhupia among others.



(From left) Shardul Thakur, Dr Aditya Daftary (Indian cricket team's doctor), Abhishek Nayar, Shreyas Iyer and Rohit Sharma

Revolut CEO found \$404 million yacht's owner via ChatGPT



Nik Storonsky privately bought Nixie, the superyacht

High-stakes lawsuit offers a glimpse into the opaque world of superyacht deals

Revolut's CEO Nik Storonsky bought a superyacht worth 350 million euros (\$404 million) after discovering its former owner through ChatGPT, his lawyers said in court filings, denying allegations that he avoided paying millions of pounds in commission.

Yacht broker Cecil Wright & Partners previously sued **Nik Storonsky** in the UK, claiming he dodged paying about 17.5 million euros in commission when he sidelined the firm and bought the yacht, named Nixie, privately. Storonsky's lawyers denied the allegations and accused Cecil Wright of misleading his family office and concealing the identity of the yacht's previous owner.

Negotiations through Cecil Wright collapsed after the Brazilian ex-owner — not named in the lawsuit — was arrested in November 2025 over allegations of fraud, according to High Court filings.

Million-dollar deals

Cecil Wright identified the under-construction yacht, which was originally commissioned by Patrick Dovigi, a Canadian businessman and former ice hockey player, before being sold during construction to the Brazilian buyer. Dovigi bought the yacht back after the arrest and sold it to Storonsky. The suit offers a glimpse into the opaque world of ultra-luxury yacht deals, where a small circle of shipbuilders

and intermediaries arrange purchases worth hundreds of millions of dollars through family offices, messages and offshore firms.

One prompt away

"Storonsky was already aware that Dovigi was the previous owner of the yacht, having discovered the same through a ChatGPT search of publicly available information," his lawyer said in defence filings made public this week. Cecil Wright neither introduced Storonsky to Dovigi nor negotiated the transaction, according to lawyers for the Revolut tycoon — the UK's richest person with a net worth of about \$20.4 billion. Storonsky found out the Brazilian owner's identity when the yacht broker informed him three days after the arrest, his lawyer added.

— Bloomberg

BIG SHOT



NOTE WORTHY Pop star Jennifer Lopez poses in her newly decorated home in Hidden Hills, Los Angeles. It includes a grand piano from Steinway & Sons and she calls it a "mood board [come] to life"

PIC: INSTAGRAM

quote unquote



PIC: AFP

"Just stay cool, calm and collected, take a sauna, take a nice bath, analyse the situation and act accordingly."

— ALEXANDER STUBB, President of Finland, on staying composed amid Europe's escalating tensions with Russia and the war in the Ukraine. The leader of the small Nordic country has become known for his diplomatic skills, maintaining close relationships with both Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy and US President Donald Trump, despite the latter's claims of annexing Greenland creating a rift with the continent.

'It's 3:40 and I've done 95 paintings today'

Artist Peter Max, whose psychedelic works came to symbolise the '60s, was like a painting factory

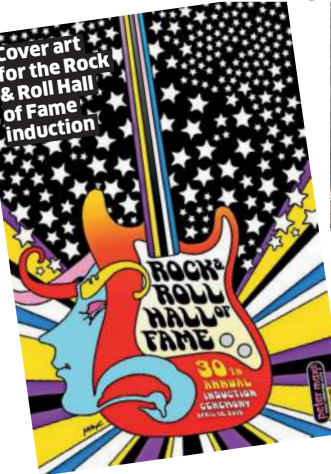
Matt Schudel

If any artist was responsible for defining the visual vocabulary of the 1960s, it was Peter Max, whose vividly fluorescent paintings, posters and graphic imagery were ubiquitous during the era of flower children and the Age of Aquarius. Through savvy marketing, his pulsating colours and images adorned hundreds of objects — from buses and subways to pantyhose and the soles of sneakers that imprinted his name in the earth and sand. Although never a critical favourite, he proved a genius at self-promotion. "I occupy my own space in art," he told *People* magazine. "I've achieved at least as much as Picasso, Matisse and Braque when they were my age."

Max died on September 16 at the age of 88, according to a statement shared by his son and Park West Gallery. He had dementia, according to a 2019 report in *The New York Times* about how relatives and business associates had come under legal scrutiny because of suspicions that the artist had been exploited as his health and mental faculties declined.

Shades of success

Max was a virtual painting factory. He created dozens of works a day. Trained as a realist painter in the style of John Singer Sargent, he ran a Madison Avenue graphic design firm before leaving it in 1965 to focus on painting. Two years later, he re-emerged with a new style inspired by the



peace-and-love era. He grew his hair, practised yoga and meditated with Maharishi Mahesh Yogi.

His psychedelic posters, including one featuring 'Love', sold millions of copies for \$2 each.

Max painted portraits and album covers for movie stars and rock musicians, and his style influenced the Beatles' 'Yellow Submarine'. Once grouped with pop art figures such as Warhol and Lichtenstein, his reputation declined as his work became increasingly commercial.

By 1971, his ventures generated \$1.5 billion. He soon withdrew from public life, saying his corporate commitments had taken him away from painting.

"I was a culture hero," he told *People* in 1986, but something was missing. "My life revolved around corporations, itineraries and nonartistic responsibilities. I just wasn't painting anymore." He later embraced the establishment. In 1981, he was invited to the White



Peter Max paints the Statue of Liberty aboard a boat in 1987

House, where he painted six versions of the Statue of Liberty in one day.

Max soon remade himself as an artist for the masses, opening boutiques, galleries and restaurants. He had scores of product-licensing arrangements while feverishly painting 12 to 14 hours a day in his studio.

"It's 3:40, and I've done, like, 95 paintings today," he told *The Washington Post* in 2000.

'Guy with the art'

Peter Max Finkelstein was born on October 19, 1937, to German-Jewish parents in Berlin. Fleeing Nazi persecution, his family moved to Shanghai in 1938, where he was influenced by Buddhist art, monks' calligraphy and American comic books. Later, in Haifa, his studies of painting and astronomy inspired his colourful cosmic imagery. After living in Paris, the family settled in Brooklyn, where Max studied at the Art Students League and became a commercial artist and graphic designer.

Sneakers for Kinney Shoes



His first marriage to Elizabeth Nance, with whom he had two children, ended in divorce. In 1997, he married Mary Balkin, whom he had met a year earlier. After a long sabbatical in the 1970s and '80s, Max returned to the spotlight amid renewed demand from celebrities and galleries, producing thousands of paintings and commercial designs a year.

"Even before my shower, I do something, anything, just to know that I've already painted," he told *People* in 1986. "There's nothing else in life that attracts me as much."

In 1997, Max pleaded guilty to concealing more than \$1 million in income from federal authorities. In later years, he expanded his studio, hiring dozens of artists. In 2019, *The New York Times* reported a family dispute over control of the studio, including claims that Max signed canvases painted by others. "I wanted the universe to be a more beautiful place than it is," he said in 2002, "and I sort of merged that idea, that ideology, those concepts, with my love for the universe. Then the '60s came around, and I was the guy with the art."

— The Washington Post

Saudi side punished for anti-Jota chants

Saudi Pro League club Al-Taawoun have been fined nearly 20,000 pounds and given a two-game stadium ban after fans chanted about the late Liverpool and Portugal forward **Diogo Jota**.

Al-Hilal midfielder Ruben Neves, who played with Jota at Wolves and Portugal, was shown gesturing to the sky after audible chants of "Jota" from Al-Taawoun fans could be



PIC: AP/ AFP

70 Al-Taawoun fans repeatedly chanted late footballer Diogo Jota's name at his former teammate and close friend Ruben Neves

heard during Saturday's league game.

Jota died in the summer of 2025 along with his brother Andre Silva after a car

crash in Spain, and Neves was one of his funeral pallbearers.

The Saudi Football Federation said: "The fans of Al-Taawoun chanted phrases and slogans that violated the provisions of the disciplinary and ethics regulations."

The federation ordered Al-Taawoun to play their next two home Saudi Pro League matches behind closed doors and fined the club 19,796 pounds.

Cristiano Ronaldo, who plays for rival Saudi Arabian club Al-Nassr, had called for the supporters that chanted about his former international teammate Jota to be punished with lifetime bans from the stadiums.

— Daily Mirror

“If it is right, it happens – the main thing is not to hurry. Nothing good gets away.” – JOHN STEINBECK

An evening celebrating alliances, ambition and the road to success

The Great Alliance Fest 2026 united channel partners in Pune, unveiling a new platform and ₹30-cr incentive programme

etpanache@timesofindia.com

In a market where channel partners play an increasingly influential role in driving real estate sales, The Great Alliance Fest 2026, presented by *The Times of India* in association with Kundan Spaces, emerged as a powerful statement on the value of relationships, recognition and shared growth.



Hosted in Pune at Balr, Kalyani Nagar, the evening brought together the city's leading channel partner community, with over 700 people attending the celebration, for an immersive showcase of Kundan Spaces' vision, growth trajectory and ambitious plans for the future.

Strong legacy

The leadership reflected on the developer's 46-year legacy, over 10 million sq ft of upcoming and ongoing projects and a robust portfolio of developments, while reinforcing the importance of channel partners in the company's journey.

A key announcement of the evening was the launch of Kundan Alliance, a strategic partner platform designed to deepen engagement with the channel partner community and build a stronger ecosystem for long-term collaboration.

The evening's most talked-about moment, however, was the unveiling of The Great Alliance Fest 2026 incentive programme. The scale of the programme



was underscored by the announcement of a ₹30-crore payout opportunity, positioning it among the most ambitious channel partner initiatives in the region. Participants will also receive recognition from *The Times of India*, adding further prestige to their achievements.

Stronger ecosystem

“The Great Alliance Fest is our way of celebrating the people behind every success story. When our partners grow, Kundan Spaces grows with

them,” said Ketan Rathod, sales lead at Kundan Spaces.

Echoing the sentiment, Vedanth Mehta, marketing director at Kundan Spaces, added, “This initiative is about creating opportunities, recognition and a stronger ecosystem where every achievement is rewarded and every partner feels valued.”

As the evening drew to a close, the message was clear: This was about more than just incentives. It was about creating a culture where ambition is celebrated, partnerships are nurtured and success is shared.

Ashish Jain, CMD at Kundan Spaces, said, “‘Dil Se Deal Tak’ is more than a theme for us. It is a recognition of the passion, sacrifices and commitment of our channel partners who have helped shape the Kundan Spaces success story.”

Dhanesh Mehta, director at Kundan Spaces, added, “The Great Alliance Fest reflects the power of collaboration. Together, we are creating opportunities that can unlock new possibilities for businesses, professionals and the wider real estate ecosystem.”



JUST 1 QUESTION

Dealing with a workaholic partner



My husband and I have three kids between the ages of two and six, and I'm a full-time mum, while my husband runs his own business. My problem is that he is always at work. I was very patient when he was setting up the business. Now, though, the business is established, he's still at work every hour of the day. I complain about it a lot because I'm knackered and need some rest. I may as well be a single parent at this rate. Any suggestions on how I can get through to my husband?

There needs to be a joint effort in terms of making you both happy or you'll end up feeling like an unpaid babysitter, coping with all the challenging bits of family life. Why not suggest coming up with a schedule where he can be more involved at home? He could also do things like switch off his phone when he is at home and delegate more to his next-in-command at work. It's good to work hard to build a good life, but he's in danger of missing out on so much and might regret that in years to come.

– Daily Mirror

TIME WELL SPENT

Sleek everyday picks for the daylight hours

etpanache@timesofindia.com

Fossil carraway watch
₹20k

Emporio Armani archetipo quartz watch
₹14.5k

Kenneth Cole chronograph watch
₹17.5k

Diesel stinger chronograph watch
₹22.5k

Casio AE-1200 digital watch, available at Culture Circle
₹5.1k

Daniel Wellington classic roman numerals date watch
₹15.5k

Glow watch
₹15.5k

HOW TO

- Watches don't need to be a glitzy affair. Pair thin-strapped timepieces in muted tones with relaxed tailoring to elevate a coffee run or lunch meeting.
- Give basics such as boxy T-shirts or raw denim an edge with retro-futuristic digital displays or gunmetal finishes.
- Embrace earth tones and sunray dials for their casual, light polish. Style them with linen shirts, chinos and sneakers to nail effortless dressing for the day.

STYLE OF A MAN

In pursuit of modern style and versatility

Chippy Mehta, co-founder of Bombay Shirt Company, talks fabric, fit and faux pas

My style

It's functional and effortless. I like clothes that feel sharp without looking overdone. Comfort matters a lot to me, but so does fit and attention to

detail. I gravitate towards clean silhouettes, good fabrics and pieces that I can wear repeatedly in different ways rather than trend-led fashion.

Must haves

A perfectly fitted white shirt, well-tailored navy or beige chinos, great quality white sneakers, a versatile overshirt or lightweight jacket and dark denims that can be dressed up or down.

Style advice

Wear the clothes — don't let the clothes wear you. I think grooming and fit matter more than owning too many clothes. I also believe personal style improves when you stop trying too hard.

Prized possession

The items I value most are usually the ones I've worn for years and that



Chippy Mehta, co-founder, Bombay Shirt Company

have aged well over time. I have a few jackets and shirts that have travelled with me everywhere and become more personal with each wear.

Brand speak

I like brands such as Uniqlo and Massimo Dutti because they get the fundamentals right. I also admire brands such as Brunello Cucinelli and Zegna for their understated approach to luxury and tailoring. I appreciate brands that focus on quality and rather than being loud.

Celeb style

I like the understated ease of Ryan Reynolds and the timeless tailoring sensibility of **Jon Hamm**. Neither looks overly styled and both dress with confidence and comfort.

Clothes cringe

Definitely the long cargo shorts, oversized bermudas and capri phase from the early 2000s.

– As told to glynda.alves@timesofindia.com

“We have no need of other worlds. We need mirrors. We don’t know what to do with other worlds.” – STANISŁAW LEM

ETPanachepersonal

MUMBAI, FRIDAY, 18 SEPTEMBER 2026 03

Gerrit De Vynck, Jeremy B Merrill

Millions are sharing personal information and private thoughts with AI as they integrate apps like ChatGPT more intimately into their lives than they did with previous generations of technology. Many talk to AI apps as they might a close friend or therapist, turning to them for emotional support and incorporating advice into their own lives and thinking.

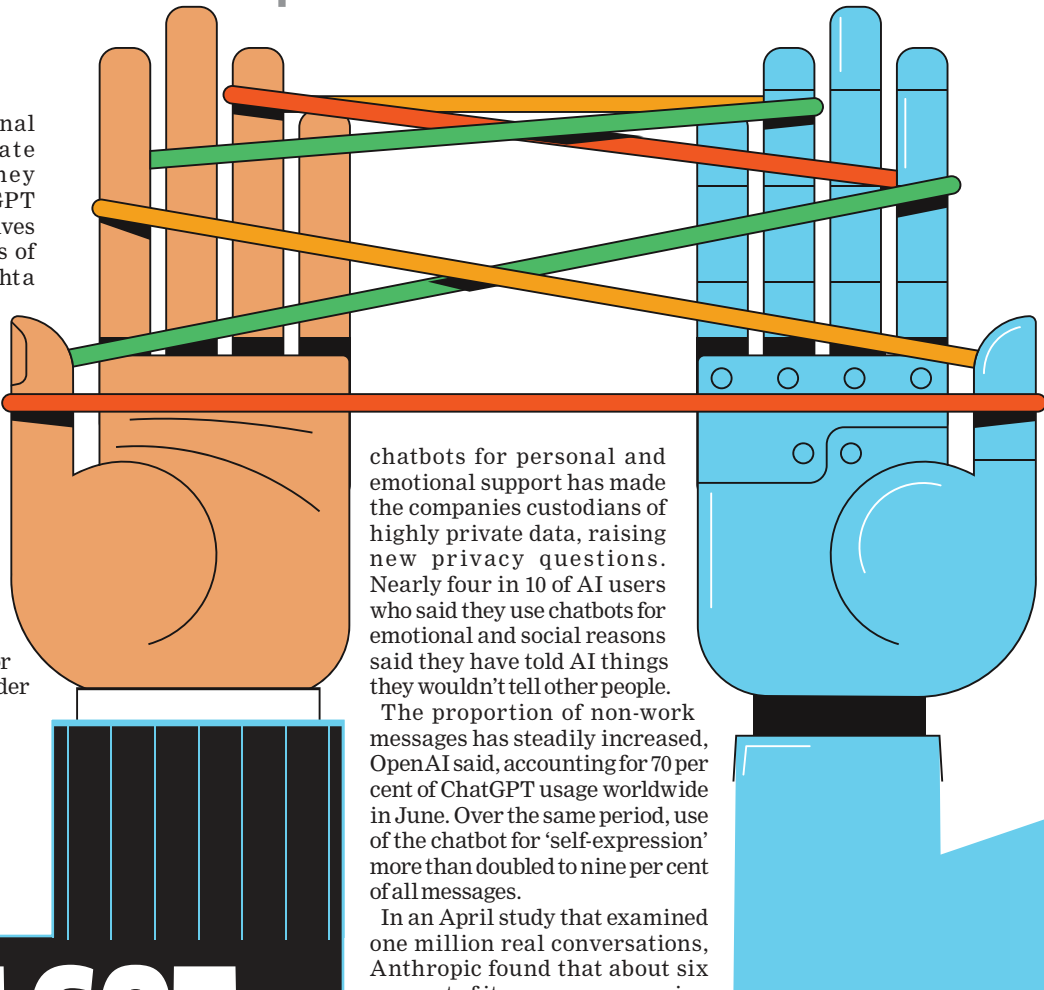
By the numbers

According to a new poll from researchers at Elon University, US, and *The Washington Post*, 27 per cent of Americans turn to AI chatbots like OpenAI’s ChatGPT or Google’s Gemini with personal, emotional or social queries. That category included seeking entertainment, relationship advice, romantic chats or connection when alone. Among the people who said they used chatbots for personal or emotional queries or discussions, nearly a third said they consider

Recent surveys show that more people turn to chatbots for advice and companionship

THEY’VE GOT A FRIEND IN AI

the chatbot they use most often to be a friend while a little more than half of them did not. Jessica Dai, a PhD student in computer science at the University of California at Berkeley, US, published a study in June based on three years of conversations about AI on the social forum Reddit. People initially posted basic questions about how to use AI after the launch of ChatGPT but posts for what Dai calls “emotional engagement” increased steadily over time. When asked to describe their relationship with AI, respondents to the Elon University survey said that it provided companionship they couldn’t get from another person. The popularity of AI



chatbots for personal and emotional support has made the companies custodians of highly private data, raising new privacy questions. Nearly four in 10 of AI users who said they use chatbots for emotional and social reasons said they have told AI things they wouldn’t tell other people. The proportion of non-work messages has steadily increased, OpenAI said, accounting for 70 per cent of ChatGPT usage worldwide in June. Over the same period, use of the chatbot for ‘self-expression’ more than doubled to nine per cent of all messages. In an April study that examined one million real conversations, Anthropic found that about six per cent of its users were coming to Claude for ‘personal guidance’. Most were asking for help with health and career issues while about 12 per cent were looking for relationship advice.

Dependency risks

Some of the heaviest Claude users were also the most sceptical of AI, according to Deep Ganguli, who leads Anthropic’s social impacts team. “The same individual who is using Claude for day-to-day work is concerned about Claude’s impact on the economy,” he said. Major AI companies including OpenAI and Google have been accused in court of betraying the trust of some heavy users of their chatbots. Families of people who developed delusional ideas or harmed themselves or others after long AI chats allege in ongoing

lawsuits that the companies designed their products to be compelling or addictive without proper regard for safety. A recent study by the non-profit Translucent found that AI models from top providers are less likely to encourage discussions of suicide but still sometimes reinforce delusional behaviour. In the Elon University survey, over one-third of respondents who said they regularly used AI for personal and emotional chats reported that chatbots agreed with them too much. 15 per cent said the bots make them feel less in touch with reality. At the same time, nearly 60 per cent of those users said chatbots were very or moderately helpful at helping them make personal decisions. Dai said that in her study, she saw many people engage emotionally with chatbots in ways that were positive. They included getting AI help to process upsetting social interactions or getting advice on connecting with a parent they have a difficult relationship with, she said.

– The Washington Post

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Big-ticket concert scams

Want to see your favourite artiste live? Here are some tips to avoid online fraudsters

Based on their experience of hosting Taylor Swift, the management team at the Paris venue for **Celine Dion**’s grand concert comeback last week was bracing to deliver devastating news to hundreds of fans: “Sorry, your tickets are fake.” The Grammy-winning star’s long-awaited return was the perfect storm for scammers who set up fraudulent ticketing websites. Avoid the traps through these methods:

Check your sources

The Plenitude Arena, France, says the highest risk of scams is when tickets first go on sale and in the shows’ immediate build-up. Generally, just four to eight per cent of people who buy tickets for the arena end up not wanting them. The only way to buy safely is on sites authorised for resale. Group-IB, a cybersecurity

firm, says it had found an array of fraudulent websites that impersonated official platforms. Some URLs were close to the real thing, like celineidion.co (instead of celineidion.com), ticketmaster-celineidion.fr (instead of ticketmaster.fr) or axs-billetterie.com (instead of axs.com). “It’s a constant battle,” Céline Trioux, the arena’s marketing director, added. “It’s impossible to close them all because technology is advancing faster than legal authorities can act.” Group-IB says fraudsters appear to have reused tools that were also deployed to target Oasis fans when the Britpop band reunited for a tour in 2025 and the 2023-2024 Eras tour.

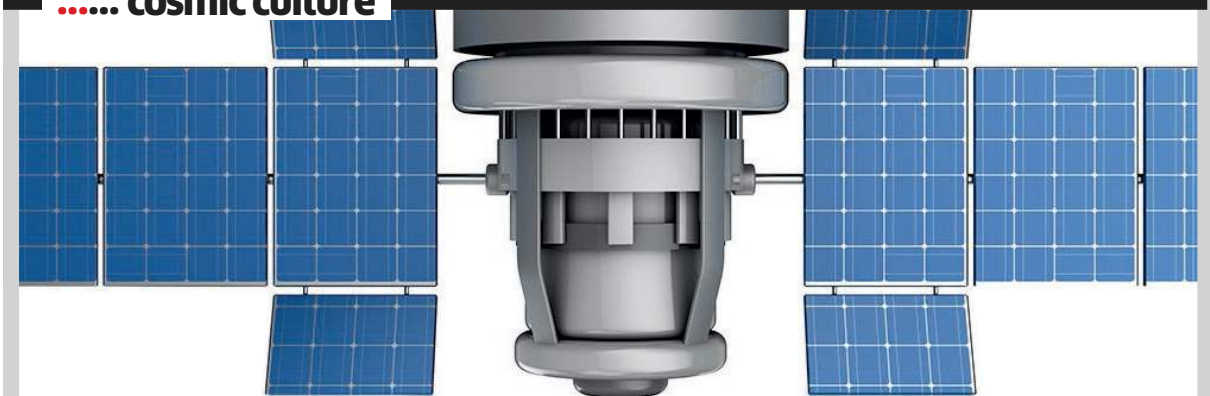
– AP



PICT: GETTY IMAGES



cosmic culture



The confirmation of microbial life that originated off Earth — more akin to *Project Hail Mary* than intelligent aliens — would be a paradigm-shifting event. Thinking about what these consequences might look like early on can help the international community prepare.

Scope for microbes

Multiple Mars landers have identified large amounts of frozen and liquid water, essential for life. Asteroid samples retrieved by Japan’s Hayabusa2 spacecraft revealed the presence of uracil, part of RNA. NASA’s Europa Clipper, the European Space Agency’s Jupiter Icy Moons Explorer, data from the James Webb Space Telescope and future missions targeting Saturn’s moon Enceladus increase the likelihood of discovering extraterrestrial microbial life.

The Outer Space Treaty, established in 1967, dictates that countries should use outer space peacefully and that no nation may claim ownership of celestial bodies. However, it doesn’t have much to say about who can own extraterrestrial organisms or biosecurity risks.

Potential outcomes

While the space race of the 1950s and ’60s led to exploration of the Moon, it led to a renewed sense of Cold War nationalism. On the other hand, astronomers built a global asteroid detection network for potential existential threats, showing that they can put aside terrestrial rivalries to work together. There are three main possible outcomes to the discovery of microbial extraterrestrial life.

TERMS OF ENGAGEMENT

Many space missions are searching for life beyond Earth – but are we prepared for the fallout if they succeed?

First, there’s a cooperative outcome where nations collaborate to regulate research, share data and protect the planet.

Second, there’s a competitive outcome. Nations could fight to be technologically superior, monopolise access or leverage

discoveries for economic or military advantages.

Third is an isolationist outcome, in which states sever international cooperation due to biosecurity concerns or political distrust.

Additional factors

The increasing role of private companies, such as SpaceX, complicates this dynamic. For example, around 60 per cent of all satellites currently orbiting the Earth belong to SpaceX’s Starlink subsidiary. The company can — and has — chosen to block access selectively in alignment with political priorities. Biopiracy may also come into play. The term applies to two main issues: The patenting of indigenous knowledge or the patenting of natural resources, such as microbes, for profit. The Budapest Treaty prohibits claiming ownership of a naturally occurring microbe on Earth, but there’s no equivalent for space.

Advances in artificial intelligence, machine learning, nanotechnology and life sciences could allow researchers to study, modify or exploit extraterrestrial microbes. The politicisation of discoveries and misinformation could further complicate how countries respond. Rather than attempting to predict a singular outcome, policymakers could adopt scenario-based planning approaches, similar to professional wargaming or path games. The question is not whether humanity will discover life beyond Earth, but whether it is prepared for the consequences when it does.

– AP



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“When the going gets weird, the weird turn pro.” – HUNTER S THOMPSON

ETPanachemelange

MUMBAI, FRIDAY, 18 SEPTEMBER 2026 04

Noah White

On New Year’s Eve, as the clock struck 12, Jeff McCarragher was on commentary duty. What sport takes place at an hour like that? The American Cornball League does. “I could be spending time with my family,” McCarragher recalled thinking. But then, that wasn’t even his weirdest gig.

In the dead of the night, after the last baseball pitch is done and before the morning’s scheduled programming can begin, a different realm of activity fills the sports channel void. Think bubblegum blowing, MS Excel championships, and the most insomnia curing of them all: Cornhole.

“This is actually a valuable job,” McCarragher said. “We’re doing something people cherish, even if they don’t know it. And, truthfully, this is the way the system works. If you want to be [on baseball] or whatever one day, you take what you can get. Sometimes, that means spending your weekends watching air guitar championships.”

Space fillers

These low-viewership offerings have long been a proving ground for aspiring broadcasters. Weird hours, weirder sports and low pay are the norm, but it provides irrefutable and valuable hope.

These offbeat sports gigs have only been around for a few decades. And they’ve only truly reached the mainstream in the past decade. “Whoever thought of broadcasting this,” McCarragher said, “must have been off his rocker.”

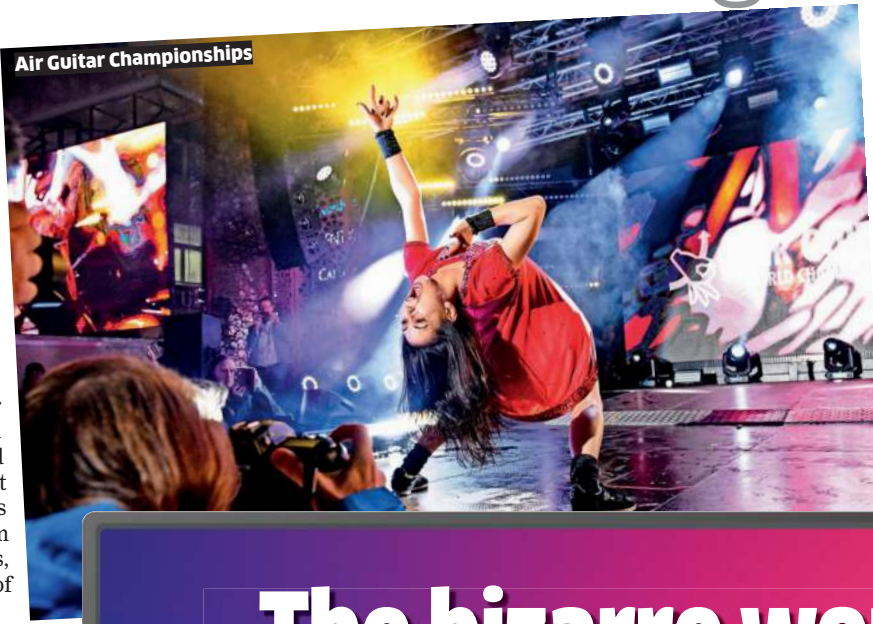
In 1980, *ESPN* started operating a continuous 24-hour broadcasting schedule. The only problem? No mainstream sports held competitions in the middle of the night.

Instead of taped reruns, *ESPN* started picking up alternative sports. Kickboxing, bowling, Australian-rules football lent way to softball and, gradually, even more niche presentations. “People love those things,” said Tom Cavanaugh, vice-president of production at Tupelo

Raycom, which produces some of these shows for *ESPN*. “The audience was never going to be massive, but it was unique.”

Pandemic push

When Covid pushed everybody indoors, it was cornhole’s time to shine. “We were already naturally social distancing,” McCarragher said. “So, it made sense [for cornhole] to be back



on air first. We ended up getting four hours on *ESPN* every weekend that summer. It was a boon.”

With nothing else to watch, sports fans became attached to the mind-numbing sounds of cornhole championships. Soon, these sports weren’t niche anymore. *CBS* bought rights to Fishing Championship—catching big fish in the sea—in 2022. *Fox Sports* amped up its bowling content.

The voice of weird

All the networks needed now were commentators to keep people entertained while also explaining the quirks of these sports. Frank Mazzella is the king of this world. Mazzella is the voice of pizza acrobatics, Rubik’s Cube championships, mullet contests. “I’m always amazed by how much people enjoy this,” Mazzella said. “It gave me a career.”

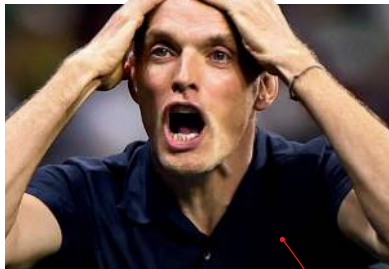
What keeps the likes of Mazzella and McCarragher motivated? Being on commentary while the elite athletes of the land engage in cow-chip tossing (throwing of bovine faeces) or bubblegum blowing, all in the dead of the night, can zap the life out of one. Yet, those like Bob Egan, now a cow-chip expert; Tim Heng, an Excel wizard; and Mazzella who “knows everything”, survived. For McCarragher, it was worth a shot.

Despite his nerves, his first broadcast went well enough, and before he knew it, it’s been seven years. A few seasons ago, he earned a call for the US Air Guitar Championships. He told the manager he needed to think about it. The time away, added to an already oozing schedule, would surely weigh on his family. He had never even heard of ‘air guitar’. Studying its rules alone would pin him in his bedroom-office for a few nights.

Yet, he couldn’t tame the urge. “Like being a starving actor,” he said. “You never want to say no.”

So, he sat down at his desk, opened his laptop and asked: What is air guitar? Over the next few hours, he watched videos of costumed, hyper-energetic performers and their rabid supporters. “They’re a good crowd,” he finally said at 2 am. “This might be fun.”

– The Washington Post



Tuchel wishes he ate grass at Azteca

England head coach **Thomas Tuchel** has said he regrets not eating the grass at Mexico City’s famed Azteca Stadium, after his side’s round-of-16 win over the hosts in the FIFA World Cup earlier this year.

England beat Mexico 3-2 in a tense yet exciting game, their defiant display the standout moment of a World Cup that ended in the semi-final for them.

Tuchel said the performance created a bond between the players. The German was so delighted that he considered taking a bite out of the Azteca turf. “I texted a friend after the match [that] I regret I didn’t eat some grass after the match to keep something from this in my body forever. That was the feeling. That was the moment,” he said recently.

“This game had so much of what you could wish for,” Tuchel added. “If you needed any proof of what it meant to these players and how they were with each other, it was the moment when Jordan [Henderson] fell over and broke his arm. Within a second, the players were there. Every single player was there stopping the celebrations, building a shield, protecting Jordan

— not going nowhere, in full empathy. It was just so special.”

“It created a huge bond. It feels like they are my players now. This is the beauty of it,” he added.

– AFP



Robbie’s abandoned robot spooks village

When Robbie Williams’s band Take That performed a set at London’s Wembley Stadium in 2011, they decked out their stage with a 60-foot mechanical robot.

Once they packed up, the robot travelled with Williams to his mansion in Wiltshire, about 90 minutes outside London. Just a few months later, however, Williams left the country and moved to California, US. The robot clearly stayed back.

Today, it’s still there and spooking the locals who may not know about the lone resident of the 71-acre property. “Something caught my eye. So, I stopped the car and there he was — this giant humanoid sitting among the trees, looking down at the field,” says Kristina Bowen, who spotted it while driving.

Om, the robot

Standing over 100 feet when fully erect, the robot, nicknamed ‘Om’, was designed to lower band members to the stage.



“I had to turn around and go back to see what I’d seen. It must be as big as a house. It caught me completely off guard, but I was intrigued. I thought someone had built a Wicker Man,” says another resident, Sarah Spencer.

“It’s such a perfect location — it just seems to emerge from nowhere. Then, as you drive alongside it, it seems to withdraw back into the foliage,” says another neighbour, Liz Neve.

– Daily Mirror



In the AI of the storm

The biggest names from the worlds of business and technology were in San Francisco, US, for a conference this week. As the industry grapples with concerns surrounding artificial intelligence, attendees at the conference spoke of ways and means of dealing with the change that’s coming.

1. Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei; 2. Salesforce CEO Marc Benioff with Nvidia’s CEO Jensen Huang; 3. Sam Altman, CEO, OpenAI; 4. Siemens president Roland Busch



A three-star Michelin restaurant where the menu follows the rain

Climate change has reached fine dining: At Tuju, a three-Michelin-star restaurant in São Paulo, Brazil, erratic rainfall keeps the owners on their toes.

What gets prepared in the kitchen depends not only on seasonality, but also on the vagaries of the weather. In a region where summer storms run riot and reservoirs still run dry in the winter, it takes “a lot of flexibility”, said Katherina Cordas, who runs a gastronomic research centre created specifically for the restaurant.

Instead of fixed items, Tuju offers four menus a year — Humidity, Rain, Gale and Drought. But they aren’t tied to fixed dates; instead they follow the specific rain patterns of the day.

For instance, “São Paulo is usually dry in July, but this year it stayed wetter, so mushroom season lasted twice as long. You always have to stay alert and adapt,” said chef Ivan Ralston.



‘Black belt’

Tuju won its third Michelin star this year, what Ralston said is the “black belt for karate practitioners”. But he insists the accolade has not gone to his head: “The pursuit of perfection is superficial,” he said.

He is more frustrated by the fact that some diners come mainly looking for social media content. “Eating is a moment to pay attention to details. Stop working on the marketing of living and enjoy life a little more!”

The evening begins with cocktails beneath a towering *jabuticaba* tree, native to Brazil. It ends on a rooftop terrace with sweeping views, with a taste of chocolates and honey from native stingless bees.

– AFP

::::: sunk cost

Welcome to Miami, super yacht graveyard

Buying a luxury boat in Florida isn’t the same as being able to afford its maintenance

Miami’s **Biscayne Bay** is packed with glittering yachts of the billionaires who call the city home. But there are also smaller boats abandoned by people who realised — the hard way — that they can’t afford to own a yacht.

Since October, Miami Beach



police have removed about 140 vessels that were left to rot. Even more sit anchored across the bay, some having partially submerged due to prolonged inactivity. “A lot of people buy a boat but don’t realise how much it costs for fuel, maintenance and marina fees,” said Javier Fernandez, commander of the Miami Beach police marine unit.

The abandoned vessels range from sailboats, cabin cruisers and pontoon craft to centre-console fishing boats, bow riders and even a 60-foot custom-rigged catamaran.

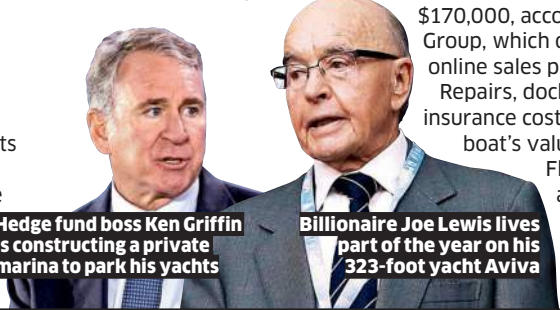
The marine graveyard is one downside of an influx of well-to-do newcomers to Miami. With wealth flooding into the city, boats have gotten bigger, driving up costs for things like marina space and maintenance. There were roughly 1.2 million registered boats in Florida in 2024.

Dangerous passions

Derelict vessels are not just a nuisance, they may even break free of rotting lines and crash into the bulkheads near the seaside mansions around Biscayne Bay. Leaking fuel can also pose environmental threats.

There were 6.4 deaths per 1,00,000 registered boats in Florida in 2024, roughly 50 per cent higher than the national rate, according to data from the US Coast Guard.

As billionaires bought



Hedge fund boss Ken Griffin is constructing a private marina to park his yachts

Billionaire Joe Lewis lives part of the year on his 323-foot yacht Aviva

properties in Miami’s most exclusive enclaves, the cost of living soared more than 36 per cent in six years. Those forces have also put pressure on boaters — and some just give up.

Expensive hobby

Buying a vessel and keeping it seaworthy is expensive. Boats under 26 feet long — the most popular class of boats in south Florida — sold for an average of \$60,000 last year, while 26- to 35-foot boats averaged \$170,000, according to Boats Group, which owns several online sales platforms.

Repairs, docking, fuel and insurance cost 10 per cent of a boat’s value. In south Florida, slips cost about \$25 to \$55 a month; new engines can run to \$30,000 or

more. With Miami marine mechanics in high demand, even something as simple as a tune-up can cost hundreds of dollars.

Marinas make more money from large boats, and many are being revamped to take in larger craft. But long-time locals are not happy. “This is a war against working people by rich people who bought a condo for a view of the marina, but now they complain about the marina,” said Jessica Londono, co-owner of a charter operator. “They are trying to put us out of business [but] we were here first.”

Standing on the docks, she said the marina’s shift away from charters and smaller vessels is transforming boating — long an egalitarian pursuit in Miami — into the domain of the wealthy. “The rich,” she said, “are really putting the squeeze on us.”

– Bloomberg

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